

Leaders change DP to honour Operation Sindoor heroes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Following a call by Prime Minister Narendra Modi to change display pictures on social media as a mark of respect to the armed forces for their success during Operation Sindoor, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, her cabinet ministers, the BJP's MPs and MLAs changed the display pictures (DP) on their social media handles on the first anniversary.

They hailed the valour of the armed forces on the first anniversary of Operation

Sindoor and for emphatically responding to the Pahalgam terror attack.

Sandhu on X said, "We mark the 1st anniversary of #OperationSindoor—a defining moment in Bharat's strategic resolve and national determination." He paid tributes to the "immortal valour" of the armed forces for responding to the Pahalgam attack with "exemplary courage, precision, and unwavering commitment" to the nation.

"India remains vigilant, united, and steadfast against every threat to its sovereign-

ty and security. A grateful nation salutes the courage, sacrifice, and unwavering devotion of our bravehearts," he said.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta lauded the courage, valour and gallantry of the armed forces on the first anniversary of Operation Sindoor. In response to the Pahalgam terror attack, India launched Operation Sindoor on May 7 last year, carrying out airstrikes on nine terror hubs in Pakistan and Pakistan-occupied Kashmir, eliminating at least 100 terrorists. "Countless salutations to the indomitable



courage, valour, and gallantry of the Indian Army on the first anniversary of Operation Sindoor," the chief minister said in a post on X.

"On the first anniversary of 'Operation Sindoor', Minister Kapil Mishra says, "Our armed

forces' bravery has been witnessed by the entire world...Terrorism had been portrayed in such a way that even those who used to demand proof in India are now praising the army. Salute to the courage of the Indian

Army. The entire world has seen that India will not provoke anyone, but if someone provokes us, we will not spare them either," Delhi Culture Minister Kapil Mishra said in his tweet.

Delhi Cabinet Minister Ashish Sood in his post said, "Operation Sindoor, which began on 7 May, has now completed one year today. This initiative reflects our strong leadership, swift decision-making, and unwavering commitment to the nation's security."

Delhi PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, in a tweet, said,

"On the first anniversary of 'Operation Sindoor,' crores and crores of salutations to the indomitable valour of the Indian Army. On May 7, 2025, the Indian Air Force, by entering their homes and eliminating the patrons of terrorism based in Pakistan and the murderers of innocent Indians in Pahalgam, made it clear that the new India responds to terrorism with decisive action. 'Operation Sindoor' is a proud symbol of the Indian Army's valour, courage, and the spirit of placing national interest above all. Under the leadership of the illustrious

Prime Minister Shri @narendramodi ji, today India is capable and determined to take every necessary step for its security, sovereignty, and the protection of its citizens."

The military operation was carried out by the three defence forces along with the BSF along the western border, targeting terrorist and military facilities in Pakistan and Pakistan-occupied Kashmir from May 7-10 last year. This operation was carried out in retaliation for the April 22, 2025, terror attack in Pahalgam in which 26 people, mostly tourists, were killed.

DDA hands over appointment letters to 1,647 newly recruited officers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) on Thursday handed appointment letters to 1,647 newly recruited officers and staff in its largest recruitment drive so far, marking a major expansion of the agency responsible for planning and developing the national Capital.

The appointments were made during a "Niyukti Samaroh" attended by Delhi Lieutenant Governor and DDA Chairman Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu. Senior DDA officials, family members of recruits and other guests were also present at the programme.

The fresh recruitment will increase DDA's workforce by nearly 55 per cent. The authority currently has



around 3,000 employees.

The new recruits will now join different wings of the authority and are expected to support DDA's expanding role in urban planning, housing, environmental restoration and infrastructure development across the Capital.

Officials said the new appointments are expected to strengthen DDA's administrative and operational capacity at a time when the agency is handling large-

scale housing, infrastructure, environmental and heritage projects across Delhi.

Addressing the gathering, Lieutenant Governor Sandhu said the newly appointed employees were becoming part of a larger vision for the transformation of the national capital. He said Delhi occupies a special position as the country's capital and governance standards are expected to remain high.

"You are not just joining a public institution. You are

becoming part of the long-term development framework of Delhi," he said. Sandhu also stressed the importance of transparency and merit in public recruitment. He said the selection process reflected institutional integrity and would help strengthen governance in line with the vision of a developed India.

The recruitment drive covered 26 different posts across technical, engineering, administrative, planning, horticulture and support services departments. The largest number of appointments were made for multi-tasking staff positions, where 745 candidates were selected. The DDA also recruited 278 malis, 147 junior secretariats assistants, 104 junior engineers in the civil category, 79 patwaris and 75 sectional

officers in horticulture.

Other appointments included junior engineers in electrical and mechanical streams, planning assistants, assistant directors, assistant executive engineers, legal assistants, programmers, surveyors and translators.

Officials said the expansion in manpower became necessary because of several large projects undertaken by DDA in recent years. These include development work in Narela, Dwarka and Rohini, large-scale housing projects, environmental restoration initiatives and heritage conservation programmes.

The authority has been actively involved in rejuvenation projects along the Yamuna floodplains through initiatives such as Baansera, Asita and Vasudev Ghat.

Newly renovated, modernised Nehru Place Post Office inaugurated

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Minister for Communications Jyotiraditya Scindia and Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta jointly inaugurated the newly renovated and modernised Nehru Place Post Office.

Addressing the gathering, Scindia said that India Post is one of the country's most trusted institutions and continues to play a critical role in financial inclusion, service delivery and national connectivity.

Referring to the vital role of the postal network, he said that just as arteries carrying blood sustain the human body, the Department of Posts serves and connects every corner of the nation through



its unmatched network and dedicated workforce, including the Dakiyas, who remain deeply connected with every household.

The Union Minister emphasised that legacy institutions must evolve with changing times and highlighted the department's efforts to modernise infrastructure, strengthen logistics capabilities and improve customer-centric services and experi-

ence. He stated that the renovated post office reflects the department's commitment towards creating bright, efficient, digitally enabled and citizen-friendly public service spaces.

He informed that the department has invested nearly ₹5,000 crore in modernising its IT infrastructure and has rolled out advanced postal technology over the past year.

Public Notice / General Information

The general public is hereby informed that my client is lawfully purchasing the below-described land/property/agricultural land from 1. Sh. Brijmohan Baisoya-Sh. Rahul Kumar Baisoya both Ss/o Rohtash Singh R/o Morna, Sector-35, Gautam Budh Nagar, Noida, UP-201301, 2. Sh. Ripul Singhal, S/o Sh. Rajesh Kumar Singhal, R/o M-8/D2 Ground Floor, Jhulelal Apartments, Pitam Pura, Delhi-110034, 3. Mrs. Vineeta Chaudhary W/o Sh. Deepak Chaudhary, R/o D-58, Block D, South Extension Part-1, Andrewsganj, Delhi-110049, 4. Sh. Ramvir Singh S/o Sh. Kishan Lal, R/o H. No. T-151, Street No -2, Near David School, Tukmir Pur, Krawal Nagar, Delhi-110094, 5. Mrs. Taru Bai W/o Sh. Daleep Singh, R/o Village Jhuppa, Nagalia (197), Post Office Mohna, District Palwal, Haryana-121004 ("Seller").

Mrs. Brijmohan Baisoya & Sh. Rahul Kumar Baisoya, Sh. Ripul Singhal are having share in the land as details hereunder in Khewat/Khata No.104min/155min, Rect. No. 10, Killa No.17, 24, situated at Village Jhuppa, Tehsil Palwal, District Palwal, Haryana, as per Fard Jamabandi for the year 2019-2020.

Mrs. Vineeta Chaudhary, Sh. Ramvir Singh are having share in the land as details hereunder in Khewat/Khata No.39/59, Rect. No. 14, Killa No. 9/2, 12, 19, 20, 21, Rect. No. 15, Killa No. 24/2, 25/1, situated at Village Jhuppa, Tehsil Palwal, District Palwal, Haryana, as per Jamabandi for the year 2019-2020.

Mrs. Taru Bai having share in the land as details hereunder in Khewat/Khata No.73/123 Rect. No.24, Killa No.5/2, Rect. No.25, Killa No.1/2, situated at Village Jhuppa, Tehsil Palwal, District Palwal, Haryana, as per Jamabandi for the year 2019-2020. The above said person have agreed to sell their entire respect shares in the aforesaid Khewat(s)/Khantoni(s) to my Client (hereinafter collective share of all is referred as "Scheduled Property/Land").

The said purchase is being undertaken by my Client with due care, proper due diligence, by issuing this public notice, so as to ascertain and invite disclosure of any hidden claims, rights, or disputes, if any, relating to the said Scheduled Property/Land.

The Seller has declared that the said Scheduled Property/Land is completely free from all kinds of encumbrances including but not limited to charges, mortgages, loans, claims, disputes, litigations, attachments, stay orders, ceiling proceedings, acquisition, surplus land, government dues, or any third-party rights or claims whatsoever, and that the title of the Scheduled Property/Land is clear, clean, and marketable. The Seller has further represented and warranted that the Seller has clear, valid, absolute, and marketable right, title, interest and ownership and is in actual, vacant, peaceful physical and legal possession of the said Scheduled Property/Land and that no prior, existing, or subsisting agreement, transaction, understanding, or arrangement of any nature whatsoever, whether oral or written, in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land has been entered into with any third party in respect thereof. It has also been declared that no case, proceeding, or dispute in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land is pending before any court, tribunal, or any competent legal or quasi-legal authority/forum.

Therefore, any person, bank, financial institution, government department, or any other party, firm, company, or entity, who has or claims to have any valid, legal, or equitable right, title, interest, claim, demand, charge, or encumbrance of any nature whatsoever in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land—whether by way of sale, gift, lease, tenancy, license, exchange, partition, mortgage, lien, inheritance, succession, agreement, litigation, decree, stay order, possession, or otherwise—shall intimate the undersigned in writing, along with full particulars of such claim/objection and supporting documentary evidence, within fifteen (15) days from the date of publication of this notice.

In case no information or objection is received within the stipulated period, it shall be conclusively and lawfully presumed that there exists no encumbrances including but not limited to third-party claim, right, or dispute etc. in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land, and my client shall be free to proceed with and complete the proposed sale transaction with the Seller and shall be legally deemed to have clear, valid, absolute, and marketable right, title, interest and ownership therein along with actual, vacant, peaceful physical and legal possession thereon, entitling my Client to lawfully proceed with and complete the proposed sale transaction of the Scheduled Property/Land with the Seller. Thereafter, any such claim, objection, or dispute shall be treated as legally untenable, deemed to have been waived, and my client shall not be held liable for the same in any civil or criminal proceedings before any court, tribunal, or any competent legal or quasi-legal authority/forum.

The Scheduled Property/Land shall be deemed to include all rights, easements, pathways, appurtenances, standing crops, trees, plants, constructions, fences, boundary walls, etc. attached thereto.

The general public is hereby cautioned not to deal or enter into any transaction concerning the Schedule Property/Land with any person, party, or entity, failing which such transaction shall be at their own cost, risk and consequences.

This public notice is issued on behalf of my Client with complete bona-fide, transparency, and good faith,so as to safeguard my client against any future allegations of fraud, misrepresentation, or collusion or any other allegations whatsoever in relation to the Schedule property. This notice is being issued without prejudice to any of the legal rights, contentions and remedies available to my client under applicable law.

Durga Lal - Advocate, Law Consultant Office,
Office No. 57 Nehru Ground Near Main Post Office,
B.K. Chowk, NIT Faridabad, Haryana. ENROL. No. PH/5563/2022
Mobile No.7303834091, Email- lawconsultantsoffice@gmail.com

Public Notice / General Information

The general public is hereby informed that my client is lawfully purchasing the below-described land/property/agricultural land from 1. Sh. Rahul Chaudhary S/o Sh. Dhiraj Singh, R/o C-9/7, C-9 Block, Yamuna Vihar, Garhi Mendu, Shajan Pura, Delhi-110053, 2. Smt. Vidaya W/o Sh. Dhan Singh, R/o Village Bhanakpur, District Faridabad, Haryana-121004, 3. Sh. Dinesh Garg, S/o Sh. Shyamali Garg, R/o Village 13, Shyam Enclave, Karkardooma, Delhi-110092, 4. Sh. Prem Chand Gupta S/o Sh. Sis Ram Gupta, R/o A-26, Rama Road, Near Adarsh Nagar Metro Station, Adarsh Nagar, Delhi-110033, 5. Sh. Rahul Gupta S/o Sh. Shiv Dhan Gupta, R/o H. No. 134, Parking Floor, Block -D, Prashant Vihar, Rohini, Delhi-110085, 6. Sh. Vinod S/o Sh. Ragbir R/o Village Bai, Ganaur, District-Sonapat, Haryana-131101, 7. Sh. Nitin Kumar Singhal, S/o Sh. Bimal Kumar Singhal, resident of A-1/106, Sector-8, Rohini, Delhi-110085 ("Seller").

Sh. Rahul Chaudhary, Smt. Vidaya, Sh. Dinesh Garg, Sh. Prem Chand Gupta, Sh. Rahul Gupta, Sh. Vinod, Sh. Nitin Kumar Singhal are having share in the land as details hereunder in Khewat/Khata No. 95/146, Rect. No. 10, Killa No. 19, 20/1 and Khewat/Khata No. 97/148, Rect. No. 10, Killa No. 11, 12/2, 20/2 and Khewat/Khata No. 98/149, Rect. No. 9, Killa No. 16 and Khewat/Khata No. 99/150, Rect. No. 9, Killa No. 25/1, Rect. No. 10, Killa No. 21/1 and Khewat/Khata No. 100/151, Rect. No. 10, Killa No. 21/2, 22, Rect. No. 14, Killa No. 2, 3/1, 8/2, 9/1, 13/1, situated at Village Jhuppa, Tehsil Palwal, District Palwal, Haryana, as per Fard Jamabandi for the year 2019-2020. The above said person have agreed to sell their entire respect shares in the aforesaid Khewat(s)/Khantoni(s) to my Client (hereinafter collective share of all is referred as "Scheduled Property/Land").

The said purchase is being undertaken by my Client with due care, proper due diligence, by issuing this public notice, so as to ascertain and invite disclosure of any hidden claims, rights, or disputes, if any, relating to the said Scheduled Property/Land.

The Seller has declared that the said Scheduled Property/Land is completely free from all kinds of encumbrances including but not limited to charges, mortgages, loans, claims, disputes, litigations, attachments, stay orders, ceiling proceedings, acquisition, surplus land, government dues, or any third-party rights or claims whatsoever, and that the title of the Scheduled Property/Land is clear, clean, and marketable. The Seller has further represented and warranted that the Seller has clear, valid, absolute, and marketable right, title, interest and ownership and is in actual, vacant, peaceful physical and legal possession of the said Scheduled Property/Land and that no prior, existing, or subsisting agreement, transaction, understanding, or arrangement of any nature whatsoever, whether oral or written, in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land has been entered into with any third party in respect thereof. It has also been declared that no case, proceeding, or dispute in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land is pending before any court, tribunal, or any competent legal or quasi-legal authority/forum.

Therefore, any person, bank, financial institution, government department, or any other party, firm, company, or entity, who has or claims to have any valid, legal, or equitable right, title, interest, claim, demand, charge, or encumbrance of any nature whatsoever in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land—whether by way of sale, gift, lease, tenancy, license, exchange, partition, mortgage, lien, inheritance, succession, agreement, litigation, decree, stay order, possession, or otherwise—shall intimate the undersigned in writing, along with full particulars of such claim/objection and supporting documentary evidence, within fifteen (15) days from the date of publication of this notice.

In case no information or objection is received within the stipulated period, it shall be conclusively and lawfully presumed that there exists no encumbrances including but not limited to third-party claim, right, or dispute etc. in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land, and my client shall be free to proceed with and complete the proposed sale transaction with the Seller and shall be legally deemed to have clear, valid, absolute, and marketable right, title, interest and ownership therein along with actual, vacant, peaceful physical and legal possession thereon, entitling my Client to lawfully proceed with and complete the proposed sale transaction of the Scheduled Property/Land with the Seller. Thereafter, any such claim, objection, or dispute shall be treated as legally untenable, deemed to have been waived, and my client shall not be held liable for the same in any civil or criminal proceedings before any court, tribunal, or any competent legal or quasi-legal authority/forum.

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Mobile No.7303834091, Email- lawconsultantsoffice@gmail.com

Public Notice / General Information

The general public is hereby informed that my client is lawfully purchasing the below-described land/property/agricultural land from 1. Yogesh Goel (HUF) S/o Sh. Suresh Kumar, Office address of C-26A, Rajan Babu Road, Near Syndicate Bank, Adarsh Nagar, Delhi-110033, 2. Sh. Yogesh Goel S/o Sh. Suresh Kumar, R/o C-26A, Rajan Babu Road, Near Syndicate Bank, Adarsh Nagar, Delhi-110033 3. Sh. Sumit Bansal S/o Sh. Suresh Chand Bansal, R/o H. No. D-48, Lord Krishna Road, Adarsh Nagar, Azadpur, Delhi-110033, 4. Sh. Sunil Kumar S/o Sh. Vinod Bansal, R/o Village Bai, Ganaur, District Sonipat, Haryana-131101, 5. Sh. Suresh Chand Bansal S/o of Sh. Ragbir Singh, R/o H. No. D-48, Lord Krishna Road, Adarsh Nagar, Azadpur, Delhi-110033 ("Seller").

Yogesh Goel (HUF), Sh. Yogesh Goel, Sh. Sumit Bansal, Sh. Sunil Kumar, Sh. Suresh Chand Bansal are having share in the land as details hereunder in Khewat/Khata No.104min/155min, Rect. No. 10, Killa No. 16, 18, 23, 25 Rect. No. 14, Killa No. 4, situated at Village Jhuppa, Tehsil Palwal, District Palwal, Haryana, as per Fard Jamabandi for the year 2019-2020. The above said person have agreed to sell their entire respect shares in the aforesaid Khewat(s)/Khantoni(s) to my Client (hereinafter collective share of all is referred as "Scheduled Property/Land").

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NORTHERN RAILWAY

Invitation of Tenders through E-Procurement system

Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-

S. No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
01	08260025	GREEN ASPECT LED SIGNAL LIGHTING	2184 NOS	03-06-26
02	08261529	STEEL WIRE ROPE	577400 MTR	09-06-26
03	08260024	YELLOW ASPECT LED SIGNAL LIGHTING	3462 NOS	09-06-26
04	07260246	FLEXBALL CABLE -SHORT WITH END CONNECTION	183 NOS	16-06-26
05	02261299	MEASURING MONITORING RELAY (HT MMR)	1061 NOS	29-06-26

NOTE -1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details. 2. No Manual offer will be entertained.

Tender Notice NO. 10/2026-2027 Dated : 07.05.2026 1526/2026



SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

PUBLIC NOTICE

Whereas, M/s. SUPER MAX AFFORDABLE HOUSING PVT. LTD., is undertaking for setting up of a Commercial plotted colony namely "SUPERMAX AVENUE 35" falling in the revenue estate of village Rathdhana Sector-35, Tehsil Sonapat on over an area measuring 3.693 acres under the terms and conditions of Licence No. 226 of 2025 dated 17.11.2025 valid up to 16.11.2030 licenses granted by the office of Director Town and Country Planning, Haryana, Chandigarh.

Whereas, M/s. SUPER MAX AFFORDABLE HOUSING PVT. LTD. has been issued Certificate of Registration by the Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority, Panchkula of the project "SUPERMAX AVENUE 35" over the measuring 3.693 acres of the Registration no. HRERA-PKL-SNP-894-2026 dated 24.04.2026 valid up to 30.11.2030

Whereas the Company is required to declare its bank account details, hence the same are hereby informed for perusal/reference of the allottees/General Public.

The Company hereby declares the following bank accounts of the project namely " SUPERMAX AVENUE 35 " in the revenue estate of the village Rathdhana, Sector-35, Tehsil Sonipat.

HEAD OF BANK ACCOUNT	BANK ACCOUNT NAME	ACCOUNT NUMBER
100% Ration Account	Super Max Affordable Housing Pvt. Ltd Master A/c Supermax Avenue 35	44703923138
70% RERA Account	Super Max Affordable Housing Pvt. Ltd RERA ESCROW A/c Supermax Avenue 35	44687935037
30% Promoter Account	Super Max Affordable Housing Pvt. Ltd Designated A/c Supermax Avenue 35	44706355105

Bank Name : - State Bank of India
Branch Address :-Rai Industrial Area Branch, Sonipat, Haryana-131029
IFSC Code :- SBIN0016087

(Anil Kumar Garg) Director
For SUPER MAX AFFORDABLE HOUSING PVT. LTD.
CIN No. U70200DL2015PTC281147
Place: Sonipat
REGD. OFFICE: E15/120 "1" Floor Sector-8, Rohini, Delhi-110085

PUBLIC NOTICE

General Public at large is hereby informed that Mr. Jawahar Singh, son of Shri Paras Ram Yadav, resident of House No. 1401, Block K, Palam Vihar, Sector 1, Gurugram is proceeding to sell following TDR certificates to our client:-

i. TDR Certificate bearing Nos. 01-419 of 29/2026 carrying a face value of 50 Sq. Mtr. each with an FAR of 2.0 out of 01-627 of 29/2026 dated 27th April 2026 granted against land bearing Rect. No. 25, Killa no. 20/1 (2-9), 21/1/1(3-15) situated in village Gopalpur, Sub Tehsil Harsaru, District Gurugram.

In case any person, Company, Firm, Bank, Financial Institution, statutory authority, Society and/or any other entity have got any interest, claim, demand, right or title of any nature pertaining to the above mentioned TDR Certificates or land parcels against which the same have been issued or any part thereof including but not limited to by way of sale, exchange, Will, treaty, gift, lease/tenancy, licence, assignment, mortgage, hypothecation, charge, lien, encumbrance, trust, family settlement/arrangement, inheritance, bequest, easement, exchange, possession, maintenance, development rights, joint venture, partnership, order/decreed/judgment of any court, MOU or through any other document with respect to the ownership rights and possession of the aforesaid owner in respect of the same, in that event the same be intimated in writing to us by Speed Post at the address indicated hereinafter or by way of email along with supporting documents within a period of 10 days from the date of publication of this notice failing which our client shall presume that the Said TDR Certificates and land parcels against which the same have been issued are free from all encumbrances/charges/third party claims and shall proceed to transact on the same from the Owner indicated above. In case no claim is lodged within the period stipulated above, the same shall be presumed to be willful waiver of the claim which might be held by any person/third party in respect of the Said TDR Certificates and land parcels against which the same have been issued.

Jagmohan Krishan Dang & Ishaan Dang
Advocates
R/o K-140, South City-I, Gurugram- 122001(HR).
Email: mailbox@ishaandang.com
Mob. 9871011115

Govt approves construction of medical college in Dwarka

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Giving a major push to healthcare and medical education infrastructure in the national Capital, the Delhi Government has approved the construction of a modern medical college and hostel complex at the Indira Gandhi Hospital campus in Dwarka, costing about ₹805.99 crore, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said on Thursday.

The ambitious project received clearance at a recent meeting of the Expenditure Finance Committee (EFC), chaired by the Chief Minister.

The Government aims to complete the project by 2028.

Rekha Gupta said the project will include a full-fledged medical college, separate hostels for male and female students, faculty housing and a modern academic block. The initiative is expected to address the growing demand for doctors in the capital while significantly strengthening healthcare services in Delhi.

The medical college will be developed in accordance with National Medical Commission (NMC) norms and will eventually accommodate 250 MBBS seats every year. Teaching activities will begin with an initial batch of 150 students.

The chief minister said the

project would be executed in phases. The first phase will focus on the construction of the academic block, student hostels and residential quarters for faculty members.

Around 1,17,246 square metres of area will be developed in this phase, including nearly 34,000 square metres of basement space for parking and other essential facilities.

The academic block will be a multi-storey structure equipped with modern classrooms, laboratories and advanced teaching facilities. The hostels will be designed to accommodate a large number of students, while faculty residences will offer



modern and comfortable living spaces.

The Public Works Department (PWD) will carry out the construction work, while the Health and Family Welfare Department will oversee the project.

campus will feature solar power systems, rainwater harvesting, water recycling mechanisms, ample natural lighting and proper ventilation. The entire campus will be made fully accessible for persons with disabilities, with ramps, lifts, Braille signage and wheelchair-friendly pathways. Modern safety systems, including CCTV surveillance, fire alarms and fire safety infrastructure, will also be installed across the campus.

Rekha Gupta directed officials to strictly adhere to quality standards and project timelines. She said a robust quality assurance mechanism would be put in place and regular monitoring

would be carried out to ensure timely completion. She also made it clear that unnecessary delays and cost overruns would not be tolerated. The Chief Minister further said that procurement of equipment, recruitment of staff, university affiliation and other operational requirements for the medical college would be completed in later stages in line with NMC norms.

Calling the project a long-term investment in Delhi's healthcare future, Rekha Gupta said the initiative was not just about building another medical college, but about strengthening the city's overall healthcare system.

She said the government's goal is to ensure better and accessible healthcare for every resident of the capital, and increasing the number of trained doctors is crucial to achieving that objective.

The chief minister expressed confidence that once operational, the institution would benefit not only Delhi residents but also people from neighbouring regions seeking quality medical treatment.

Reaffirming the government's commitment to quality medical education, Rekha Gupta said the new institution would play a key role in producing skilled doctors for the future.

Govt to tackle Yamuna froth at Kalindi Kunj barrage

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government is working on a long-term strategy to address the problem of white froth in the Yamuna River at the Kalindi Kunj barrage and revamp the area, officials said on Thursday.

Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh recently visited the site along with experts from IIT-Roorkee and officials of the Delhi Jal Board (DJB), where long-term measures to tackle the issue were discussed.

"The slope at the Kalindi Kunj barrage is one of the major factors behind froth formation. A study will be carried out by IIT Roorkee to find a solution to this, whether the slope can be redesigned to reduce its height," Singh said.

According to the Government's plan, dhobi



ghats and cloth-dyeing units located near the barrage are contributing untreated surfactant-laden water to the river.

"A relocation policy is being planned for these dhobi ghats away from the river. Also, there will be stricter monitoring of cloth-dyeing units to ensure compliance with water pollution norms," the minister said.

Singh added that the Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board (DUSIB) and the Delhi Pollution

Control Committee (DPCC) would be directed to jointly work on the relocation and enforcement plans.

"The reason foam is formed is mainly because of the presence of surfactants like phosphates in the effluents flowing into the river. When the surfactant-contaminated water falls down from the barrage height, it produces foam, which accumulates and floats on the water surface," an official said. As part of the pro-

posed revamp, the Delhi government also plans to build a new Chhath Ghat near the barrage at an estimated cost of Rs 100 crore.

"A large Chhath Ghat will be developed and implemented by the UP Irrigation Department. We will give funds for the project," the minister said.

Froth formation in the Yamuna is a recurring problem, particularly during winter, and often turns into a major political and environmental issue. Every year, devotees visiting Kalindi Kunj for Chhath Puja are seen offering prayers and taking dips in the river amid thick layers of foam.

The Kalindi Kunj barrage remains under the control of the Uttar Pradesh Irrigation Department. As a temporary measure, the DJB sprinkles a de-foaming agent on the white foam to suppress it.

Govt likely to receive ₹7,000 cr funds from Centre for roads, Yamuna cleaning

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi is expected to receive central funds to the tune of ₹7,000 crore in the current fiscal for works in priority areas, including road and infrastructure development and Yamuna cleaning, officials said on Thursday.

Proposals worth ₹1,000 crore — especially for Public Works Department and Delhi Jal Board (DJB) projects — have been sent for the Centre's approval, they said.

According to Delhi government data, it is estimated that ₹591 crore from Central Road Funds, ₹1,500 crore under the National Mission for Clean Ganga, and another ₹100 crore for strengthening disaster management apparatus in the capital will be received from the Centre.

Further, the Delhi govern-



ment is expected to receive ₹3,931.16 crore for centrally sponsored schemes (CSS).

The total grant from the Centre in 2026-27 is estimated at over ₹7,000 crore, around 34 per cent higher than the revised estimates for 2026-27, a senior government official said. The revised figures show that the central grants in 2025-26 remained 56 per cent lower than the budget estimates for the year.

Notably, out of ₹6,000 crore from the Centre for capital projects, no receipts

were reported at the revised estimate stage, data showed.

Delhi was expected to receive ₹1,000 crore in 2025-26 from the Central Road Fund, which was revised to ₹212.43 crore. However, no sum was received, the data showed. In the case of CSS, the budget estimates for 2025-26 were ₹4,127.82 crore, which were revised to ₹2,207.84 crore.

The actuals stood at ₹1,202.59 crore, just 54.47 per cent of the revised estimates, according to the figure.

DPA urges Govt to intervene in school fee refund matter

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Parents Association (DPA) has urged Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Education Minister Ashish Sood to intervene in the long-pending school fee refund matter linked to the recommendations of the Justice Anil Dev Singh Committee, claiming dues of over ₹1,317 crore.

In a memorandum submitted to the Delhi Government on Thursday, the association sought disclosure of all schools liable for refunds and requested strong representation before the Delhi High Court, which is scheduled to hear the matter on May 8.

The Justice Anil Dev Singh Committee was constituted to examine alleged unjustified fee hikes by private unaided schools in the national Capital and had identified several schools for the refund of excess fees collected from parents.

According to the association, a public list of around 531 schools covered under the committee's recommendations was released in 2016, but the committee is understood to have continued functioning till around April 2020.

The DPA alleged that the publicly available list may not represent the complete and final list of schools covered under the committee's work.

It claimed that nearly 230 schools had challenged the committee's findings before courts, while around 300 schools may still remain liable for refunds without having challenged the recommendations.

The association also raised concerns that some schools may fall outside both the publicly available list and the known list of schools that approached courts, creating ambiguity over the total number of refund-liable schools and the overall refund amount.

Citing public reports that estimated the refund liability at around ₹750 crore in 2019, the DPA claimed that with nine per cent simple annual interest, the amount may have crossed ₹1,317 crore by 2026.

Police bust interstate racket involved in illicit pharmaceuticals trade

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police has arrested four persons allegedly linked with an interstate racket involved in the manufacture, relabelling and distribution of spurious prescription drugs, unearthing an illegal processing and repackaging unit in north-west Delhi's Mukherjee Nagar area.

Police said the illicit operations allegedly involved diversion of medicines meant for government hospitals in Uttar Pradesh, removal of original labels and identifying marks, and their illegal sale in Delhi-NCR and northeastern states after repackaging.

The arrestees include the alleged kingpin Manoj Kumar Jain (56), a resident of Mukherjee Nagar; Raju Kumar Mishra (57) from Panchkula in Haryana; Vikram Singh alias Sunny (32) and Vatan (35), both residents from Prayagraj.

According to police, counterfeiters of several life-saving medicines, including rabies vaccines, snake venom antiserum, insulin, human albumin and Hepatitis-B vaccines, were being circulated by the syndicate, posing a serious threat to public



health. "A team of the crime branch had been constituted on April 22 to gather intelligence regarding the illegal trade of spurious and government-supplied medicines in Delhi," Deputy Commissioner of Police (Crime) Pankaj Kumar said in a statement.

During the operation, police received specific information that an organised gang was collecting medicines supplied to government hospitals, removing their original packaging and relabelling them for commercial sale in Delhi-NCR and northeastern states.

Acting on the input, the team coordinated with the drugs control department of the Delhi government and conducted a raid at a premises in Indra Vikas Colony in Mukherjee Nagar.

Drug inspectors from the drugs control department

and the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) also participated in the raid.

"During the search, the team apprehended Manoj Kumar Jain from the premises and recovered a huge quantity of branded medicines, government supply drugs, suspected counterfeit medicines, packaging and labelling material and machinery allegedly used in illegal manufacturing and relabelling," the officer said.

Police said the recovery indicated the existence of a well-organised network engaged in large-scale illicit production and circulation of spurious pharmaceutical products. A case was registered under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Drugs and Cosmetics Act at the Crime Branch police station on April 23.

Mandoli jail inmate stabbed by fellow prisoners

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 41-year-old inmate lodged in Mandoli jail in northeast Delhi was allegedly stabbed by fellow prisoners inside the prison premises, prompting police to register a case and launch an investigation into the assault, officials said on Thursday.

The incident came to light after Harsh Vihar police received information from GTB Hospital regarding the admission of an injured inmate from Mandoli jail on May 6. During the inquiry, the



injured prisoner was identified as Javed, son of Kamsuddin, who is currently lodged in Mandoli jail in connection with narcotics case registered at Seemapuri police station under the NDPS Act.

Police said preliminary

investigation revealed that Javed was allegedly attacked by other inmates inside the jail complex during the evening hours.

He sustained stab injuries in the assault and was immediately shifted to GTB Hospital for treatment. After receiving medical care, the inmate was discharged from the hospital, officials said.

A case under Section 118(1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, related to voluntarily causing hurt using dangerous weapons or means, has been registered at Harsh Vihar police station. Police

said they are trying to ascertain the sequence of events that led to the attack and identify the inmates involved in the stabbing.

Investigators are also examining whether the assault was linked to any previous rivalry or dispute inside the jail. Officials said statements are being recorded and assistance is being sought from jail authorities as part of the probe.

The incident has once again raised concerns over violence and security lapses inside prisons in the national capital.

Delhi records highest value of stolen property among Union Territories in 2024: NCRB

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi recorded the highest value of stolen property among all Union Territories in 2024, even as the national capital saw a marginal improvement in its recovery rate compared to the previous year, according to the latest National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) data.

The NCRB's 'Crime in India 2024' report showed that property worth Rs 671.4 crore was reported stolen in

Delhi in 2024, while property worth ₹105.0 crore was recovered, resulting in the recovery rate of 15.6 per cent.

In 2023, property worth ₹688.6 crore was reported stolen in the national capital, of which ₹99.7 crore was recovered, taking the recovery rate to 14.5 per cent.

The data also showed that in 2022, Delhi recorded property theft worth ₹624.1 crore, while recoveries stood at ₹106.3 crore, trans-

lating into a recovery rate of 17 per cent.

Among the Union Territories, Delhi accounted for the largest share of the total value of stolen property as well as recoveries in 2024, the report stated.

The NCRB data showed that across all Union Territories, property worth ₹750.9 crore was reported stolen in 2024, of which property worth ₹130.1 crore was recovered, resulting in a recovery rate of 17.3 per cent.

Under this category, stolen property generally refers to items taken through offences such as theft, snatching, burglary, robbery, dacoity and other property-related crimes.

The category includes a wide range of valuables and assets, including motor vehicles, motorcycles, scooters, light motor vehicles, three-wheelers, electronic gadgets, mobile phones, cash, jewellery, cycles, cattle and several other miscellaneous items.

Carriers of Mahabharata tales face uncertain future: Eviction notices to Yamuna Bazar residents

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

It has been more than 200 years of continuity — of smoke from funeral pyres rising above the Nigambodh Ghat, priests performing aartis, and families making the river their very own. That timeless link threatens to snap, perhaps forever, with eviction notices being served to those living in Yamuna Bazar. It could be over in just 15 days, said the residents.

That's the time the Delhi Disaster Management Authority (DDMA) has given the families in Yamuna Bazar in north Delhi's Kashmere Gate area to vacate the settlement voluntarily, failing which demolition action would be undertaken to clear the "encroachment".

A total of 26 notices have been served to individuals found occupying the site.

The notices direct them to vacate the area within 15 days from the date of issuance and immediately under all circumstances.

The fear is not only of losing their homes but also of watching an entire riverbank culture, inherited across centuries, disappear. Several families living along the Yamuna said they have spent generations carrying forward traditions tied to the river, from cremation rituals to preserving stories they say date back to the Mahabharata era.

Officials said notices were served earlier this week to 310 dwellings along the Yamuna floodplains in the O-Zone area designated as protected no-construction land under the Delhi Development Authority (DDA).

They cited recurring flooding as a threat to human life and property. For many residents, it is the cruellest blow.

"An illegal encroachment in the form a residential cluster having approximately 310 dwellings at Yamuna Bazar within the wall along the banks of Yamuna in the O-Zone comprising floodplain land owned by DDA is in existence," the DDMA notice said. "The same (Yamuna Bazar) is being inundated during Yamuna floods every year, thereby posing a serious threat to the loss of human life, cattle and property," it added.

The O-Zone along the Yamuna is designated as a protected, no-construction floodplain which is under the management of the Delhi Development Authority (DDA).

The action comes a week after Delhi Lt Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu chaired a detailed review with DDA officials on the progress of rejuvenation works in the



Yamuna Bazar area, following a visit to the area along with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta last month.

According to Delhi government official, there are 32 ghats in the Yamuna Bazaar ghat area. These ghats have been encroached upon over time. Around 310 residential structures currently exist in the area, housing nearly 1,100 people. The floodplain stretch of the Yamuna Bazaar ghats,

located along the Yamuna River within the walled area of Yamuna Bazaar, falls under the O-Zone category. The land belongs to the DDA, and all construction activity in the area is strictly prohibited. The NGT has directed the DDA to take necessary action regarding encroachments on the Yamuna floodplains.

"My family has been living here for nearly 200 years now, and we even have maps

and records proving our presence here for over a century. What we heard from our ancestors is that these ghats were once divided caste-wise and families had their traditional roles connected to the Yamuna," said Sunil Sharma, a priest at Nigambodh Ghat near Yamuna Bazar.

Sharma said his family stayed near the ghats as priests, performing Yamuna 'aarti', conducting cremations at Nigambodh Ghat and carrying out rituals connected to the river.

"This is not just a place for us, it is our and the city's heritage," he said.

Sharma, who is also associated with the Yamuna Ghat Panda Association, said nearly 60 families with histories stretching back in time remain connected to the area. Generations of priests, workers, boatmen and caretakers gradually settled

around the river while serving pilgrims, cremation grounds and temple activities.

"Our fathers and grandfathers taught us the religious and cultural importance of this place. We learned priesthood here, and now we are passing the same traditions to our children.

"This is how most families here earn their livelihoods. The river is not separate from our lives, it is at the centre of our existence," Sharma said.

Surender, a 47-year-old resident and lifeguard in the area, said his family's connection to the Yamuna goes back generations.

"Our ancestors used to tell us that our family had been staying here since the time of Akbar, and we have proof showing our presence here for at least 150 years. My father became known across the country because he

swam from Delhi to Mathura, something no one else could do at the time," he said.

"About 200 years ago, our ancestors came as priests and settled in the area, and since then, we have been residing here. Even today, people are doing the same jobs, though some have gone into the corporate world to earn more money," added another resident.

Residents also said locals often help prevent suicides and drownings near the river.

Surender said his family's expertise in swimming and rescue work came entirely from growing up alongside the Yamuna.

"Whatever we learned about swimming, survival and rescuing people, we learned from the river itself. My grandfather learned it, then my father, then I learned it and now my children are learning it too.

IN FOCUS



A Citrine wagtail at a wetland on the outskirts of Pobitora Wildlife Sanctuary, in Assam on Thursday

PTI

Fatwa politics replaced by *Vikas* in UP: CM Yogi

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Saharanpur

Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath on Thursday said the state had moved away from the politics of "appeasement" and "fatwas" to a model focused on public welfare, while attacking previous governments for allegedly encouraging communal and caste-based politics.

Addressing a programme in Saharanpur after laying the foundation stones of 325 development projects worth ₹2,131 crore, Adityanath said western UP had undergone a major



transformation. "Earlier, government funds were spent on cemetery boundary walls, illegal encroachments and caste-communal appeasement. Today, the same money is being used for roads, universities, sports colleges, RCC drains, expressways and the development of religious and tourism sites," the CM said.

Professional killers suspected in murder...

Rath was returning home from Kolkata in a white Mahindra Scorpio SUV around 10.30 pm when a car, later identified with a tampered registration, suddenly blocked the road. Motorcycle-borne assailants, arriving on at least four bikes, opened fire from both sides at point-blank range. Rath, seated in the front passenger seat, was hit by at least three bullets, two piercing his heart and one in the abdomen. His companion, Buddhadeb Bera, sustained critical injuries to the chest, abdomen and leg. Approximately 10 rounds were fired in total. Rath was rushed to a private nursing home but was declared dead on arrival.

The forensic team recovered spent cartridges and shattered glass from the SUV at the crime scene. An SIT headed by the Inspector-General of CID, with officers from the Intelligence Branch and the Bengal STF, has been constituted. The car has been seized, and CCTV footage is under scrutiny. No arrests have been made.

His death, BJP leaders allege, was no random act of post-poll rage but a targeted message to Suvenud Adhikari. Adhikari described Rath's killing as "cold-blooded and pre-planned", claiming the assailants conducted reconnaissance for "two to three days" and monitored movements closely. "This is the result of 15 years of <Maha-Jungle Raj>[>]," he told reporters, vowing "cleansing work" while urging cadre restraint. Union Minister Sukanta Majumdar assured the family of justice. Senior BJP leaders framed it as a "targeted political assassination" aimed at demoralising the incoming administration.

As the SIT probe intensifies, examining political links, criminal syndicates, and possible revenge for Adhikari's Bhabanipur triumph, the new BJP Government faces an immediate test. Security has been ramped up in vulnerable districts, yet the cycle of violence, familiar from 2011, 2016, and 2021 and now 2026, persists.

Military chiefs draw new red line on terror

"In an era of prolonged conflicts around the world, we struck hard, achieved clearly defined objectives and then decided to cease hostilities when the Pakistanis were compelled to negotiate and requested us to stop," he said.

"The objectives were achieved through a calibrated shot and sharp shock that altered the enemy's risk appetite and disrupted his command and control without locking India into a long-drawn war or conflict," he added.

In his remarks, Air Marshal A K Bharti, who too played a crucial role as Director General of Air Operations in implementation of Operation Sindoor, highlighted the "primacy of air power" in achieving desired results.

"We struck and decimated their nine terrorist camps. The proof is there for everybody to see. We struck 11 of their airfields. We destroyed 13 of their aircraft either on the ground or in the air, including one high-value airborne asset at a record distance of more than 300 kilometres," he said. Bharti is currently serving as Deputy Chief of the IAF.

"They (Pakistan) have not been able to inflict any major damage on our side; neither any military infrastructure nor much of the civilian structures," he said.

"Whatever they may say, remember narratives and rhetoric do not give you victory. Victory is measured by hard facts," he added.

Director General of Naval Operations Vice

Customs seizes marijuana worth nearly ₹9 crore at Delhi airport

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ New Delhi

Customs officers at Delhi's Indira Gandhi International Airport have arrested two Indian passengers for allegedly smuggling suspected marijuana worth nearly ₹9 crore from Vietnam, officials said on Thursday.

The passengers arrived from Vietnam on May 5 and were intercepted at the Green Channel "on the basis of profiling", an official statement said.

"During the search, a total



of 17 packets of assorted ready-to-eat snacks containing green-coloured narcotic substance suspected to be

ganja/marijuana were recovered from one black and one green trolley bag," the statement said.

NIA files chargesheet against 3 in alleged ISIS-linked bio-terror plot

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Ahmedabad

The National Investigation Agency has filed a detailed chargesheet before a special NIA court against three accused, including a doctor allegedly linked to the banned terror outfit Islamic State, in connection with an alleged bio-terror conspiracy involving the planned use of ricin poison for a mass-casualty attack.

The chargesheet names Hyderabad-based doctor Syed Ahmed Mohiuddin Abdulqader Jilani, along with Azad Suleman Saifi and Mohammad Suhail (Mohammad Salim Khan), as key accused in the case. Investigators have also submitted documentary evidence, technical material and other supporting records before the court.

According to the investi-



gation agency, the accused were allegedly involved in a conspiracy to produce ricin - a highly toxic biological substance derived from castor seeds - with the alleged intention of carrying out a large-scale terror attack. The NIA has claimed that the main accused, Dr Mohiuddin, who reportedly studied medicine in China, had allegedly converted his Hyderabad residence into a covert laboratory for preparing toxic substances. Investigators further alleged that foreign-based ISIS han-

dlers radicalised him and encouraged him to play a larger operational role in South Asia.

The agency has also accused the other two suspects of assisting in logistics, illegal arms procurement, mobilisation of funds and recruitment of radicalised youth for the alleged conspiracy. Officials stated that accused were allegedly planning to use ricin, described as an extremely dangerous toxin naturally found in castor beans, in a potential terror strike.

Bihar Govt approves 110 acres for CISF training centre

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Patna

Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Thursday announced that the state government has approved 110 acres of land in Kishanganj district for the establishment of a Regional Training Centre (RTC) of the CISF.

The approved land lies in the Pothia circle of Kishanganj district. "In an important decision aimed at continuously strengthening the security system of Bihar and the country, approval has been granted for the proposal to provide 110 acres of land in the Pothia circle of Kishanganj district to the Centre for establishing an RTC of the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF)," he wrote on X.

MLAs authorises Kharge to pick next Kerala CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Thiruvananthapuram

With three names in the contention for the Chief Minister's post in Kerala for the next party-led Government, the Congress Legislature Party (CLP) on Thursday passed a resolution authorising Congress President Mallikarjun Kharge to decide on the CM pick. The resolution was moved by KPCC president Sunny Joseph during the CLP meeting held here in the presence of AICC observers Mukul Wasnik and Ajay Maken.

At present, senior Congress leaders VD Satheesan, Ramesh Chennithala and AICC general secretary KC Venugopal are being considered for the top post.

According to party sources, the resolution was unanimously adopted by the newly elected MLAs and senior party leaders. The Congress, which won 63 seats in the 2026 Assembly elections, convened the



meeting at Indira Bhavan here amid intense discussions over the party's chief ministerial choice.

Following the adoption of the resolution, the AICC observers began individual meetings with MLAs to seek their views on the leadership issue. Earlier in the day, Wasnik and Maken held discussions with senior leaders, including VM Sudheeran, K Sudhakaran, Ramesh Chennithala and V D Satheesan.

The observers are expected to submit a report to the party high command on Friday, which will take the final decision on who will be the Chief Minister of Kerala. The observers also met with UDF ally party leaders.

Adani Group may settle US SEC case outside court

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Ahmedabad

The legal proceedings initiated by United States market regulator against billionaire industrialist Gautam Adani and his nephew Sagar Adani may move toward an out-of-court settlement, according to reports citing legal and policy sources familiar with the matter.

The case, originally filed in

November 2024 by the U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission, relates to allegations linked to bribery and fraud in connection with securing power-related contracts. Reports indicate that discussions between the regulator and the Adani Group have entered an advanced stage and a formal settlement framework could be announced later this month.

FROM PAGE - 1

A second bag was reportedly picked up by a man in a white vehicle who fled the scene. ED officials quickly cordoned off the area and recovered the cash. The flat is linked to one Nitin Gohal, an IT professional now under the agency's scanner.

ED sources claimed that Gohal acted as a key facilitator, helping defaulting builders evade regulatory action by arranging 'political protection'. Officials have identified him as a close associate of Rajbir Singh Ghuman, Officer on Special Duty (OSD) to Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann. Searches were also conducted at premises connected to Gohal and his relatives, including one named Veer Davinder, according to opposition claims.

Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann, addressing the media during his 'Shukrana Yatra' in Amritsar, firmly distanced his government from the operation. "We have no relation with these raids. The ED officials have come to raid the company of someone there and are doing their work," he said, describing the matter as related to old accounts and private business dealings between individuals.

The denial did little to douse the political fire. Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) leader Bikram Singh Majithia took to X, accusing the AAP government of shielding 'kattar fraudsters', Crores of money, 500 notes flying in the air. Money belongs to whom, OSD CM Mann Rajbir Singh. ED raids on CM Bhagwant Mann's close aide, OSD Rajbir Ghuman's close aides and relatives Nitin, Veer Davinder," Majithia posted in Punjabi, describing the cash-throwing incident as evidence of a larger hawala racket. Congress leader and Leader of Opposition Partap Singh Bajwa also highlighted the proximity of the raids to the Chief Minister's office.

GMADA, responsible for planned growth around Chandigarh, has previously faced allegations of lax oversight in CLU approvals. Developers allegedly diverted investor funds meant for project development while failing to pay dues, leaving buyers in limbo and the authority out of pocket. The ED is now tracing the proceeds of crime, including alleged hawala transactions routed through middlemen for political cover.

This is not the first time central agencies have acted against politically connected figures in Punjab. Over the past few weeks, the ED has intensified probes into several cases involving real estate and alleged corruption. With the state slated for assembly polls in early 2027, the timing has sharpened accusations of a witch-hunt by the Centre against the AAP-led government.

Iran reviews US peace deal amidst Trump...

Meanwhile, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio discussed peace efforts in the Middle East at the Vatican. Rubio met with Pope Leo XIV, whose opposition to the Iran war has led to open sparing with Trump. Trump posted on social media Wednesday that ending the war and resuming oil and natural gas shipments disrupted by the conflict depends on Iran accepting an agreement, which he did not detail.

"If they don't agree, the bombing starts," Trump wrote.

A fragile ceasefire between the US and Iran has largely held since April 8. But in-person talks between the two countries hosted by Pakistan last month failed to reach an agreement. The war began February 28, when the US and Israel launched strikes against Iran.

"We expect an agreement sooner rather than later," Pakistani Foreign Ministry spokesperson

Tahir Andrabi said Thursday. "We hope the parties will reach a peaceful and sustainable solution that will contribute not only to peace in our region but to international peace as well."

But he declined to give a timeline, saying Pakistan would not disclose details of the ongoing diplomatic efforts.

Asked whether Pakistan was expecting any response from Iran later Thursday, Andrabi said: "I will not comment on specifics or the movement of the messages."

Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, speaking in televised remarks, said Islamabad remained in "continuous contact with Iran and the United States, day and night, to stop the war and extend the ceasefire."

From prison walls to wedding vows: An...

The marriage has generated considerable discussion because the bride is a serving prison officer while the groom is a former inmate who had once been lodged in the same jail. The unusual nature of the relationship has sparked mixed reactions, ranging from admiration and support to criticism and disbelief.

Several social organisations and local activists present at the ceremony congratulated the couple and extended their support. Supporters described the marriage as a reflection of personal freedom and mutual trust, while critics questioned the appropriateness of such relationships involving prison officials and inmates.

People close to the development said the officer had earlier faced resistance and criticism over her decision, but remained firm and chose to marry publicly. The incident has now become one of the most talked-about developments in the region, triggering wider conversations on interfaith relationships, individual choice, and social acceptance in contemporary society.

Tamil Nadu hangs in limbo

Congress announced a State-wide protest against the Governor and the BJP regime at the Centre over the issue on Friday. "Governments are not decided on the lawns of Lok Bhavan. They are decided on the floor of the House," said Congress. TVK cadres staged a protest demonstration outside the Lok Bhavan on Thursday, demanding that the governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar should allow the party chief Vijay to form the Government.

Meanwhile, DMK leaders said party president and outgoing Chief Minister MK Stalin conveyed his wish — in a meeting — to the leaders of alliance parties including the Left that they should continue to be part of the Secular Progressive Alliance. On the AIADMK front, MLAs of the party were lodged in a resort in neighbouring Pudukcherry.

CPI(M) general secretary M A Baby called upon Arlekar to uphold democratic conventions by inviting the TVK to form the Government as it was the single largest party in a fractured Assembly. Speaking on the political impasse in Tamil Nadu, the CPI (M) top leader argued that in the absence of a clear majority or a pre-poll alliance reaching the magic number, constitutional precedent dictates that the leader of the largest party be sworn in. He cited the 1996 invitation to BJP stalwart Atal Bihari Vajpayee as a historical parallel. "The Governor's office should be beyond suspicion," said Baby

Bihar Cabinet expands to 32, including Nishant

"I am overwhelmed by the love and blessings of my family members from Bihar in Patna! I am deeply grateful to all of you from the bottom of my heart for this warm welcome. Your unprecedented enthusiasm clearly shows that our resolve for development and public service is receiving full support from the people," Modi said in Patna congratulating the first BJP CM led cabinet members.

Nishant Kumar, along with leaders from the BJP, JD(U), LJP(R), HAM(S) and Rashtriya Lok Morcha, was sworn in as minister as the NDA Government carried out its first major cabinet reshuffle after sweeping the Bihar Assembly polls.

While Samrat Choudhary held General Administration, Home, Cabinet Secretariat, Vigilance, Civil Aviation and all such departments that have not been allocated to anyone as his portfolios, Deputy CM Vijay Kumar Chaudhary got Water Resources and Parliamentary Affairs.

Deputy CM Bijendra Prasad Yadav was given the important Finance portfolio while Vijay Kumar Sinha got Agriculture and Nishant Kumar's portfolio was Health. His predecessor Mangal Pandey of BJP had served as Health Minister in last Nitish Kumar regime however he did not get any portfolio in Samrat cabinet becoming talk of the political circle in the State.

Altogether 32 leaders, drawn from all constituents of the five-party NDA in the state, were administered the oath of office by Governor Lt Gen (Retd) Syed Ata Hasnain.

BJP, which is the single largest party in the 243-member assembly with 89 MLAs, has 15 ministers, who took oath on Thursday.

JD(U) is represented by a total of 15 ministers, 13 of whom took the oath at the Gandhi Maidan on Thursday. Vijay Kumar Chaudhary and Bijendra Prasad Yadav had taken oath in April along with Samrat Choudhary and were designated as deputy chief ministers.

Sanjay Kumar Singh and Sanjay Kumar Paswan, both from the Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) headed by Union minister Chirag Paswan, are back as ministers, and so are Santosh Kumar Suman and Deepak Prakash, sons of Union minister Jitan Ram Manjhi of the Hindustani Awam Morcha and Upendra Kushwaha of the Rashtriya Lok Morcha, respectively.

Others who made it in the expansion are Leshi Singh with Housing Construction as portfolio and Ram Kripal Yadav as Minister for Cooperation. The list includes Neeloo Mishra as Urban Development & Housing, IT portfolio, Damodar Rawat for Transport, Sanjay Singh Tiger will be the new Higher Education and Law Minister, Ashok Chaudhary has got Food & Consumer Protection, Bhagwan Singh Kushwaha as Planning & Development portfolio, Arun Shankar Prasad will be the new Labour, Employment & Skill Development Minister, Madan Sahni has been allocated the Prohibition, Excise & Registration department, Santosh Kumar Suman as Minor Water Resources portfolio, Ramdeo Prasad Nishad got the SC & EBC Welfare, Pallavi Saha will lead Income Tax, Kumar Dharendra will be the new Minister for Road Construction, Sheela Kumari will head Science, Technology & Technical Education, Kedar Prasad Gupta the Tourism Minister, some prominent names like Shweta Gupta to head Social Welfare, Sanjay Kumar to lead Sugar Industry Ministry and Deepak Prakash will be the new Panchayati Raj Minister.

President, PM hail Operation Sindoor on 1st anniversary of PoK strikes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

President Droupadi Murmu, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh and Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday hailed Operation Sindoor and lauded the armed forces on the occasion of the first anniversary of the punitive military strikes against terror infrastructure in Pakistan and Pakistan-Occupied Kashmir (POK).

Operation Sindoor was carried out by the three Services along with the Border Security Force (BSF) along the western border, targeting terrorist and military facilities in Pakistan and Pakistan-occupied Kashmir from May 7-10, 2025. This operation was carried out in retaliation to the April 22, 2025 terror attack in Pahalgal in which 26 people, mostly tourists, were killed. The military strikes killed more than 100 terrorists in Pakistan and POK.

President Murmu said that Operation Sindoor is a defining testament to India's unwavering resolve against terrorism and the country stands vigilant, united and prepared to respond with strength to those who seek to threaten "Bharat".

"The extraordinary success of this mission reflects the unmatched courage and determination of our armed forces. The brutal attack at Pahalgal was met with befitting and exemplary precision," she said in a social media post.

"Operation Sindoor stands



as a defining testament to India's unwavering resolve against terrorism and all forces that threaten our sovereignty and the safety of our citizens," she said on the military strikes' first anniversary.

Those who seek to threaten Bharat must know that our nation stands vigilant, united, and prepared to respond with strength, the president said. "Today, the nation salutes the indomitable bravery, sacrifice and professionalism of our soldiers," she said.

Prime Minister Modi said Operation Sindoor reflected India's firm response against terrorism and an unwavering commitment to safeguarding the national security.

He said a year later, India remains as steadfast as ever in its resolve to defeat terrorism and destroy its enabling ecosystem.

Modi said a year ago, Indian armed forces displayed unparalleled courage, precision and resolve during the Operation Sindoor.

He said the forces gave a fitting response to those who dared to attack innocent

Indians at Pahalgal and the entire nation salutes the Indian forces for their valour.

"Operation Sindoor reflected India's firm response against terrorism and an unwavering commitment to safeguarding national security. It also highlighted the professionalism, preparedness and coordinated strength of our armed forces," he said in a social media post.

At the same time, Modi said, it showcased the growing jointness among India security forces and underlined the strength that India's quest for self-reliance in the defence sector has brought to the country's national security.

Rajnath Singh said "On the anniversary of Operation Sindoor, we salute the valour and sacrifices of our armed forces, whose courage and dedication continue to safeguard the nation."

"Their actions during the operation reflected unmatched precision, seamless jointness and deep synergy across services, setting a benchmark for

modern military operations," he said.

The defence minister said the operation stands as a "powerful symbol of national resolve and preparedness, showing that our armed forces are always ready to act decisively when it matters most."

"It also stands testament to India's steady advance towards achieving #Atmanirbharta, enhancing capability while reinforcing resilience," he said.

Home Minister Amit Shah in a social media post said "This day will continue to bring the dreadful message to our enemies that no matter where they hide, they cannot escape. They are always within our sight and the fierce wrath of our firepower. On this day, I salute the unparalleled valour of our forces."

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath in a social media post said "Heartfelt congratulations to the people of the country and salute to the brave soldiers of the Indian Army on completion of one year of 'Operation Sindoor', which is a glorious expression of the unity of 145 crore Indians, indomitable will, extraordinary valour of the armed forces and India's clear policy."

"Our brave soldiers' courage, sacrifice and dedication are India's invincible strength. The nation will always remain indebted to them," Adityanath said.

"It is more than just a chapter of history, but inspiration for the future. Jai Hind," he added.



Governors are BJP agents mauling Constitution: Kapil Sibal on TN Govt delay

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Rajya Sabha MP Kapil Sibal on Thursday criticised Tamil Nadu Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar for not inviting Vijay-led TVK to form the Government, alleging that governors are "agents" of the BJP who "maul" the Constitution to serve that party's interests.

Sibal's remarks come amid Vijay's efforts to cobble up support to form his maiden Government after his TVK emerged as the single largest party in the the April 23 assembly polls.

Vijay went to the Lok Bhavan on Thursday for a second time in 24 hours to meet Arlekar in connection with his request to be invited to form the Government with the Congress' support, even as the BJP asserted that the governor will go by the rule book on the matter.

Tamil Nadu Lok Bhavan

said Governor Arlekar explained to TVK chief Vijay that his party does not have requisite support to form the Government.

In a post on social media, Sibal said, "Tamil Nadu... Governors are agents of BJP. They maul the Constitution to serve BJP's interests."

"Call Vijay (leader of single largest party). Swear him in as CM," the Independent Rajya Sabha MP said.

"Let him prove his majority on the floor of the House. No post poll alliance in majority. Sarkaria Commission. Settled law. But who listens!" Sibal said.

The TVK won 108 seats in the 234-member Assembly in the April 23 polls and emerged as the single largest party. Though the Congress, which has five MLAs, has extended support to the TVK, the actor-politician-led party is still short of as many seats to touch the magic number of 118, the majority mark.

Nation Focus



Denying Vijay chance to form TN Govt unfair: Shivakumar

Karnataka Deputy Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on Thursday termed as "unfair" Tamil Nadu Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar not inviting TVK chief Vijay to form the Government in that State, despite emerging as the single largest party. He urged the Governor to allow TVK to form the Government and prove its majority on the floor of the Assembly. "In Tamil Nadu what the Governor is doing is not fair. He should allow the single largest party (TVK) to form the Government and ask them to take the floor test," Shivakumar said.

Addressing reporters here, he said, in 2018, the then Governor invited B S Yediyurappa, leader of the BJP – the single largest party with 104 seats in the 224 member assembly – to form the Government, despite the Congress-JD(S) alliance submitting a letter claiming a majority. However, unable to manage the numbers, Yediyurappa resigned in three days, before facing the floor test. Citing the example of former PM Atal Bihari Vajpayee, Shivakumar recalled that the then President gave him an opportunity to prove a majority on the floor of the Lok Sabha.



GoC reviews security, troop preparedness in Poonch

General Officer Commanding (GOC) of the White Knight Corps, Lieutenant General PK Mishra, on Thursday visited forward areas along the Line of Control (LoC) in Jammu and Kashmir's Poonch and reviewed the prevailing security situation and operational preparedness of troops, officials said. Lt Gen Mishra, accompanied by the GOC of the Ace of Spades Division, visited areas under the Krishna Ghati Brigade to assess the security environment, infrastructure development and readiness of troops deployed along the border, they said.

In a post on X, the White Knight Corps said the Army commander was briefed on operational deployment, surveillance architecture and measures put in place to maintain a "robust counter-infiltration grid" along the LoC. "GOC White Knight Corps alongwith GOC Ace Of Spades Division, visited forward areas along the Line of Control to review the prevailing security situation, infrastructure development and operational preparedness of formations under Krishna Ghati Brigade," the post said.

Rahul's double standards exposed as Congress MLA praises SIR: BJP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Thursday hit out at Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, accusing him of "double standards" after an MLA from his party in Kerala reportedly praised the SIR process for "removing a large number of fake voters".

In a post on social media, BJP spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla said Congress MLA Mathew Kuzhalsadan has "exposed" Gandhi's "lies" on SIR.

"Congress has exposed Congress. Congress's MLA in Kerala has said SIR was very good because it cut out fake voters created by the Left and helped the Congress party. That is why the Congress party does not speak against SIR, the Election Commission or EVMs in Kerala," he said, sharing a video clip of Kuzhalsadan.

In the video shared by Poonawalla, Kuzhalsadan was purportedly heard saying that the "SIR process removed a lot of fake voters in some constituencies at least managed by CPM. So, that also helped us".

Accusing Gandhi of electoral opportunism, Poonawalla said the Congress leader was making "hit-and-run allegations" to provide himself an alibi for his "99th defeat".

"Just look at the opportunism. In Kerala, SIR appears acceptable to them because they won there. In Tamil Nadu too, SIR seems fine. But in Bengal, they want to use it as an excuse. This is Rahul Gandhi's conditional approach to the Constitution, and even his own party



leaders do not take him seriously," he said.

In the April 9 assembly elections, the Congress-led United Democratic Front secured a decisive victory, winning 102 seats in the 140-member House, while the Left Democratic Front won 35 seats. The BJP won three seats.

Poonawalla claimed that anti-incumbency was evident in West Bengal as well and alleged that Gandhi later changed his stand to blame SIR for electoral setbacks.

"In Bengal too, it is evident that there was an anti-incumbency effect. Rahul Gandhi himself had made a video while going to Nicobar. But after that he changed his tune because you need somebody or something to blame in order to save yourself. So, he is blaming SIR in Bengal, but not in Kerala.

"In fact, he is hailing SIR in Kerala. This shows the double standards and opportunism of the Congress party," he said.

He also took a swipe at the Congress leader, saying no one takes him seriously for repeatedly making such claims without providing evidence in court.

UCC, population control need public support; caste politics ends with caste identity: Bhagwat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mysuru (Karnataka)

Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat on Thursday said population control policies and the implementation of a Uniform Civil Code required public cooperation and long-term thinking, and asserted that caste-based politics would disappear only when society stopped identifying with caste divisions.

Addressing an interaction



RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat during a lecture on Social Harmony as a Catalyst for National Development at JSS Mahavidyapeetha in Mysuru PTI

session after delivering a lecture on "Social Harmony as a Catalyst for National Development" at JSS Mahavidyapeetha here, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh chief also called for harmony among religions and communities. He urged people to practise equality in social life through conduct rather than slogans.

"Because society remembers caste, politicians take advantage of it. Their legitimate aim is to get votes. If

they cannot get votes through work, they will get votes through caste," he said.

Replying to a question on the Population Control Bill and Uniform Civil Code (UCC), Bhagwat said the RSS was not the Government but a social organisation and emphasised that laws could succeed only with public participation.

"People must first be educated. Policy is necessary, but policy can only succeed with public cooperation," he said.

Centre launches JANANI portal for maternal, child healthcare tracking

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Union Health Ministry has launched a digital platform aimed at strengthening maternal and child healthcare services through seamless tracking of beneficiaries, real-time monitoring and interoperable health records.

Launched during the national summit on Innovation and Inclusivity Best Practices Shaping India's Health Future, JANANI (Journey of Antenatal, Natal and Neonatal Integrated Care) is a service-oriented digital platform designed to comprehensively monitor and maintain digital health records of women during their reproductive years, a health ministry Statement.

Developed as an upgraded version of the existing Reproductive and Child Health (RCH) portal, the platform creates a longitudinal health record by capturing service delivery events across the continuum of care, the Statement said.

JANANI will facilitate continuous tracking of maternal and child healthcare services, including antenatal care, delivery preparedness, institutional delivery, postnatal care,



newborn care, home-based newborn and young child care, and family planning services. "The platform ensures continuity of care at every stage by enabling timely interventions and seamless monitoring of beneficiaries," the Statement said.

A key feature of the platform is the introduction of QR-enabled digital Mother and Child Health (MCH) cards, which will allow portability and easy access to health records across healthcare facilities.

JANANI also incorporates automated alerts for high-risk pregnancies, real-time dashboards for supervisory review and due-list generation for frontline health workers, enabling timely tracking and targeted interventions.

Nora Fatehi apologises to NCW over Sarke Chunar, says no intent to offend

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Actor Nora Fatehi on Thursday appeared before the National Commission for Women (NCW) in connection with a controversy surrounding the song 'Sarke Chunar' and apologised, saying there was "no intention to offend anybody."

Speaking to reporters after the hearing, Fatehi said she had been put in a situation unintentionally but acknowledged her responsibility as an artist.

"It was just a situation that I was put in, and there was no intention to offend anybody. But of course, I have to be responsible as an artiste. I definitely apologise, we have done everything in writing. They have been so kind and helpful," she said.



The actor also said she has decided to sponsor the education of orphan girls.

"It's really important for us to give back to society. So, I decided that we should sponsor a few orphan girls, their education, so that is the goal after this matter," she said.

In a Statement, the commission said that Fatehi submitted a written unconditional apology.

According to the commission, Fatehi said she was not

well-versed in Kannada and was unaware of the objectionable message conveyed in the Hindi-dubbed version of the song.

She expressed regret over the impact caused by the song and assured the commission that she would exercise greater caution while associating with future projects.

During the hearing, NCW chairperson Vijaya Rahatkar expressed concern over the vulgarity and societal impact of such content and said artistes and public figures cannot evade social responsibility by citing contractual limitations or lack of awareness.

Rahatkar said celebrities wield significant influence over society, particularly the youth, and must remain conscious of the messages they convey.

Bihar: Over 150 kids fall ill after consuming mid-day meal in Saharsa

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Saharsa

More than 150 children were taken ill after allegedly consuming food that was part of the mid-day meal in a school in Bihar's Saharsa district, a senior official said on Thursday.

The incident occurred at a middle school in Baluaha village of the district.

The official said that 115 children were undergoing treatment at the Sadar Hospital, while around 50 students were admitted to Mahishi Public Health Centre.



"We received information that several children fell ill after consuming the mid-day meal in Baluaha. The children were initially treated at the primary health centre, but later,

many were referred to the Sadar Hospital," Saharsa District Magistrate Deepesh Kumar told reporters.

"According to doctors, the health condition of the children has improved, but they will be kept under observation for some time. There is no need to panic. Some kids are having mild fever. They are being treated accordingly," Kumar said.

Meanwhile, family members of some children claimed that a snake was found in the container in which cooked pulses was stored at the school.

TMC rattled after defeat, violence has no place in democracy: Shivraj Singh

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

Union minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Thursday condemned the killing of senior BJP leader Suvendu Adhikari's personal assistant, saying the Trinamool Congress had become "rattled" after its electoral defeat in West Bengal. Adhikari's executive assistant Chandranath Rath was shot dead by bike-borne assailants on the outskirts of Kolkata on Wednesday night.

Speaking to reporters on the sidelines of a programme in Lucknow, Chouhan said violence has no place in democracy and accused the ruling Trinamool Congress of resorting to violent means.

"TMC and Mamata Banerjee have become rattled after their crushing defeat. There is no place for violence



Union Minister of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare Shivraj Singh Chouhan visits a mango orchard of Malihabad, Lucknow on Thursday PTI

in democracy, but the Trinamool Congress has resorted to violence," he said.

"It is extremely unfortunate that the personal assistant of our leader

Suvendu Adhikari was riddled with bullets in this manner," the Union Agriculture Minister said.

He asserted that under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra

Modi, the BJP's objective is to build a violence-free, fear-free and developed Bengal.

"Whoever has committed this heinous act and murder, no criminal will be spared. Such incidents are not only tragic but shameful in a democracy. Bengal will become both secure and developed," Chouhan said.

Responding to another question on the completion of one year of Operation Sindoor, Chouhan said the Government fulfils what it promises.

"Anyone who dares to cast an evil eye on India or Indian citizens will not be tolerated. Terrorism is moving towards elimination, Naxalism is moving towards elimination, and under Prime Minister Modi's leadership, India is progressing towards becoming secure, fear-free and developed," he added.

States Focus



Puducherry LG K Kailashnathan receives the resignation letter of AINRC chief N Rangasamy as UT's Chief Minister at Lok Bhavan in Puducherry on Thursday

PTI

N RANGASAMY RESIGNS AS PUDUCHERRY CHIEF MINISTER

AINRC chief N Rangasamy on Thursday resigned as Puducherry Chief Minister and submitted his resignation letter to Lieutenant Governor K Kailashnathan at Lok Bhavan here. Later, speaking to reporters, he said he would meet the Lt Governor shortly and stake claim to form the Government. Rangasamy is all set to lead Puducherry for the fifth time with his party, the AINRC-led NDA, winning the elections in the UT with a handsome margin. The All India NR Congress has emerged victorious in 12 out of the 16 seats it contested and the BJP won four of the 10 seats it fought. The AIADMK and Latchia Jananayaga Katchi (LJK), other NDA constituents, emerged successful from one seat each and the combine has 18 seats in the 30-member House.



LALREMTLUANGA SWORN IN AS AIZAWL MAYOR

Zoram People's Movement (ZPM) leader H Lalremtluanga was sworn in as the new Mayor of Aizawl Municipal Corporation (AMC) on Thursday. R Lalawmpuii was sworn in as the new Deputy Mayor of the civic body. Alongside the Mayor and Deputy Mayor, 17 other newly elected corporators, including four Executive Corporators, were administered the oath of office by Aizawl Deputy Commissioner Lalhriatpuia during a swearing-in ceremony held at the municipal corporation's board of corporators meeting hall in Aizawl's Thuampui area. Lalremtluanga, 43, had worked in different fields, including a teacher in a private school, an outreach worker with FXB International and an assistant in a public sector undertaking unit, before joining politics.

BJP alleges pre-planned conspiracy in Adhikari's PA murder

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Thursday accused the Trinamool Congress (TMC) of fostering a "mafia culture" and "maha jungle raj" in West Bengal following the killing of the personal assistant of senior BJP leader Suvendu Adhikari.

Adhikari's executive assistant, Chandranath Rath, was shot dead by bike-borne assailants who intercepted Rath's vehicle near Doltala in Madhyamgram around 10.30 pm on Wednesday, forced it to stop and opened fire at point-blank range before fleeing.

BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla alleged that post-poll violence has been "institutionalised" in West Bengal over the last 15 years and claimed BJP workers and leaders are targeted whenever the TMC suffers electoral setbacks.

"The killing of the PA of Suvendu Adhikari ji is a direct result of the 'maha jungle raj' created in the last 15 years by the TMC. The manner in which post-poll violence has



Mortal remains of BJP leader Suvendu Adhikari's close aide Chandranath Rath, who was shot dead on Wednesday night, is brought to his native village in Purba Medinipur district, West Bengal on Thursday

PTI

been institutionalised, whether in 2021 or now, shows a direct targeted killing. A pre-planned conspiracy was done to eliminate the PA of Suvendu Adhikari ji," Poonawalla alleged.

Claiming that evidence emerging so far pointed towards a conspiracy, he said the TMC's "frustration" over electoral losses is leading to targeted attacks against BJP

leaders and workers. "It is obvious that the frustration of losing elections has become so severe that they indulge in post-poll violence and targeted killings of BJP leaders and workers. This will not be tolerated," he said.

The TMC condemned the killing and demanded a court-monitored CBI probe.

The BJP's West Bengal unit president, Samik

Bhattacharya, on Thursday described the killing of the close aide of the party's senior leader Suvendu Adhikari as a "planned political murder" and claimed that it was designed to cause instability in the State.

"It was a targeted violence," he told reporters at the Barasat Hospital where the post-mortem of Chandranath Rath was con-

₹1,400 cr seized in 2026 polls, West Bengal sees 68.92% spike: ECI

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

The Election Commission of India (ECI) on Thursday released a data and said over ₹1,400 crore worth of illicit inducements were seized during 2026 General Elections, Assembly elections in Assam, Kerala, Puducherry, Tamil Nadu, and West Bengal, and bye-elections in seven Assembly constituencies across five States.

West Bengal saw the highest increase in the seizures of 68.92 per cent, and Tamil Nadu saw an increase in seizures of 48.40 per cent in 2026 compared to the corresponding figures during the 2021 elections.

The figures represent a 40.14 per cent increase in seizures as compared to the 2021 assembly polls in the States of West Bengal,

Assembly Elections 2026 Record Seizures Reported									
Total seizures during the 2026 Assembly elections in five states were 40,14% higher compared to the 2021 Assembly elections									
	In ₹ crore					Freebies and Other Items			
	Cash	Liquor	Drugs	Precious Metals	Other				Total
Tamil Nadu	105.22	4.94	78.61	165.86	307.65				662.28
West Bengal	31.14	151.86	130.28	69.36	190.77				573.41
Assam	6.07	22.71	70.08	3.68	14.70				117.24
Kerala	12.12	2.51	58.47	2.25	5.33				80.67
Puducherry	0.33	0.38	0	8.99	0.02				9.72
Total	154.89	183.33	337.88	250.14	518.73				1,444.96

Data as on May 6, 2026

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Vande Mataram not equal to national anthem: Owaisi

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

AIMIM president Asaduddin Owaisi on Thursday objected to the Union Cabinet's decision to grant 'Vande Mataram' the same statutory protection as the national anthem 'Jana Gana Mana', saying the song cannot be treated on par with the anthem, as it is an ode to a goddess.

The nation does not run in the name of a god or goddess and it does not belong to one god or goddess, he said.

In a post on X, he said, "Jana Gana Mana celebrates India and its people, not a particular religion. Religion—nation. The man who wrote Vande Mataram was sympathetic to the British Raj and despised Muslims. Netaji Bose, Gandhi, Nehru, and Tagore all rejected it."

Referring to the Constitution of India, he said the Preamble begins with "We, the People" — not



AIMIM president Asaduddin Owaisi

"Bharat Maa". It promises "liberty of thought, expression, belief, faith and worship".

The very first provision of the Constitution, Article 1, describes

"India, that is Bharat" as a Union of States, he said. In the Constituent Assembly, some members wanted the Preamble to begin in the name of a goddess and they specifically

invoked Vande Mataram. Others wanted it to begin "In the name of God" and to replace "its citizens" with "her citizens". However, all these amendments were defeated, Owaisi said.

"India, that is Bharat, is its people. The nation is not a goddess; it does not run in the name of a god or goddess, and it does not belong to one god or goddess," he said.

Meanwhile, Telangana BJP president N Ramchander Rao took exception to Owaisi's objections to the government's decision and said the AIMIM leadership views any form of cultural integration as a threat to religious exclusivism.

It is not just limited to Owaisi, even Jinnah followed the same trajectory, he said.

Jinnah had not objected to Vande Mataram during the early phase of his political career as a Congress member and his opposition emerged only after he left the Congress, he said.

"What does this tell us? Once politics becomes dependent on religious exclusivism, every civilisational symbol is portrayed as a threat," Rao said in a post on X.

Suggesting a pattern, the BJP leader said the AIMIM opposes not just Vande Mataram, but also the Uniform Civil Code, the abolition of Triple Talaq and every attempt at creating a common framework.

"All of this stems from a leadership mindset that sees cultural integration and national cohesion as dangers to its political relevance and religious exclusivism," he said.

The Union Cabinet has approved a proposal to amend the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971 to make any obstruction to the singing of the national song Vande Mataram a punishable offence.

This gives Vande Mataram the same statutory protection as the national anthem Jana Gana Mana.

Centre extends 5 State laws to Chandigarh to boost transparency



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chandigarh

The Centre has extended the provisions of five State legislations, including three of Punjab, to the Union Territory of Chandigarh.

The move is part of a set of governance and regulatory reforms which are aimed at modernising legal frameworks, enhancing transparency and improving ease of living and ease of doing business. The extensions have been made through notifications under Section 87 of the Punjab Reorganisation Act, 1966, in accordance with the established practice of extending suitable state laws to Chandigarh, which does not have its own legislature, officials said.

These measures, taken together, represent a comprehensive effort to address gaps in existing legal frameworks, bring greater clarity and uniformity in regulation, strengthen citizen protection, and support efficient governance in Chandigarh.

The notifications were issued by the Centre on May 6. The reforms comprise extension of three laws of Punjab and one each of Haryana and Assam.

The Assam Tenancy Act, 2021, aligned with the Model Tenancy Act, 2021, has been extended to replace the

existing East Punjab Urban Rent Restriction Act, 1949, and introduce a modern and balanced tenancy framework.

The Act provides for formal tenancy agreements, clear delineation of rights and obligations, structured eviction procedures and a time-bound dispute resolution mechanism, thereby promoting transparency and improving availability of rental housing. To ensure a transparent and efficient rental housing market, the Centre had formulated the Model Tenancy Act, 2021.

The Model Tenancy Act seeks to balance the interests of landlords and tenants, create a transparent and accountable ecosystem for renting of premises, and provide a speedy dispute resolution mechanism. The law is also expected to encourage private participation in rental housing and promote efficient utilisation of available housing stock.

The Act provides for a modern and balanced tenancy framework with various provisions including clarity on rent and tenancy terms. Mandatory written tenancy agreements will ensure that rent, duration, revision and other key conditions are clearly specified upfront, thereby reducing disputes.

₹500 crore scam linked to GIFT City uncovered in Gujarat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gandhinagar

A large-scale alleged investment fraud connected to a proposed data centre venture in GIFT City has come to light in Gujarat, with preliminary estimates suggesting the scam could involve nearly ₹500 crore.

The allegations are centred on Utpal Patel, originally from Isri village in Meghraj taluka of Aravalli district, who is accused of attracting investors through a high-return technology investment scheme.

According to information emerging from affected investors, Patel allegedly promoted a business model based on renting "terabyte" (TB) units in a data centre setup. Investors were reportedly encouraged to invest around ₹38,000 per TB with



promises of fixed monthly returns of nearly ₹1,650.

To build credibility, offices were allegedly established in GIFT City, Noida and Kashmir, while the venture was projected as a rapidly expanding technology enterprise. The attractive return model is believed to have drawn investments from hundreds of people from Gujarat and several other States.

The alleged fraud came under scrutiny after operations at the GIFT City office

abruptly stopped, and investors reportedly failed to receive promised payouts. Concern among investors increased after the office was found locked and communication channels became inactive.

Sources claim the accused has gone untraceable after reportedly shutting down social media accounts. There is speculation that he may have left the country a few days ago, though no official confirmation has been issued so far. His residence in Isri village is also said to be locked.

Investors allege that Patel maintained a lavish public image, including the use of luxury vehicles and appearances at public events. It is also claimed that photographs and recognition received at various functions were used to strengthen investor confidence.



Tourists visit the Taj Mahal on a cloudy day in Agra on Thursday

PTI

CAQM assesses anti-stubble burning preparedness of States

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) in NCR and adjoining areas has reviewed State action plans and preparedness for elimination of paddy stubble-burning incidents during the upcoming paddy harvesting season, officials said on Thursday.

The review took place at a meeting on Wednesday convened by CAQM with senior officials from Punjab, Haryana and Uttar Pradesh Governments, including deputy commissioners/district magistrates (DCs/DMs) of hotspot districts.

Representatives of the Punjab Pollution Control Board (PPCB), Haryana State Pollution Control Board



(HSPCB), and Uttar Pradesh Pollution Control Board (UPPCB) also attended the meeting. "During the meeting, the urgent need for systematic and coordinated preparedness ahead of the forthcoming paddy harvesting season was highlighted," an official said.

"The importance of strengthening both in-situ and ex-situ crop residue management mechanisms, along with focused enforcement and awareness measures, was also emphasised to ensure effective implementation at the field level," the official added.

It was also noted that stubble burning is not a seasonal concern but a larger air pollution mitigation challenge throughout the year, affecting the ambient air quality across the region.

To tackle the situation, deliberations were held on key operational and logistical aspects, including timely availability of crop residue management (CRM) machines, promotion of zero stubble-burning villages through incentives, and enforcement measures for ensuring compliance etc.

Several action points emerged from the meeting, such as Punjab, Haryana and Uttar Pradesh have to submit detailed reports on the status of functional CRM machines within two months.

Naidu proposes Singapore model for one district in Andhra

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Amaravati

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Thursday proposed adopting Singapore's best administrative practices in one district as a pilot model and directed officials to prepare a 90-day action plan for implementation.

Addressing the seventh collectors conference at the Secretariat, the Chief Minister stressed the need to adopt a collective "We" mindset instead of an individualistic "Me" approach, drawing inspiration from Singapore's governance philosophy.

"We should adopt Singapore's best governance practices by develop-



ing one district as a model and implement them through a focused 90-day action plan," he said.

Naidu said that everyone should move away from an individualistic mindset, and he too would replace the word "I" with "We" in his public discourse.

The CM said learning is a

continuous process and adopting best practices from anywhere in the world can deliver strong outcomes in governance, administration and development.

Highlighting the state's Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP), Naidu said decisions taken today would have a long-term impact on

the people of the state and pointed to regional disparities in development.

Referring to tribal districts, the CM said Alluri Sitharama Raju district achieved higher GSDP than Parvathipuram Manyam due to value addition in coffee cultivation.

Emphasising innovation-led growth, Naidu said the service sector should expand further and Andhra Pradesh contributes nearly 10 percent of the country's agricultural output.

Noting that several districts possess rare earth mineral resources, he said processing plants linked to these minerals could create new industrial opportunities and economic growth avenues.

Colonial legacy held back India's economic strength: Amitabh Kant

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

When the British colonised India 200 years ago, India's share of global GDP was more than 25 percent. By the time they left in 1947, it had dwindled to just 2 percent," said former NITI Aayog CEO and G20 Sherpa Amitabh Kant at Bharat Ki Soch's flagship Mantrana discussion series on the theme "Shedding Our Colonial Vestiges: Lessons for a Viksit Bharat".

The session, moderated by Navika Kumar, Editor-in-Chief of the *Times Group*, was also held to mark one year of Operation Sindoor, which Bharat Ki Soch Chairman Anil Rajput described in his inaugural address as "a powerful reflection of India's courage, resolve, and strategic clarity in defending our country against terrorism." *The Pioneer* was the media partner of the event attended by a galaxy of intellectuals from various fields.

Kant began with the numbers that define the colonial ledger. At the time of independence, he said, India had 80 per cent living in poverty, a literacy rate of only 12 percent, and an average life expectancy of just 32 years. He cited Lord Salisbury, the Secretary of State for India, who had himself acknowledged the extraction: "We bled India." He referenced Dadabhai Naoroji's work on poverty and un-British rule, and drew a causal link between that extraction and the famines that followed. The Bengal famine of 1770, he said, killed over 10 million people and wiped out nearly a third of Bengal. One British author had described its magnitude as worse than the Black Plague of the 14th century.



NITI Aayog CEO and G20 Sherpa Amitabh Kant, Editor-in-Chief of the *Times Group* Navika Kumar and Bharat Ki Soch Chairman Anil Rajput at Bharat Ki Soch's flagship Mantrana discussion series on the theme 'Shedding Our Colonial Vestiges: Lessons for a Viksit Bharat' in New Delhi

Pankaj Kumar

"This history we should never forget as Indians," Kant said. "The tragedy is that Indians forget history." But the lecture was not an exercise in grievance. Kant pivoted quickly to the argument that decolonisation, intellectual and institutional, is the precondition for genuine development. He pointed to Japan, South Korea, and China as the only three countries to achieve developed status in the post-World War II era, and noted that none of them copied Western culture or abandoned their own roots. "They went back to their history, their civilisation," he said. "That is the lesson."

He grounded his argument in India's civilisational depth, citing recent archaeological evidence from the Rakhigarhi excavations suggesting Indian civilisation predates

Egyptian and Mesopotamian civilisations, potentially going back to 4500 BC. He described Nalanda University, which at its peak had 10,000 students and 2,000 professors drawn from across Asia, as a reminder that India was once the centre of intellectual excellence in the known world.

On the path forward, Kant identified four strategic priorities for an India seeking true independence from global vulnerabilities: renewable energy, critical minerals, semiconductors, and clean technologies. He argued that India's climatic conditions make it uniquely suited to renewable energy dominance, and said the current 270 gigawatts target should be expanded significantly. On artificial intelligence, he said India holds three distinct advantages: it generates 20 percent of the

world's data, has access to renewable energy for data centres, and possesses unparalleled talent. "Frontier AI models may be built elsewhere, but India must use AI to transform the lives of its citizens," he said.

Anil Rajput, in his opening remarks, framed the broader purpose of the Mantrana series as a dialogue between India's civilisational wisdom and contemporary policy. He said development cannot be only economic. "It is about the framework through which a society thinks, decides, and governs itself. We must ask whether India can truly become a developed nation without intellectual, institutional, and psychological decolonisation."

Kant closed with a characteristic declaration. "This will not merely be India's decade. This will be India's century."

AI holds meet amid airline facing West Asia conflict headwinds

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Air India's board of directors held a meeting on Thursday amid the loss-making airline facing multiple headwinds, including high jet fuel prices, due to the West Asia conflict.

The board meeting took place at Air India's headquarters in Gurugram, Haryana.

The meeting started at around 11.30 am and went on for over three hours, according to sources.

Specific details about the discussions at the meeting could not be ascertained.

Earlier, sources had said the airline's financials for 2025-26, cost-saving measures and selection of a new CEO were expected to be discussed at the meeting.

Current CEO and MD Campbell Wilson will be stepping down later this year.

Airspace curbs and higher jet fuel prices due to the West Asia conflict are adversely impacting the airline, which is in the midst of an ambitious transformation plan. Operational costs have gone up significantly in recent months for the carrier.

Against this backdrop, the airline is mulling various cost-saving measures.

AAP, BJP trade barbs over twin blasts in Punjab



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Aam Aadmi Party MP Sanjay Singh on Thursday alleged that the BJP has started its "Mission Punjab" with twin blasts in Amritsar and Jalandhar to vitiate the peaceful atmosphere in the poll-bound State, prompting sharp reaction from the saffron outfit.

The BJP condemned Singh's linking of the party's "Mission Punjab" to the bomb blasts and said it reflects AAP's "political frustration". Addressing a press conference, Singh said that even in West Bengal, post-poll violence is being witnessed after the BJP's victory.

"There is a direct relation between the BJP and Pakistan's ISI (Inter Services Intelligence). We have seen this in the past in the Pathankot incident. Blasts in Amritsar and Jalandhar are part of the BJP's poll strategy to break the

peace in the state," Singh said. The BJP has a "history of joining hands with the ISI", he claimed, adding that Prime Minister Narendra Modi "invited" them to investigate the Pathankot incident.

"The BJP has strong relations with the same ISI that is behind several incidents in India. Hence, Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann and our party have accused them of causing blasts in Amritsar and Jalandhar," he added.

In response, Delhi BJP chief Virendra Sachdeva said that AAP is completely "frustrated" as all the parties AAP convened Arvind Kejriwal supported and campaigned for in West Bengal and Tamil Nadu were pushed to the margins after the assembly elections.

On Wednesday, Mann held the BJP responsible for the twin blasts and said this was how the party was preparing for the upcoming assembly elections in Punjab.



Editor's
TAKE

India-Vietnam reaffirm a strategic convergence

As India seeks a greater role in Southeast Asia and Vietnam looks to diversify its strategic partnerships, the convergence of interests is unmistakable

Lately, India has started focusing on Southeast Asia, the region traditionally dominated by China. The region has seen rapid strides in economic development, but many countries here are vulnerable to external pressures and succumb to the power play in the region, as development in the region has not been uniform. Since 1991, India has engaged with Southeast Asian nations under the 'Look East Policy,' which was given a fillip by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who upgraded it to the Act East Policy in 2014. It now encompasses strategic and economic shifts aimed at deepening India's engagement with Southeast Asia and the broader Indo-Pacific region through trade, connectivity, defence cooperation, and cultural ties. This has indeed increased Indian influence in the region and provided a counterweight to China's influence, which treats this region as its backyard.

In this framework, Vietnam occupies a pivotal position as one of India's most trusted partners in the region. Over the years, India and Vietnam have expanded cooperation in defence, energy, digital connectivity, and trade, while also strengthening people-to-people and civilisational links rooted in Buddhism and historical exchanges.

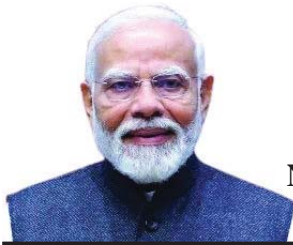
Vietnam and India have cooperated for a long time and have a convergence of interests and strategic outlooks - their goals align in keeping the South China Sea open for navigation and ensuring maritime security. Vietnam is officially recognised by the India as a 'key pillar' of its 'Act East Policy.' The relationship has gone a notch up, as it has been elevated to an "Enhanced Comprehensive Strategic Partnership."

The visit of Vietnam's President in India is as symbolic as it is strategic. As both nations commemorate a decade of their Comprehensive Strategic Partnership, the visit offers an opportunity to assess how far the relationship has evolved and in what direction should it move forward. Indeed, India and Vietnam have quietly built one of the most dependable partnerships in Asia in the last ten years.

At the heart of the engagement lies defence cooperation. Vietnam remains one of India's closest security partners in Southeast Asia. New Delhi has offered credit for defence procurement, assisted in the capacity-building of Vietnamese armed forces, and stepped up naval exchanges. Bilateral trade has crossed the \$15 billion mark, but remains modest relative to the scale of both economies. The visit is expected to push forward cooperation in sectors such as pharmaceuticals, renewable energy, digital infrastructure, and supply chain diversification. India and Vietnam are well-positioned to emerge as complementary manufacturing and innovation hubs. Equally significant is the cultural and civilisational connect. Expanding tourism, academic collaboration, and diaspora engagement could add depth to this relationship. Yet, the challenge is that it should not provoke an undue response from China, and so it must be kept below the threshold. President To Lam's visit, therefore, is all about cementing partnership through trust and purpose. The challenge now lies in converting that trust into transformative cooperation.

Somnath and Bharat's unconquerable spirit!

I urge my fellow Indians to travel to Somnath in this special time. When you stand on the shores of Somnath, let its ancient echoes speak to you



NARENDRA MODI

At the start of 2026, I had gone to Somnath for the Somnath Swabhiman Parv, marking a thousand years since the first attack on the Somnath Temple. Now, I will be back in Somnath on May 11th, to mark 75 years since the inauguration of the restored Temple by the then President of India, Dr Rajendra Prasad. In less than half a year, it is a privilege to be attending two important milestones relating to Somnath and its journey from ruin to renewal or what we describe as from Vidhvans to Srijan. Somnath gives us a civilisational message. The vast sea before it evokes timelessness. The waves tell us...that no matter how fierce the storms are or how turbulent the tides are, one can always rise again with dignity and strength. The waves return to the shore, as though reminding every generation that the spirit of the people can never be subdued for long.

Our ancient scriptures say:
Prabhaasam cha parikramya prithivee krama sambhavam.

It means, a Pradakshina of the divine Prabhasa (Somnath) is equal to a Pradakshina of the whole earth itself! While people have come here to pray, they have also experienced the remarkable continuity of a civilisation whose flame could never be extinguished. Empires rose and fell, tides changed, history moved through conquest and upheaval, yet Somnath continued to endure in our consciousness. It is time to remember the countless greats who stood firm in the face of tyranny. There were Lakulisha and Soma Sarman, who transformed Prabhasa into a great centre of philosophy. Chakravarti Maharaja Dharasena IV of Vallabhi built the Second Temple three centuries ago. Bhima Deva, Jayapala and Anandapala will always be remembered for defending civilisational honour against invasions. It is said that Raja Bhoja too helped with the reconstruction. Karna Deva and Siddharaja Jayasimha played a vital role in restoring Gujarat's political and cultural strength. Bhava Brihaspati, Kumarapala Solanki and the Pashupata Acharyas rebuilt and sustained the shrine as a great centre of worship and learning. Vishaladeva Vaghela and Tripurantaka protected its intellectual and spiritual traditions. Mahipaladeva and Ra Khangar were instrumental in reviving worship after destruction. Punyashlok Ahilyabai Holkar, whose 300th birth centenary is being marked, ensured the continuity of devotion in the most difficult of times. There were the Gaekwads of Baroda, who safeguarded the rights of pilgrims. And of course, our soil is blessed to have nurtured brave personalities



like Veer Hamirji Gohil and Veer Vegdaji Bhil, whose sacrifice and courage have become a part of Somnath's living memory.

In the 1940s, when the spirit of freedom swept across India and the foundations of a new republic were being laid under the leadership of towering figures like Sardar Patel, one thing continued to trouble him deeply...the condition of Somnath. On November 13th, 1947, during Diwali time, he stood next to the dilapidated ruins of the temple with sea-water in his hands and said, "On this auspicious day of the (Gujarati) New Year, we have decided that Somnath should be reconstructed. You, people of Saurashtra, should do your best. This is a holy task in which all should participate." On one clarion call of Sardar Patel, it was not only the people of Gujarat but also the people of the whole of India that responded enthusiastically.

Unfortunately, fate did not allow Sardar Patel to witness the fulfilment of the dream he had so passionately championed. Before the restored Somnath Temple could open its doors to devotees, he had departed from this world. Yet, his impact continued to be felt over the sacred shores of Prabhas Patan. His vision was championed by Shri KM Munshi, ably supported by the Jamsaheb of Nawanganar. In 1951, when the Temple was complete, it was decided to call the President of India, Dr Rajendra Prasad, for the ceremony. Overcoming strong objections from the then Prime Minister Pandit Nehru, Dr Prasad graced the ceremony, thus making it even more special and historic. My mind also goes back to October 2001,

when I had just taken over as Chief Minister. On October 31st 2001, the Jayanti of Sardar Patel, the Gujarat Government had the honour of organising a programme to mark 50 years since the Somnath Temple opened its doors. It also coincided with the 125th birth anniversary celebrations of Sardar Patel. The then Prime Minister Shri Atal Bihari Vajpayee and the then Home Minister Shri LK Advani attended the programme. During his speech on May 11th, 1951, Dr Rajendra Prasad said that the Somnath Temple proclaims to the world that anything with unparalleled faith and love cannot be destroyed. He expressed hope that this Temple will live in the hearts of people. He also said that the restoration of the Temple was a fulfilment of Sardar Patel's dream, but taking that spirit forward, it is important that we restore prosperity to the lives of people. These are important and inspiring messages he gave.

This is the path we have been walking for over a decade. I consider it my good fortune that, inspired by the principle of 'Vikas Bhi, Virasat Bhi', from Somnath to Kashi, Kamakhya to Kedarnath, Ayodhya to Ujjain, Trimbakeshwar to Srisailem, our team has had the opportunity to equip our spiritual centres with the latest facilities while at the same time preserving their traditional character. This, along with efforts to improve connectivity, ensures more people can visit them. It boosts the local economy, secures livelihoods and deepens the spirit of 'Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat.'

The struggles and sacrifices of those who laid down their lives to protect Somnath and those who rebuilt it time and again will never be forgotten. Countless individuals from different corners of India contributed to restoring its glory. They saw every part of Bharat as sacred, bound together by a sense of oneness that transcended geography. In a world often marked by divisions, this spirit of unity is more relevant than ever. Somnath will continue to stand tall in all its glory because the sense of unity and shared civilisational consciousness lives on in the hearts of every Indian. As a tribute to this, remembering the extraordinary courage of a thousand years, there will be special Pujas at Somnath for the next thousand days. It is gladdening to see several people donating for these Pujas as well.

I urge my fellow Indians to travel to Somnath in this special time. When you stand on the shores of Somnath, let its ancient echoes speak to you. You will not only be overwhelmed by devotion but will also feel the strong pulse of a civilisational spirit that refuses to fade, that is unbroken and unyielding. You will experience Bharat's unconquerable spirit and understand why, despite every effort, our culture remained undefeated and you will have the opportunity to behold the vision of eternal triumph. It will surely be unforgettable. *Jai Somnath!*

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

I WILL BE BACK
IN SOMNATH ON
MAY 11TH, TO
MARK 75 YEARS
SINCE THE
INAUGURATION
OF THE
RESTORED
TEMPLE BY THE
THEN PRESIDENT
OF INDIA, DR
RAJENDRA
PRASAD

The writer is the Prime
Minister of India and also
the Chairman of the Shree
Somnath Trust

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narendramodi

PIC TALK



Farmers load harvested maize onto a tractor trolley, in Morigaon district, Assam. PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



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ECONOMIC RESILIENCE FACES A CRUCIAL TEST AS FOREIGN INVESTORS SHY AWAY

Apropos "Capital Flight Tests Market Resilience" (May 7, 2026), the sharp withdrawal of foreign investments and the weakening rupee underline the vulnerabilities hidden beneath India's growth narrative.

Global uncertainties, coupled with rising crude oil prices, have exposed how dependent economic momentum can become on external investor confidence. Our overdependence on crude oil import is our weakness as it can be used as a lever.

The immediate challenge before policymakers is not merely to arrest capital outflows, but to restore trust through predictable governance, fiscal prudence, and greater diversification of energy sources.

India's economic

fundamentals remain comparatively strong, supported by domestic institutions and a resilient financial framework. However, long-term stability cannot rest on optimism alone.

Exchange rate management must remain pragmatic and reforms should reassure investors that policy continuity and macroeconomic discipline are enduring commitments rather than temporary responses to crises.

The present moment is less a test of exuberant growth and more one of endurance and credibility.

How effectively India balances global volatility with internal strength will determine whether it can sustain investor confidence and economic stability in the years ahead.

K CHIDANAND KUMAR, BENGALURU

When civility stops at the gate



SANJAY CHANDRA

2ND OPINION

A pleasant May drizzle had just passed, and I was out for my morning walk with my wife within the society premises. The roads were still wet, but that did not concern me much, until a car drove through a puddle and splashed water all over us, leaving our trousers soaked. What stayed with me even more than the sudden discomfort, however, was the manner in which the car simply drove on without slowing down, without so much as a glance in the rear-view mirror, and without any hint of an apologetic smile or a raised hand that might have acknowledged what had just happened.

Was my expectation unreasonable? I did not think so, especially considering that we live in a well-to-do condominium inhabited by people who are, by all conventional measures, educated professionals in corporates and gov-

ernment offices, neighbours who are almost an extended family, and yet, in that brief moment, there was a complete absence of acknowledgement. I know, at least for myself, that had I been on the other side, I would have stopped and apologised, and it is perhaps this contrast that made it evident that the incident was not an isolated one.

A few months ago, we were nearly run over by another individual driving a large car, possibly the same person. When confronted, he chose not to apologise, but to argue, asserting that we were at fault, and that we had no right to even photograph his vehicle.

On another occasion, during a society meeting, a gentleman spoke harshly to anyone who dared to disagree with him, and his tone with the estate manager bordered on intimidation, with remarks that carried implicit threats about changing authority. He was equally dismissive, even disrespectful, towards some of the women present, and what struck me most was not merely what was said, but the manner in which it was said. The same group has become more vocal with the announcement of society elections. Their exchanges, if stripped of their tone, might almost appear comic. But the aggression that accompanies them is difficult to ignore, particularly when one considers that these are the very individuals who may soon be responsible for managing our shared spaces.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

What troubles me is that this is no longer confined to isolated incidents or individuals, for the same tenor, sharp, dismissive, and often derogatory, seems to have seeped into our larger discourse, visible in society meetings, in everyday interactions, and increasingly in public life, not restricted to one place or level, but echoing across contexts, even globally.

I am not alone in sensing this discomfort, as many others feel it too, even if they do not always articulate it, and it leaves me with a quiet, unsettling question about

whether we have become the right people at the wrong time, or whether the standards we grew up with, of courtesy, restraint, and mutual respect, are no longer as valued as they once were. The answer lies not in lamenting the times but in choosing not to

be shaped entirely by them, because if civility is indeed fading, it will not return through argument or assertion, but only, if at all, through quiet practice, one interaction at a time, and through a conscious effort to pause, reflect, and respond with a sense of consideration that acknowledges the presence and dignity of others in the spaces we share. Perhaps change begins when we choose courtesy, even when none is offered.

The writer is founder of Kala - Krazy About Literature And Arts, is an author, speaker, coach, arbitrator, and strategy consultant

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

India-Japan partnership in health is promising

India and Japan have historically shared warm and stable relations, free from major diplomatic discord. Although bilateral ties remained limited for years, sustained engagement through high-level visits and strategic cooperation has significantly strengthened the partnership. Healthcare has now emerged as an important pillar of this growing relationship.

The recent joint Committee Meeting on Healthcare held in New Delhi highlighted the commitment of both nations to deepen cooperation in areas such as digital health and medical innovation. India's globally recognised pharmaceutical and medical device manufacturing capabilities complement Japan's technological expertise and ageing healthcare needs. Japan has also shown keen interest in India's skilled healthcare workforce. The "Memorandum of Cooperation in Healthcare and Wellness" has further provided a framework for collaboration, particularly in addressing non-communicable diseases such as cancer, whose burden is rising in both countries. Enhanced cooperation in research, technology and healthcare delivery can greatly benefit the public health systems of both nations. The partnership reflects how strategic ties extend beyond economics and defence to improving human well-being and public health outcomes.

GANAPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

Preserving the true spirit of PILs

Public Interest Litigation (PIL) has long served as one of India's most powerful instruments of social justice, enabling judicial intervention in issues ranging from environmental protection and labour rights to prison reform and access to essential services. It is this legacy that gives significance to the Supreme Court's recent observations on the growing misuse of PILs.

Hearing a batch of petitions, including matters related to the Sabarimala Temple, a Constitution Bench led by Chief Justice Surya Kant remarked that PILs are increasingly turning into "Private Interest Litigation," "Publicity Interest Litigation," and even "Political Interest Litigation." These remarks reflect serious concern over the dilution of a constitutional mechanism originally intended to safeguard public welfare. PILs were conceived as extraordinary remedies in situations where conventional governance mechanisms had failed.

However, their increasing use for political contestation and personal agendas risks blurring institutional boundaries. Such trends burden courts and raise concerns about judicial overreach. The need of the hour is not to restrict access to justice, but to ensure that every PIL genuinely serves the larger public interest rather than narrow private ambitions.

YASH PAL RALHAN | JALANDHAR

Democratic mandates must be respected

With the results of the West Bengal Assembly elections already declared, the political atmosphere in the state remains tense. Allegations questioning the electoral mandate and criticism of the Election Commission have intensified the confrontation between rival political parties. However, in a democracy, respecting the verdict of the people remains fundamental to constitutional governance. Electoral defeats and victories are integral to democratic politics, and transitions of power must take place with dignity and responsibility. While political parties have every right to raise concerns through constitutional and legal channels, prolonged refusal to acknowledge the public mandate risks undermining democratic institutions and public confidence. The outcome of the election reflects not only political competition but also public assessment of governance and administrative performance over the years. Constructive opposition and healthy political engagement are essential, but they should not obstruct governance or the smooth functioning of state administration. At this juncture, all stakeholders should prioritise stability, democratic values and the welfare of the people of West Bengal. The focus must now shift from political confrontation to governance and development in the larger public interest.

KIRTI WADHAWAN | KANPUR

Growing concerns over India Post's declining services

Postal Department should issue special RTI stamps in denominations of rupees 2, 10 and 50 on the lines of earlier such stamps used for licences of radio and TV sets. Presently, copying charges under the RTI Act in amounts lower than rupees 10 are not feasible because of discontinuance of postal orders in denominations of rupees 2



From forcing customers to make even small Speed Post payments through mobile phones or by purchasing postal stamps separately, to shrinking post-office presence in busy commercial hubs like Old Delhi, the Department of Posts appears to be drifting away from public convenience.

Postal Department has now made it compulsory for even petty payments for Speed Post and other postal services to be made through mobile phones, doing away with the normal practice of accepting cash. Users of postal services are instead advised first to purchase postal stamps by standing in a queue at another counter and then join the queue for Speed Post service after affixing the postal stamps. This ridiculous practice harms the Department as well, when unnecessarily the Department's money is wasted on such postal stamps sold merely to avoid cash being received directly for Speed Post services. Department of Posts should restore the earlier practice of accepting cash or payments through mobile phones in respect of Speed Post services.

Many post offices, like the one at Delhi Railway Station, accept Speed Post items only after 12 noon. There should be uniform timings in all post offices for accepting items to be sent through Speed Post. Special 24x7 Speed Post counters should work without break rather than stopping service in between for some time gaps. This should not create a problem since there are always two staffers deployed at each counter, out of whom one can handle the work during the break for the other staffer. Newly introduced printing machines for printing Speed Post receipts with stickers are not being used because of the alleged non-availability of paper rolls. Department should ensure sufficient supply of paper rolls, ensuring use of these printing machines at all post offices. It will be beneficial to the public exchequer also by avoiding man-hours and gum used to paste postal receipts in government departments on their despatch registers.

Most of the post offices in the commercial hub of the Old Delhi area have been closed only because of the huge reduction in postal business. People are instead shifting towards unreliable and costly courier services because of difficulties created by the Postal Department, as referred to above. Instead, the Postal Department should be more user-friendly to increase its earnings. With the introduction of government savings schemes in banks, post offices mainly function for booking Speed Post articles. With the increasing trend of online banking, bank branches can be approached to provide counters for booking Speed Post by paying them nominal commission.

During renovation of Chandni Chowk, a building was especially constructed at Bhai Mati Dass Chowk (Fountain) for providing space for public utility services in the public sector, including postal services apart from banking and insurance (both life and general). But this building is lying vacant. Postal Department should approach Municipal Corporation of Delhi to provide space in this building for opening a post office.

It is time that the Postal Department reviews all its postal services to induce newness in the system, also aimed at more earnings for the Department without hurting commoners. The aim should be to promote postal services for effectively competing with the increasing use of private courier services.

Postal Department delivers highly subsidised rubber-stamped (printed) postcards costing just 50 paise to Akashwani (All India Radio), where senders write "Any Song" for programmes of listeners' choice of film songs merely to get their names broadcast on Akashwani. During the 2019 Lok Sabha elections,



postcard politics between political parties cost the public exchequer heavily. Postcards are also misused for commercial purposes, such as by chit-fund companies to send reminders for payments. All such printed or rubber-stamped postcards should be discarded without delivery.

Subsidised postcards and Inland Letter Cards, not being used by common people, should be discontinued. Only sponsored Meghdoot postcards should remain, with a postal tariff of one rupee. Printed postcards should be priced at ten rupees. Likewise, registered newspapers should have a subsidised tariff of one rupee, whereas even the cost of inputs for production of small newspapers has risen manifold.

While normal postal services are exempt from GST, levying GST on select services like Speed Post is senseless, with tax money going from one pocket of the government to another. Levying GST on postal services results in expenditure of resources on paying GST by the Postal Department and its collection by the GST Department. Speed Post tariffs, both local and non-local, should be rationalised uniformly at rupees 20 or 30 (abolishing GST) per 50 gm weight slab or part thereof. All other postal tariffs (inland and international) should be in multiples of ten rupees. Postal tariff for ordinary mail should be revised to ten rupees per 50 gm weight slab. International postal tariffs (both air and surface) should be rationalised by having equal tariff rise for every 20 gm weight slab for air mail, and for every 50 gm weight slab in the case of surface or sea mail.

Sponsored postal stamps, with some minimum stipulated number carrying advertisements or other messages desired by sponsors to be endorsed by a committee of the Department, with sponsorship charges fixed per printed stamp, should be introduced. The system will generate enormous revenue firstly from sponsorship and secondly by making sponsoring companies shift from private courier companies to postal services.

To induce newness in the system and for earning extra revenue through philately, an altogether new definitive series of postal stamps and postal stationery should be issued simultaneously in all denominations every year on the first day of the new financial year, which should also be the date of revision of postal tariffs, if any. But the colour of a particular denomination of a postal stamp of the definitive series should remain the same, with only a change in design on the basis of the theme selected for that year.

Commemorative stamps in denominations of rupees 12 and 41 were issued on 24.01.2019 and 12.06.2019 respectively. With rationalisation of postal tariffs in multiples of ten rupees, commemorative stamps should then be issued only in multiples of ten rupees and only in the two most commonly used denominations. But the practice of printing stamps of different denominations in the same stamp sheet (except miniature sheets) should be discontinued because users of stamps of different denominations are different. The collection item of 'Miniature Sheets' should be priced higher than the face value of the stamps in them.

Media reports indicated that some notorious

persons from the underworld managed to get postage stamps issued with their photos printed under the "My Stamp" concept, where individuals can get their photos printed on postage stamps to be used towards postal tariffs on payment of extra cost. There is no provision whereby the "My Stamp" concept may not be available for tax defaulters and persons with criminal backgrounds. India Post should immediately discontinue the "My Stamp" concept because practically there can be no provision whereby persons with notorious backgrounds may not be able to get their photos printed on postage stamps.

Postal Department discontinued postal orders in outdated denominations like rupees 1, 2, 5 and 7 because of extremely low sales figures and high handling costs. Handling cost of a postal order was rupees 37.45 to the Postal Department in the year 2011-12. Handling cost for clearing operations of banks and in concerned public authorities was even extra. The public exchequer should not bear such extraordinary loss in handling postal orders in denominations like rupees 10 and 20. Rather, higher denominations like rupees 100, 200 and 500 may be added to avoid purchase of demand drafts in submitting various types of fees.

Postal Department should issue special RTI stamps in denominations of rupees 2, 10 and 50 on the lines of earlier such stamps used for licences of radio and TV sets. Presently, copying charges under the RTI Act in amounts lower than rupees 10 are not feasible because of discontinuance of postal orders in denominations of rupees 2. Even the Central Information Commission, through its verdicts and administrative orders, has repeatedly recommended issue of RTI stamps.

There is huge unclaimed money lying deposited in post offices, with many account holders and depositors having died without informing their legal heirs. There are always chances of frauds (as happened in some banks), whereby mischievous persons in connivance with certain postal employees may try to grab such unknown deposits. Postal Department should send letters by registered post in the names of such account holders and depositors who have not operated their accounts and claimed maturity amounts of deposits in the last, say, three years, giving them a reasonable period of, say, three months to either renew their accounts or deposits.

Otherwise, all such unclaimed money may be frozen in some fixed account, which may be allowed to be withdrawn only after careful verification. Details of all such accounts should then be made public also so that legal heirs may be able to claim them, but only after a rigorous scrutiny procedure. Postal Department should follow LIC of India in introducing successive nomination in all deposits, including government savings schemes.

Assam victory & the 3-H model



The verdict of the Assam Assembly elections of 2026 marks a decisive political moment. The Bharatiya Janata Party's return to power for the third consecutive term is not merely an electoral victory, but the consolidation of a distinct political model. This outcome can be best understood through what may be described as the "3H framework" — Himanta, Hindutva in the Assam context, and Holistic Development. These three elements have not operated in isolation. They have worked together to produce a stable and expanding mandate.

At the centre of this framework stands Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma. His leadership has acted as the integrating force between ideology, governance and cultural assertion. Unlike conventional leadership models that rely either on identity politics or welfare delivery, this model combines both. The result is a political structure where narrative and performance reinforce each other.

The first pillar of this framework is ideology, but in a contextualised form. In Assam, Hindutva has not followed a uniform national template. It has been adapted to address specific regional concerns related to identity, land and migration. Historically, these concerns have shaped political mobilisation in the state, particularly during the Assam Agitation. The BJP's narrative of "Jati, Mati, Bheti" gave political expression to these anxieties by linking cultural identity with territorial rights.

What is significant in the period from 2021 to 2026 is the shift from articulation to materialisation. Identity was not left as a rhetorical tool. It was operationalised through governance measures such as land protection initiatives, delimitation exercises and administrative interventions. The delimitation process, in particular, played a crucial role in redefining political representation. It provided a practical framework for addressing the unresolved question of who constitutes the Assamese political community. In this sense, identity moved from being an abstract concept to a lived administrative reality.

The second pillar is holistic development, which has functioned as the most visible dimension of governance. The emphasis has been on delivery, scale and inclusion. Welfare schemes have been designed to reach households directly, ensuring that governance outcomes are experienced at the grassroots level. Programmes such as Orunodoi have provided financial support to vulnerable sections, while initiatives like the Mukhyamantri Mahila Udyamita Abhiyan have aimed to transform beneficiaries into economic participants. These schemes are not merely distributive. They are part of a broader development logic. Direct benefit transfer mechanisms have improved efficiency and transparency. They have also strengthened trust between the state and citizens. Governance, in this model, becomes measurable and visible, reducing the gap between policy formulation and implementation.

At the same time, infrastructure development has complemented welfare delivery. Increased capital expenditure, improved connectivity and investment initiatives such as Advantage Assam 2.0 have expanded the state's economic horizon. The shift from traditional sectors like oil and tea to emerging sectors such as electronics, digital ecosystems and green energy indicates a transition from a limited economic base to a diversified growth model. This transformation has enhanced Assam's investment absorption capacity and repositioned it within the national economic framework.

A notable aspect of this development model is the focus on women and youth as distinct political constituencies. Women-centric schemes have strengthened household stability and increased political participation. Similarly, youth engagement through employment generation, skill development and entrepreneurship has created an aspirational voter base. The fulfilment of large-scale job commitments and the expansion of educational support schemes have contributed to this consolidation. The election consolidated first-time voters in the eulogised adornment of Sarma as "Mama", and created a strong subterranean connect amongst young voters to relate to narratives about building a future-ready Assam.

The third pillar is the pride of the Assamese, which operates at the level of cultural and symbolic politics. Over the past few years, there has been a conscious effort to reposition Assamese heritage within a broader national narrative. Historical figures such as Lachit Borphukan have been elevated to national prominence. Cultural achievements, including the recognition of Assamese as a classical language and the global visibility of heritage sites like the Charaideo Maidams, have reinforced a sense of collective pride.

These initiatives are not merely symbolic. They strengthen cultural consolidation and turn identity into a source of political capital through participatory cultural events like mass Bihu performances.

At the centre of these three pillars is the leadership of Himanta Biswa Sarma. His role has been crucial in translating ideological narratives into governance outcomes and cultural initiatives into political legitimacy. His leadership style combines administrative efficiency with direct public engagement. Regular field visits, rapid decision-making and a strong communication strategy have contributed to the perception of responsiveness. Another important dimension of this leadership is coalition building. The expansion of the BJP's social base through alliances with regional parties has created what may be described as a "rainbow coalition". This has enabled the integration of diverse communities, including tribal groups, into a broader political framework. The party's growing presence in Scheduled Tribe constituencies reflects this structural shift.

The electoral data supports this analysis. The steady increase in seat share, from around 60 seats in 2016 to over 100 in 2026, indicates not just continuity but expansion. This trend is significant because it challenges the conventional pattern of anti-incumbency in Indian state politics. It suggests that when governance delivery, ideological clarity and cultural assertion are aligned, electoral support can deepen over time.

The 2026 verdict, therefore, reflects a reconfigured political compact in Assam. Identity remains a central concern, but it is now stabilised through governance. Development is not treated as a standalone objective but as part of a larger socio-political ecosystem. Cultural assertion bridges the gap between regional pride and national visibility. In conclusion, the Assam election of 2026 demonstrates how a political framework built on the integration of leadership, ideology and development can produce durable outcomes. The "3H framework" offers a useful lens to understand this shift. At its core lies the ability to convert governance into a lived experience, identity into policy and leadership into trust.



Why India needs a stronger eastern maritime gateway



As the conflict in West Asia continues, global shipping routes remain under strain. For India, whose trade depends heavily on the sea, this makes the resilience of maritime routes more important than ever. Nearly 95 per cent of India's trade by volume and around 70 per cent by value moves by sea. In this context, strengthening India's eastern seaboard is not just about expanding port infrastructure. It is also about protecting the reliability of the country's trade and supply chains.

The Bay of Bengal, which connects India with some of the fastest growing economies of the Indo Pacific, is becoming a key corridor for global trade. As India deepens its engagement with Southeast Asia and strengthens connectivity with the Andaman and Nicobar Islands near the Malacca Strait, one of the world's busiest maritime chokepoints, the eastern coast is gaining both economic and strategic relevance.

Within this shift, Andhra Pradesh stands out. With a coastline of nearly 974 kilometres, the second longest in India, the state sits along key shipping routes linking India with Southeast Asia, East Asia and the wider Indo Pacific. Its location

gives it a natural advantage in trade connectivity and maritime logistics.

Andhra Pradesh already anchors one of the most significant port networks on India's eastern coast. Visakhapatnam, Gangavaram, Krishnapatnam and Kakinada handle a large share of bulk cargo, containers, petroleum products and industrial raw materials serving eastern and southern India. These ports support sectors such as steel, cement, fertilisers, seafood exports and energy logistics, while also enabling industrial clusters to grow around them.

India's maritime strategy is increasingly focused on port-led development under the Sagarmala Programme. More than 800 projects worth over 75 lakh crore have been identified under this framework to improve port capacity, connectivity and coastal economic activity. Andhra Pradesh's ongoing port expansion aligns closely with these national priorities.

Three new deep-sea ports will further strengthen this capacity. Mulapeta Port in North Andhra is being developed to support cargo movement along the northern Bay of Bengal and unlock mineral and bulk trade potential. Machilipatnam Port in Central Andhra is emerging as a modern container and bulk gateway supported by improved road and rail connectivity to India's eastern hinterland. Further south, Ramayapatnam Port will add deep-draught capability that can handle larger vessels.

Together, these projects are helping shift India's maritime balance. For years, most container traffic has been concentrated on the



western coast. Expanding capacity along the eastern seaboard reduces pressure on existing ports, diversifies trade routes and improves resilience.

The economic logic is clear. Efficient ports reduce turnaround time, lower freight costs and attract manufacturing investment. When combined with industrial parks and logistics hubs, they become engines of regional growth. Andhra Pradesh has increasingly followed this approach by linking ports with industrial corridors and logistics planning.

There is also a strategic dimension playing out in real time. The ongoing conflict involving Iran,

Israel and the United States is already disrupting key shipping routes and exposing how fragile global trade flows can be. The Strait of Hormuz and the wider Gulf region remain critical for energy and cargo movement.

For India, the implications are direct. Most of its crude oil imports pass through these routes, and a significant share of exports to Europe and West Asia depends on them. Disruptions in these corridors increase costs and reduce reliability.

The impact is already being felt in everyday life. A large share of India's cooking gas travels through the Gulf region and the Strait of Hormuz. When tensions rise and ships avoid these

routes, supplies tighten and prices become volatile. For millions of Indian households, this quickly becomes a kitchen-table issue.

In this context, strengthening the eastern seaboard is not just about growth. It is about creating an alternative. Ports along the Bay of Bengal provide a counterbalance by diversifying India's trade gateways and reducing dependence on any single route.

Connectivity with the Andaman and Nicobar Islands further strengthens this advantage. Located near the Malacca Strait, the islands sit along major global shipping routes linking the Indian Ocean with East Asia. A stronger eastern mainland presence allows India to better use this strategic location.

If India is to achieve its long-term ambition of becoming a 1 trillion dollar merchandise export economy, port capacity and logistics efficiency will be critical. Expanding maritime infrastructure along the eastern coast will play a key role in that effort.

As global trade becomes more uncertain, India will need a more balanced and resilient maritime network. The eastern seaboard will be central to this shift. With its growing network of ports, Andhra Pradesh is well placed to play a leading role in shaping India's maritime future.

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Father-son murder case: Seven sentenced to life imprisonment

A court here has sentenced seven persons to life imprisonment for killing a man and his son here in 2020. District and Sessions Judge Jai Prakash Pandey on Wednesday sentenced the seven and also imposed a fine of ₹1,01,500 each on them, District Government Counsel Priyadarshi Piyush Tripathi said.

Tripathi said that on August 13, 2020, Santra Devi, a resident of Akbelpur Naupur village, had gone to Lalgaon market along with her husband Hiralala and sons Tej Kumar Yadav and Vinod Yadav to buy medicines.

According to the prosecution, when they reached Ghodsahna village, two persons identified as Surendra and Pradeep stopped them and took Hiralal and Tej Kumar Yadav to their house on the pretext of discussing the village head election,

Soon an altercation broke out during which Pradeep and Surendra allegedly shot dead Hiralal. When Tej Kumar tried to flee, he was also shot dead, he said. Both father and son died on the spot, Tripathi added.

He said a chargesheet was filed against eight accused in the case, but one of them, Phenkhu Yadav, died during the trial.

Kerala court sentences man in minor girl rape case

A Kerala court has sentenced a 20-year-old man to 21 years of imprisonment for raping a minor girl after befriending her on a social media app. Karunagappally Fast Track Special Court judge Rajeevan Vachal sentenced the convict to 21 years under the relevant provisions of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, special public prosecutor (SPP) NC Premchandran said.

The court also imposed a fine of ₹1.1 lakh on the convict, the prosecutor said.

The incident occurred in 2024 when the accused befriended her on a social media app and then offered to take her to the Azheekal beach here.

However, instead of taking her to the beach, he took her to an isolated place behind the CHC hospital at Mynagappally here and raped her, the SPP said.

Following the incident, the girl attempted suicide, but was saved and then told the doctors what had happened, the prosecutor said.

The hospital authorities informed the police, who registered a case and launched an investigation.

The prosecutor said that seven witnesses were examined and 20 documents were submitted before the court to substantiate the guilt of the accused.

Did not sing 2006 track ‘Vol 1’: Honey Singh tells Delhi HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Rapper Yo Yo Honey Singh on Thursday told the Delhi High Court that he did not sing the “vulgar” 2006 track, ‘Vol 1’, allegedly released by him and Badshah under their collaboration ‘Mafia Mundeer’.

“This is an opportunity for me to make sure that this stigma goes because this is not mine. This is position we have taken — I am here to assist the court to make sure this content goes off — I have gone public to say that this is not something I have sung,” Singh’s counsel told Justice Purushendra Kumar Kaurav, who was hearing a petition



by Hindu Shakti Dal seeking removal of the song from online platforms.

The senior lawyer informed the court that proceedings in relation to the track were also pending



Consumers not to pay for service not received: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday said consumers cannot be required to pay for a service which they no longer received, and tariff determination is not merely a mathematical exercise but a regulatory balancing act.

The apex court set aside a February last year order of the Appellate Tribunal for Electricity (APTEL) which had directed that entire capital cost of Rithala Combined Cycle Power Plant in Delhi be permitted to be recovered through depreciation over a period of 15 years.

A bench of Justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhe delivered its judgement on an

appeal by the Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission (DERC) challenging the APTEL’s order.

“The tariff determination is not merely a mathematical exercise but a regulatory balancing act. The object of enabling reasonable cost recovery for utilities must be weighed against and calibrated with, paramount obligation to safeguard consumer interest,” the bench said.

It said in this case, admittedly, electricity was not supplied to consumers beyond March 2018.

“The consumers cannot be required to pay for a service which they no longer received,” the top court said.

It said under the Power Purchase Agreement (PPA),



the Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (TPDDL) had to supply electricity only for a period of six years.

The bench noted that Section 61 of the Electricity Act, 2003, governs the determination of tariff and Section 61(d) specifically provides that in

specifying the terms and conditions for the determination of tariff, the appropriate commission shall be guided by the object of safeguarding consumers’ interests and at the same time, recovery of the cost of electricity in a reasonable manner.

Questioning religious practices will break religion, civilisation: SC in Dawoodi Bohras case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday remarked that if individuals start questioning certain religious practices or matters of religion before a constitutional court then there will be hundreds of petitions questioning different rituals, leading to the breaking of religions and the civilisation.

The nine-judge Constitution bench is hearing petitions related to discrimination against women at religious places, including the Sabarimala temple in Kerala, and on the ambit and scope of the religious freedom practised by multiple faiths, including Dawoodi Bohras.

The bench comprises Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and Justices BV Nagarathna, MM Sundresh, Ahsanuddin Amanullah, Aravind Kumar, Augustine George Masih, Prasanna B Varale, R Mahadevan and Joymalya Bagchi. The Central Board of Dawoodi Bohra Community filed a PIL in 1986 seeking the setting aside of a 1962 judgment, which had struck down the Bombay Prevention of Excommunication Act, 1949 — this law made excommunication of any community member illegal.

The 1962 Constitution bench judgment said, “It is evident from the religious faith and tenets of the Dawoodi Bohra community that the exercise of the power of excommunication by its religious head on religious grounds formed part of the management of its affairs in matters of religion and the 1949 Act in making even such excommunication invalid,



infringed the right of the community under Article 26(b) of the Constitution.”

Senior advocate Raju Ramchandran, representing a group of reformist Dawoodi Bohras, submitted that a practice which is conducted in response to secular and social actions of an individual cannot be the subject of Constitutional protection under Article 25 of the Constitution and consequently cannot be a ‘matter of religion’ under Article 26 of the Constitution.

Ramchandran told the court that a practice which may have a religious aspect but also significantly and adversely impacts fundamental rights is not immune to restriction under Article 25 of the Constitution or Article 26 of the Constitution.

Responding to the submission, Justice Nagarathna said that if everybody starts questioning certain religious practices or matters of religion before a constitutional court, then “what happens to this civilisation where religion is so intimately connected with the Indian society”.

“There will be hundreds of petitions questioning this right that right, opening of the temple, and the closure of the temple. We are conscious of this,” she said.

Allahabad High Court judge recuses from hearing contempt case against Swami Avimukteshwaranand

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Prayagraj

A Judge of the Allahabad High Court has recused himself from hearing a contempt petition filed against Swami Avimukteshwaranand, alleging disobedience of a court order in a POCSO case registered in Prayagraj.

On Wednesday, when the matter came up before the court, Justice Rohit Ranjan Agarwal said that he did not want to hear the matter. “Lay before another bench after obtaining nomination from Hon’ble the Chief Justice as fresh,” he said. The contempt petition was filed against Swami Avimukteshwaranand



and others, alleging disobedience of the court order passed on March 25 while granting anticipatory bail to Avimukteshwaranand.

The matter will now come before another judge after nomination by the

Chief Justice. In the contempt application, filed by Ashutosh Brahmachari Maharaj, it was alleged that in spite of the High Court order, Avimukteshwaranand held several meetings and made statements.

As part of the conditions of the anticipatory bail, the court had warned the applicants from tampering with evidence, and ordered the accused to appear before the trial court on the date fixed unless exempted.

The court said that the applicants shall not make any inducement, threat or promise to any person acquainted with the facts of the case, or dissuade them from disclosing such facts to the court or to any police officer.

High Court refuses urgent hearing on plea against Tata Trusts May 8 board meeting

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Bombay High Court on Thursday refused urgent hearing on a plea, which sought an injunction order against the May 8 board meeting of the Sir Ratan Tata Trust claiming that the trust was in violation of the provisions of law.

The petition, filed by a 61-year-old Thane resident Suresh Patilkhede, also sought a restraining order on the trustees of the trust from passing or implementing any decision arising out of or connected with its proposed board meeting to be held on Friday.

The plea was mentioned on Thursday before a bench of Chief Justice Shree Chandrashekhar and Justice Gautam Ankhad seeking urgent hearing. The court, however, refused and said the petitioner was at liberty to move the court’s vacation



bench. The High Court closes for summer vacation from Saturday.

In his plea, Patilkhede sought directions from the court to reconstitute the trust’s board, alleging that the premier public charitable trust was in clear and continuing violation of a 2025 amendment to the Maharashtra Public Trusts Act that caps the number of life trustees.

As per this amendment, if a trust’s original documents do not specifically allow permanent or “life trustees”, then such trustees cannot

make up more than one-fourth of the total board members. The plea claimed that under the usage and practice of the Trust, out of a total of six trustees, three perpetual trustees (also referred to as life trustees or trustees for life) were appointed between 1989 and 2019.

The petitioner added that, at present, the Trust has six trustees, including Jimmy Naval Tata, Jehangir HC Jehangir, Noel Naval Tata, Venu Srinivasan, Vijay Singh, and senior advocate Darius Khambata.

Of these, three are continuing as life trustees, he claimed, adding that this was “contrary to the mandatory statutory limit” on the number of life trustees.

It further claimed that the proposed meeting was unlawful as the instrument of the trust does not provide for the appointment of life trustees.

Husband can’t evade duty to maintain family: Delhi Court

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has upheld an interim maintenance order directing a man to pay ₹7,500 per month to his estranged wife and minor daughter in a domestic violence case, saying that an able-bodied husband cannot evade his legal obligation to maintain his family by concealing his income.

Additional Sessions Judge Sheetal Chaudhary Pradhan dismissed the husband’s appeal against a trial court order passed under the Protection of Women from Domestic Violence Act, 2005.

“I am of the considered view that it is for the appellant/husband to manage his expenses and merely giving the details of expenses by him and the ground that he has the responsibility of his mother does not absolve him from maintaining his legally wedded wife,” the court said.

Rani Kapur-Priya Kapur dispute: Ex-CJI DY Chandrachud appointed as mediator

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday appointed former Chief Justice of India DY Chandrachud to act as a mediator in the dispute between late industrialist Sunjay Kapur’s mother Rani Kapur and his wife Priya Kapur over the family trust.

Asking the parties to participate in the mediation proceedings with an open mind, the apex court said they may not make any statements in the public and also not go on social media about the dispute.

“It is a family dispute. Let it be confined among the family only. It should not be a source of entertainment,” a bench of Justices JB Pardiwala and Ujjal Bhuyan said.

The bench observed that having regard to the nature of the dispute among the family members, it had suggested on April 27 that the parties should consider going for mediation.

“Today, all the counsel appearing for the respective parties have very graciously agreed to go for mediation. In such circumstances referred to above, we appoint DY Chandrachud, former Chief Justice of India, to act as a mediator,” the bench said. “We shall await for a preliminary report from the mediator and thereafter proceed further with the



matter,” the bench said and posted the matter for August. It said the fees of the mediator and other modalities shall be fixed in consultation with the parties.

It directed the parties to get in touch with the mediator.

The bench made it clear that the mediation would be confined only so far as the family members were concerned.

“This being a family affair, the endeavour on their part should be to get the dispute resolved at the earliest and put an end to the entire matter. We firmly believe that all parties should participate in the mediation proceedings with an open mind,” it said.

The bench said it will be in the interest of one and all if they are able to resolve the matter before the mediator, otherwise this is going to be a “long drawn litigation”.

It said the mediation would be confined to the

present matter. On April 27, the top court sought a response from Priya Kapur and others on a lawsuit by Sanjay Kapur’s mother seeking directions to declare the family trust “null and void”.

The bench had issued notice to Priya Kapur and others on the plea filed by the 80-year-old Rani Kapur alleging that the trust, which was constituted in her name in October 2017, was a product of “forged, fabricated and fraudulent” documents.

The legal proceedings over control of the estate and assets are pending before the Delhi High Court and the petition before the top court seeks a status quo on alienation of all the properties of the trust.

During the hearing on April 27, the top court asked the parties in the dispute over the Sona Group Family Trust to explore mediation.

Court acquits Thane man accused of stepson’s murder

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thane

A Thane court has acquitted a man accused of killing his 4-year-old stepson, noting that the prosecution failed to establish the chain of circumstances to prove the guilt of the accused beyond a reasonable doubt.

Sessions Judge SB Agrawal, in the order passed on Tuesday, also highlighted contradictions in the testimonies of the prosecution’s witnesses.

The court directed that Mohammed Dilshad Mohammed Imran (25), who has been in custody since his arrest on July 30, 2024, be set free forthwith if not required in any other case.

According to the prosecution, the man allegedly throttled his wife’s son, born from her previous relationship,

in a flat on Ghodbunder Road in the Manpada area of Maharashtra’s Thane city on July 28, 2024, following a dispute over the child’s identity.

The police initially registered an Accidental Death Report (ADR) after the man took the child to the hospital, claiming he had suffered a fall due to giddiness induced by epilepsy.

However, following the post-mortem examination, a First Information Report (FIR) was registered against the man under Section 103(1) (murder) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

The court said the prosecution’s case was based on circumstantial evidence, but there was no direct witness who had seen the accused assaulting the victim.

“In a case based on the circumstantial evidence, it is imperative for



the prosecution to prove each and every fact that forms a chain of circumstances, which leads to the only conclusion of the guilt of the accused,” it noted.

The autopsy noted multiple injuries on the victim, but it was not made out that all the injuries were fresh. On the contrary, the doctor had opined that

some of them were earlier injuries. Even otherwise, in the absence of other material, mere medical opinion would not be sufficient to bring home the guilt of the accused, the court opined.

The prosecution’s claim that the accused offered a false explanation is also not made out, since he has contended that the victim had suffered an epilepsy attack and had fallen because of the same, it noted.

The conduct of the accused also does not seem to be suspicious, as he immediately called the neighbour and took the victim to the hospital, the court said.

Surprisingly, neither the neighbour nor the hospital staff (who attended the victim) have been examined by the prosecution, it pointed out.

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India represents dynamic opportunities, says Walmart CEO

India represents one of the most dynamic opportunities in global commerce, from where it has sourced goods worth \$40 billion so far, said US-based retail giant Walmart Inc President and CEO John Furner.

Walmart, which had earlier announced to source goods from India worth up to \$10 billion per year by 2027, is focusing on strengthening entrepreneur and supplier capabilities.

“We have already sourced more than \$40 billion in goods from India and are focused on strengthening entrepreneur and supplier capabilities, raising compliance and quality standards, and helping scale manufacturing so more Indian businesses are ready to export,” said Walmart Inc President and CEO John Furner.

Under its Vridhhi initiative, which is designed to support MSMEs in modernising, expanding, and reaching their domestic ambitions, the company has supported the growth of over 1.15 lakh entrepreneurs.

It is helping them to raise their compliance and quality standards, and to scale manufacturing so more Indian businesses are ready to export, according to a statement issued by Walmart India.

Gold, silver advance on weak dollar amid US-Iran peace hopes

Gold prices rose further by ₹600 to ₹1.56 lakh per 10 grams in the local market here on Thursday, following a pullback in the US dollar and easing crude oil prices amid hopes for a US-Iran peace deal.

Silver prices jumped by ₹7,000 to ₹2,61,500 per kg on improved industrial demand, marking the fourth straight day of gains, according to the All India Sarafa Association.

Gold of 99.9 per cent purity gained ₹600 to ₹1,56,000 per 10 grams (inclusive of all taxes) from the previous close of ₹1,55,400 per 10 grams. The metal had jumped ₹2,900 per 10 grams on Wednesday.

Gold of 99.5 per cent purity traded at ₹1,55,200 per 10 grams, according to the association.

Silver prices also advanced for the fourth consecutive day, surging by ₹7,000 to ₹2,61,500 per kg from the last close of ₹2,54,500 per kg (inclusive of all taxes). The white metal had gained ₹3,500 in the previous session.

“Gold extended its gains on Thursday as optimism around a potential US-Iran agreement continued to support sentiment across precious metals,” Saumil Gandhi, Senior Analyst — Commodities at HDFC Securities, said.

“Ongoing weakness in the US dollar drove additional support for precious metals. The dollar index traded below the 98 level. The pullback in the US dollar, influenced by market speculation regarding a potential US-Iran agreement to resolve the conflict, creates opportunities for easing monetary policy,” Gandhi added.

Govt extends subsidy scheme for companies flagging merchant ships

The shipping ministry on Thursday extended the scheme for providing subsidies to Indian companies flagging merchant ships in India for five years until the financial year 2023-31.

The scheme for the promotion of flagging of merchant ships in India has been extended for a further period of five years, till FY 2030-31, reinforcing India’s commitment to strengthening its maritime fleet and global shipping presence, the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways said in a statement. In order to achieve the objective of Atmanirbhar Bharat, the Union Cabinet, in July 2021, approved a scheme with an outlay of ₹1,624 crore over five years for providing a subsidy to Indian shipping companies bidding for global tenders floated by ministries and central public sector enterprises for imports of Government cargoes.

The scheme was announced by Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman during her budget speech for FY22.

According to the scheme, for a ship flagged in India after February 1, 2021, which is less than 10 years old at the time of flagging, a subsidy is given at 15 per cent of the quote offered by the lowest bidding foreign company (LI), or the actual difference between the quote offered by the Indian-flagged vessel exercising Right of First Refusal (ROFR) and the quote offered by the LI foreign company, whichever is less.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | MAY 8, 2026

Stock markets end lower in choppy trade; Sensex declines 114 points

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Benchmark indices ended lower in a choppy trade on Thursday, with the Sensex declining 114 points, as investors turned cautious amid unabated foreign fund outflows and rising geopolitical uncertainties.

After facing heavy fluctuations during the day, the 30-share BSE Sensex ended 114 points or 0.15 per cent lower at 77,844.52. During the session, the benchmark hit a high of 78,384.70 and a low of 77,713.21, gyrating 671.49 points.

The 50-share NSE Nifty dipped 4.30 points, or 0.02 per cent, to end at 24,326.65.

“Indian markets remained volatile throughout the session, with the Nifty closing flat at 24,326, amid continued Foreign Institutional Investor outflows, crude oil prices sustaining around \$100 per barrel, rupee weakness and uncertainty surrounding Iran’s response to the proposed negotiation terms,” Siddhartha Khemka - Head of Research, Wealth Management, Motilal Oswal Financial Services Ltd, said.

From the Sensex firms, Hindustan Unilever, Tata

Consultancy Services, Tech Mahindra, Titan, Sun Pharma and ITC were among the major laggards.

On the other hand, Mahindra & Mahindra, NTPC, Kotak Mahindra Bank and Tata Steel were among the winners.

The BSE MidCap Select index jumped 1.40 per cent, and the SmallCap Select index climbed 1.09 per cent.

Sectorally, Focused IT fell 0.76 per cent, PSU Bank (0.54 per cent), Consumer Durables (0.52 per cent), FMCG (0.45 per cent), Energy (0.11 per cent), Capital Goods jumped 2.05 per cent, Power (1.23 per cent), Auto (1.81 per cent), Industrials

(1.69 per cent), Power (1.23 per cent) and Realty (0.88 per cent).

“The positive undertone was primarily driven by a sharp cooling in crude oil prices amid optimism surrounding a potential US-Iran peace agreement. Stability in the rupee, improving global sentiment, and continued buying interest in select earnings-driven counters further supported the move.

“However, persistent geopolitical uncertainty and cautious institutional positioning ahead of key developments kept the upside in check,” Ajit Mishra, SVP, Research, Religare Broking

CAG conducting special audit of 101 cities to assess ease of living: Murthy

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

India is conducting a special audit of 101 cities to assess ease of living from the citizen’s perspective, Comptroller and Auditor General K Sanjay Murthy said on Thursday.

In his inaugural address at the 5th BRICS Supreme Audit Institutions (SAI) Leaders’ Summit here, Murthy also said the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) of India is auditing multi-modal transport and first-mile, last-mile logistics, in partnership with institutions like the Indian Institute of Technology and Indian Institute of Management, and the World Bank.

India is hosting the three-day summit under the overarching theme ‘Ease of Living with a Focus on Urban Mobility’.

Convened during India’s year of BRICS Chairmanship 2026 by the Office of the CAG, the summit brings together 42 delegates, including Heads of SAIs from BRICS member countries, to deliberate on audit themes of shared relevance, exchange best practices, and strengthen public financial oversight.

“There is something particularly fitting about gathering here in the city that India calls both its Silicon Valley and its Garden City.

“A city that writes the software powering the world’s most advanced enterprises, and where, on the very same morning, a nurse boards an overcrowded bus for a ninety-minute commute to save lives that software cannot reach. Bengaluru, in that way, is not just a host city. It is the living argument for why this summit matters,” Murthy said.

He said Indian cities today occupy just 3 per cent of the country’s land, yet they contribute

60 per cent of the national GDP. By 2030, 70 per cent of all new jobs in India will be created in cities. “Urban mobility is where governance stops being abstract and starts being personal. It is the daily referendum that citizens conduct on their Governments, not at the ballot box, but at the bus stop,” he noted.

Global congestion indices have risen from 20 per cent to 25 per cent as of 2025, costing each urban commuter between 100 and 180 hours of productive time every year.

“And yet, the solutions are not unknown,” the CAG said, adding that the barrier is governance. He further said the urban mobility fails not for want of roads or rails, but for want of systems that work together.

“We build metro lines that don’t connect to bus networks. We build flyovers that merely shift congestion. We measure outputs, kilometres of road laid, stations built, rather than outcomes: did commute times fall? Did air quality improve? Did inequality in access reduce?” he added.

NITI Aayog proposes State, district task forces to improve quality of schools

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Government think tank NITI Aayog has pitched for setting up state and district task forces and integrating AI for pedagogical innovation to improve the quality of schools in the country.

In the report ‘School Education System in India: Temporal Analysis and Policy Roadmap for Quality Enhancement’, the Aayog has given 13 recommendations to improve quality of schools.

The five academic recommendations focus on transforming pedagogy, assessment, and foundational learning; emphasising holistic education and student wellbeing; re-imagining vocational education and skill integration; strengthening Early Childhood Care and Education (ECCE); and integrating AI for pedagogical innovation.

Besides, the eight systemic recommendations include reforming school structure through composite schools and evidence-based rationalisation, strengthening school infrastructure, undertaking governance reform and administrative capacity building, institutionalising a

whole-of-society approach through State and District Task Forces on School Quality, strengthening school management committees. Elevating teacher deployment and professional development, expanding digital and broadcast-based learning, and promoting equity and inclusion are the other systemic recommendations of the Aayog.

India’s school education system spans 14.71 lakh schools, serving over 24.69 crore students, making it the largest system in the world.

Reflecting on the progress achieved over the past decade, the report presented a comprehensive analysis across key dimensions of access, infrastructure, equity, inclusion, digital integration, and learning outcomes for all 36 states and UTs.

Infra projects driving UP’s property market: UP-RERA

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Uttar Pradesh’s real estate regulatory authority UP-RERA is likely to sanction 400 new projects during 2026 as against 308 in the last calendar year as the property market is growing across the state driven by improvement in infrastructure, its Chairman Sanjay R Bhoosreddy said on Thursday.

Addressing a real estate summit organised by industry body Ficci, Bhoosreddy, the Chairman of Real Estate Regulatory Authority, Uttar Pradesh, highlighted that the property market in UP is now

just not limited to Lucknow, Noida, Greater Noida, and Ghaziabad.

Real estate activities have picked up in other cities like Kanpur, Gorakhpur, Varanasi, Ayodhya, Jhansi, Hapur,

Rupee rises 23 paise to close at 94.26 against US dollar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The rupee pared initial losses and settled for the day on a positive note, higher by 23 paise at 94.26 (provisional) against the greenback on Thursday, as Brent crude and the US dollar index retreated from their elevated levels.

Forex traders said Brent oil prices have fallen below \$100 per barrel on a rise in investor risk appetite in global markets on hopes of peace between the US and Iran. However, factors such as unabated foreign capital outflows and safe-haven dollar demand from importers capped sharp gains for the rupee.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee witnessed high volatility. It opened at 94.77 against the US dollar, registering a fall of 28 paise over its previous close. In intraday trade, the USD/INR pair touched an intraday low of 94.90 and a high of 94.08 against the American currency.

The rupee finally settled at 94.26 (provisional), registering a rise of 23 paise over its previous close.

On Wednesday, the rupee appreciated 69 paise to close

at 94.49 against the US dollar. “We expect the rupee to trade with a positive bias on improved global risk sentiments amid easing tensions between the US and Iran and softening of global crude oil prices. A decline in the US dollar may also support the rupee.

“However, dollar demand from importers and FII outflows may cap sharp gains. USD/INR spot price is expected to trade in a range of 93.80 to 94.40,” said Anuj Choudhary, Research analyst at Mirae Asset ShareKhan.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback’s strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 97.86, down 0.16 per cent.

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Union Minister Mansukh Mandaviya on Thursday launched a nationwide free annual health check-up initiative for all workers aged 40 and above.

Addressing the gathering at ESIC Medical College & Hospital in Delhi, Mandaviya said the implementation of the four Labour Codes reflects Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s guarantee of ensuring dignity, welfare and social security for workers across the country.

Calling the occasion a day dedicated to the honour of ‘Shram Shakti’, the Labour and Employment Minister said the Government is committed to strengthening social security coverage for all workers.

He highlighted that under the leadership of Prime Minister Modi, the Government has worked over the last 12 years to empower “Shram Shakti” and “Yuva Shakti” through employment generation and welfare measures.

He said that social security coverage in the country has expanded significantly from nearly 30 crore people a

decade ago to around 94 crore beneficiaries today, increasing from 19 per cent to 64 per cent.

He further stated that ESIC coverage has increased from around 7 crore beneficiaries a decade ago to nearly 15 crore beneficiaries today.

Launching the initiative, Mandaviya said that free health check-ups for all workers above 40 years of age will now be conducted yearly across the country.

Early detection through health screenings can help prevent serious diseases, and treatment and medicines identified during the camps will be provided through ESIC facilities, he added.

Highlighting key labour reforms under the four

Labour Codes, the minister said that provisions for equal wages for men and women workers have been ensured, maternity leave has been increased from 12 weeks to 26 weeks, and work-from-home provisions for women have also been incorporated.

While countries across the world are still exploring ways to bring gig and platform workers under social security frameworks, the Modi Government has proactively ensured their inclusion through the new Labour Codes, he pointed out.

Mandaviya added that workers engaged in hazardous occupations and employees working even in establishments with fewer than 10 workers are now being brought under ESIC coverage.

He also stated that while workers earlier remained neglected and unheard, the present Government has ensured that their concerns are being addressed with commitment and sensitivity.

The nationwide health check-up initiative is another important endeavour aimed at ensuring dignity, protection and better healthcare outcomes for the country’s workforce, he added.

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Alcoholic beverage makers have sought a reasonable price hike from state Governments to deal with pressures arising out of rising can and bottle costs due to supply chain disruptions triggered by the West Asia crisis.

Confederation of Indian Alcoholic Beverage Companies (CIABC) and the Brewers Association of India (BAI) have urged states to allow revisions of IMFL (Indian Made Foreign Liquor), wine and beer products and provide interim relief measures to help manufacturers cope with rising production costs.

BAI has asked state Governments to allow suppliers a price increase of 15-20 per cent to partially offset the impact of rising input costs.

increased by almost 100 per cent, and materials such as LDPE, BOPP and adhesives have become costlier by 20-25 per cent,” Giri said.

Severe shortage of commercial LNG supply has put glass bottle manufacturers under significant strain, and they too face partial or full shutdowns. “Supply of glass and cans may be severely strained in the coming months and even years,” BAI said.

Moreover, the beer industry, which is also facing issues with the supply of cans, sees it prolonging due to rising aluminium costs. “Aluminium supplies from the Middle East have been badly hit, and suppliers have warned that prolonged disruption risks not only output but also a shutdown of manufacturing plants,” said Giri.

British Prime Minister Keir Starmer's leadership is on the line as millions turn out to vote in key local and devolved parliamentary elections across the UK on Thursday. The biggest polls since the UK general election in 2024 are being pitched as a stress test of Starmer's hold as leader of the Labour Party, the governing party that is lagging behind smaller parties in pre-poll surveys.

India reaffirms position on Indus, Teesta waters treaty

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India has reiterated its firm stance on the Indus Waters Treaty while also emphasising continued cooperation with neighbouring countries on water-sharing issues. Responding to media queries, an MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal stated that the Indus Waters Treaty remains in abeyance due to Pakistan's continued sponsorship of cross-border terrorism.

The MEA spokesperson noted that India's position on the treaty is consistent and linked directly to security concerns arising from terrorism emanating across the border. Stressing the need for accountability, he said

Rubio visits Vatican after Trump's Pope criticism

**NICOLE WINFIELD/
MATTHEW LEE**
■ Vatican City

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio made a fence-mending visit to the Vatican on Thursday to underscore strong bilateral ties, after President Donald Trump's broadsides against Pope Leo XIV for his opposition to the Iran war angered the Holy See and sparked ongoing sparring between them.

The US State Department said that the meetings with Leo and the Vatican's top diplomat covered peace in the West Asia and "underscored the strong relationship between the United States and the Holy See", and reflected the "enduring partnership" between them.



MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal

Pakistan must "credibly and irrevocably" renounce its support for cross-border terrorism for meaningful progress to take place. The remarks come amid ongoing tensions between the two countries, where

diplomatic and bilateral engagements have often been affected by security-related concerns.

India has repeatedly maintained that terrorism and dialogue cannot go hand in hand, and the latest state-

ment reinforces that position. On a separate issue concerning regional water cooperation, the spokesperson addressed the Teesta river project and India's engagement with Bangladesh on water-sharing matters.

He highlighted that India and Bangladesh share 54 rivers, making water management a significant aspect of bilateral relations between the two neighbours.

According to the MEA spokesperson, both countries have established structured bilateral mechanisms to discuss water-related issues. These mechanisms continue to function regularly, reflecting the commitment of both sides to maintaining dialogue and cooperation on shared

The statements underline India's dual approach in regional diplomacy — maintaining a tough position on issues related to national security while continuing constructive engagement with neighbouring countries on development and resource-sharing initiatives.

Passengers leave cruise ship after hantavirus death reported

ASSOCIATED PRESS
 The Hague

More than two dozen passengers from at least 12 different countries left a cruise ship hit by a deadly hantavirus outbreak on April 24 without contact tracing, nearly two weeks after the first passenger died on board, the ship operator and Dutch officials said on Thursday.

The news raised concerns that the virus could spread as travellers returned home, although experts say the risk to the wider public is considered low as hantavirus isn't easily transmitted between people. Even so, the Dutch health ministry said a woman who was not on the ship was



Medics escort a patient evacuated from the MV Hondius cruise ship

being tested for hantavirus and being kept in an isolated ward in an Amsterdam hospital after showing symptoms. The woman was part of a flight crew and had contact with an infected passenger on the plane, it said. If the woman tests positive, she could be the

Health authorities were not monitoring people or trying to trace others who may have come into contact with the cruise passengers on at least four continents.



অসম লোকসেৱা আয়োগ

ASSAM PUBLIC SERVICE COMMISSION

Jawaharnagar, Khanapara, Guwahati-781022.

No.294PSC/Sty-2/2021 -2022

NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER

E-tenders are invited by the undersigned through e-procurement system i.e. www.assamtenders.gov.in in two bid systems from eligible Agencies/Firms having adequate experience and credential in the concerned fields of work, for all the items mentioned below for entering into a contract for meeting the Commission's requirements for a period of one year, extendable for another one year on satisfactory performance basis from the date of award of Contract .

Item	Scope of Works
A.	Printing & Supply of OMR Answer Sheets with Barcodes microline and water mark, (Single Layer), readable on OMR System, in the format (Specifications & Design) to be decided by the Commission.
B.	Printing & Supply of Carbonless OMR (1 + 1 Tear off) i.e. in two parts A4 size, Top copy printed in 100-110 GSM paper and bottom copy printed in 50-60 GSM paper with Barcodes microline and water mark, readable on OMR System, in the format (Specifications & Design) to be decided by the Commission.
C.	Scanning of used OMR Answer sheets and result processing at the office of the APSC

The item either A or B shall be ordered one at a time as per requirement and decision of the Commission.

Important dates of the tender:

Sl. NO.	Scheduled	Start date	Start time	End date	End time
1.	Tender publishing	05-05-2026	05:00 PM	NA	NA
2.	Tender download	05-05-2026	05:00 PM	28-05-2026	1 1:00 AM
3.	Pre-Bid Meeting	12-05-2026	At 1:00 P.M	Venue- APSC Office Khanapara, Guwahati-22	
4.	Bid submission	18-05-2026	10:00 AM	28-05-2026	1 1:30 AM
5.	Bid opening (Technical)	28-05-2026	02:00 PM	NA	NA

Tender documents may be downloaded from the official website [https://assamtenders.gov.in](http://www.assamtenders.gov.in). The bidders would be required to register in the website for submission of the bids .The bidders are required to have Digital Signature Certificate (DSC) of Class-III (only Signing) from any of the Certifying Authorities. Aspiring bidders who have not obtained the user ID and password for participating in e-procurement may obtain the same by registering in the www.assamtenders.gov.in. The requirements to register with the e- procurement portal are available on the website indicated above.

All other relevant information and the detailed Bid documents are available on website www.assamtenders.gov.in

Sd/-
Secretary
Assam Public Service Commission
Jawaharnagar, Khanapara, Guwahati-22

DIPR/C/PIO/2/8-May-26

PUBLIC NOTICE FOR - AUCTION OF PLEDGED ASSETS BEING GOLD ORNAMENTS					
The Borrowers, in specific and the public in general are here by notified that public auction of the gold ornaments pledge in the below accounts is proposed to be conducted by the Axis Bank at the below mentioned Branch. That the below mentioned Borrowers has availed the credit facility from the Axis Bank Limited against the pledge of gold ornaments ("Gold Loan Facility") in favour of the Bank towards the security. The Demand notices were issued to the Borrowers/Guarantors calling up the Borrowers/Guarantors to pay their outstanding amount towards the Gold loan facility availed. As the Borrowers/Guarantors have failed to repay the outstanding loan amount, the bank is constrained to invoke the pledge and proposed to conduct an auction sale of pledged gold ornaments more particularly described in schedule of property hereunder on 08-06-2026 at 11:00 AM on "As In Where Is", "As Is What Is", "Whatever There Is" and "No Recourse Basis". Auction will be held at					
DETAILS OF BORROWERS AND OUTSTANDING AMOUNT					
Customer Name	Loan A/c No.	Amount Outstanding (₹)	Date of Recall Notice	Gross Weight	Net Weight
B.O.: FARIDABAD [HR]					
HARJEET KAUR	XXXXXXXXXXXX4629	₹14,68,645.80	12-02-2026	355.500	341.400
HARENDER KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX2137	₹3,17,811.00	02-04-2026	46.500	36.300
NARESH KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX6925	₹1,54,833.00	09-02-2026	29.100	27.000
KULDPEE .	XXXXXXXXXXXX9870	₹54,094.00	19-12-2025	10.200	9.300
JUN GOGAI	XXXXXXXXXXXX9872	₹49,646.06	12-12-2025	20.600	18.400
PREM WATI	XXXXXXXXXXXX2088	₹94,903.00	24-01-2022	11.100	10.600
B.O.: GHAZIABAD [UP]					
POONAM.	XXXXXXXXXXXX5615	₹25,80,633.14	13-04-2026	351.600	331.700
PUSHPENDRA	XXXXXXXXXXXX5185	₹14,33,704.00	02-04-2026	194.900	171.200
NADEEM .	XXXXXXXXXXXX0158	₹7,49,511.00	18-04-2026	88.600	84.700
SUMIT NAGAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX8773	₹61,678.00	09-02-2026	14.800	13.900
B.O.: GREATER NOIDA [UP]					
RAHUL SINGH	XXXXXXXXXXXX7416	₹27,31,364.99	10-12-2025	368.700	357.500
PIYUSH SHARMA	XXXXXXXXXXXX4866	₹2,60,185.00	02-04-2026	35.600	33.300
NITIN KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX1569	₹2,56,659.00	02-04-2026	34.400	26.600
GAURAV SINGH	XXXXXXXXXXXX1931	₹1,29,396.00	10-01-2026	21.800	20.750
B.O.: HATYAPUR GUR HR					
PINKI	XXXXXXXXXXXX6279	₹18,49,006.04	19-12-2025	476.600	370.600
POONAM RASTOGI	XXXXXXXXXXXX7646	₹6,00,112.11	13-04-2026	64.100	61.500
SIDDHARTH .	XXXXXXXXXXXX2939	₹51,371.00	27-09-2024	10.800	10.100
B.O.: PUSHPVIHAR, DELHI [DL]					
PUNEET KUMAR GUPTA	XXXXXXXXXXXX1521	₹30,69,418.13	02-04-2026	380.700	359.600
ASHNA NAYIR	XXXXXXXXXXXX0336	₹9,44,119.00	09-02-2026	129.400	116.950
ABHISHEK KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX1932	₹1,58,694.00	10-12-2025	25.600	23.600
ABHISHEK KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX2277	₹1,05,651.00	10-12-2025	17.300	16.800
B.O.: R K MISSION, NEW DELHI [DL]					
MAYANK ARORA	XXXXXXXXXXXX0833	₹23,83,176.29	19-12-2025	550.070	518.700
VIKAS KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX0936	₹8,84,435.33	09-02-2026	157.590	145.090
B.O.: SECTOR 10A, GURGAON [HR]					
ROCKY YADAV	XXXXXXXXXXXX9481	₹29,67,213.00	02-04-2026	565.000	502.000
ASHOK KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX6828	₹1,31,287.00	13-04-2026	15.900	15.000
SAHIL	XXXXXXXXXXXX0789	₹63,314.00	10-12-2025	10.300	9.700
B.O.: SECTOR 16, FARIDABAD [HR]					
GYANVEER SINGH	XXXXXXXXXXXX4246	₹19,16,893.05	02-04-2026	226.830	203.670
SAKSHI VERMA	XXXXXXXXXXXX7591	₹52,993.00	02-04-2026	102.500	97.250
B.O.: SHALIMAR BAGH, DELHI [DL]					
NEERAJ BHORIYA	XXXXXXXXXXXX7040	₹13,76,295.30	16-11-2025	251.100	234.100
KAPIL KUMAR SINGH	XXXXXXXXXXXX1575	₹11,73,086.00	26-02-2026	338.300	305.000
RUCHI SULTANIA	XXXXXXXXXXXX7468	₹9,82,839.40	14-10-2025	282.000	257.400
MANISH KUMAR AGIWAL	XXXXXXXXXXXX7497	₹1,19,565.34	02-04-2026	51.000	47.300
B.O.: SWASTHYA VIHAR, NEW DELHI [DL]					
ISTIAK AHMAD	XXXXXXXXXXXX2451	₹9,67,626.23	18-04-2026	88.500	85.800
MOHD JAVED	XXXXXXXXXXXX2447	₹9,89,236.74	09-03-2026	127.	

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that my clients have agreed to purchase the **Entire Property No. J-4/31-B, situated at DDA Janta Flats Kalkaji New Delhi-110019**. It has been brought to my notice that Eight Legal Heirs of Original Aliotee were brought forward during the execution of Relinquishment Deed in favor of the current Seller, in furtherance of which Conveyance Deed was executed in DDA in the name of current Seller. Any person, bank, or financial institution having any claim, right, title, interest, or objection against the said property by way of inheritance, mortgage, gift, lien, or otherwise is requested to notify the undersigned in writing with supporting evidence within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice. If no objection is received, the sale will be finalized and it shall be presumed that no such claim exists.

ACHIN SHARMA (ADVOCATE)
(Regd. No. D/5425/2011) : G-2/70, Tulsī Tower,
Akananda Shopping Comp. New Delhi-110019
Mobile: 9810221449, 9310221449

PUBLIC NOTICE

My client Mr. Ramber Singh, S/o Sh. Hardev Prasad R/o B-86, Ram Park Colony, Lohari, Ghaziabad, U.P.-201102, severed all his relations with his wife Asha, and two sons Vineet @ Joni and Nitin @ Toni and their wives and children due to their mutual misbehaviour, tortuous and illegal acts and due to disobedient. My client declare that from his all movable and immovable properties. My client shall not be responsible for any act & deeds, anyone who will deal so, with them in any manner, shall do at their own risk, costs and consequences of them, in future.

Manish Kumar (Advocate) Delhi High Court,
Court, Ch. No. 735-L, F.F. Western Wing, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi-110005

PUBLIC NOTICE

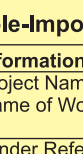
Whereas, M/s Seagull Buildwell Pvt. Ltd. is undertaking development of an Industrial Plotted Colony namely "NRI MURTHAL INDUSTRIAL TOWNSHIP" in Village Bhigan, Tehsil Ganaur, District Sonapat, Haryana over an area measuring 32.95 acres under the terms and conditions of Licence number 119 of 2025 dated 11.07.2025 granted by Office of Director, Town & Country Planning, Haryana (in short "DTCP").

Whereas, M/s Seagull Buildwell Pvt. Ltd. has been granted the RERA Registration of the project over area measuring 32.95 Acres vide Registration No. HRERA-PKL-SNP-884-2026 dated 09.04.2026 from the Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority, Panchkula (in short "Hon'ble Authority").

Whereas the Build'well Authority has directed the firm to publish the bank account details of the project for perusal/reference of the Allottees/General Public. The Company hereby declares the following bank accounts of the project "NRI Murthal Industrial Township".

HEAD OF BANK ACCOUNT	ACCOUNT NUMBER
100% Collection Account	50200119045883
70% Escrow Account	50200119045860
30% Free Account	50200119045818
Bank Name: HDFC Bank Ltd. IFSC: HDFC0001349	

Authorized Signatory
For: M/s **Seagull Buildwell Pvt. Ltd.**
Village Bhigan, Tehsil Ganaur, District Sonapat.



DELHI TRANSPORT CORPORATION

(A GOVT OF NCT OF DELHI)

I.P. ESTATE: NEW DELHI

NIT

Table-Important Information / Time schedule of Bid

#	Information	Details
1.	Project Name/ Name of Work	Engagement of Life Insurance Company for "DTC Group Insurance Policy in lieu of Employee Deposit Linked Insurance (EDLI)".
2.	Tender Reference No.	Admn/2026/166F
3.	Ministry/Division	Delhi Transport Corporation, Government of NCT of Delhi
4.	Procuring Entity and Agency Name	Delhi Transport Corporation, Administration Department, IP Estate, New Delhi-110002
5.	Procurement Method	Open e-tender
6.	Mode of Tendering	e-tender through GeM portal of GNCTD at (https://gem.gov.in/)
7.	EMD Amount	Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) is being waived off, subject to the Bidder submitting the Declaration.
8.	Last Date & Time for submission of bids	09.05.2026 upto 16:00hrs. on GeM portal of GNCTD at (https://gem.gov.in/)
9.	Date, Time & Venue for opening of Technical bid	09.05.2026 at 16:30 hrs. at Tender Cell, Room No. 207, Delhi Transport Corporation, Headquarters, IP Estate, New Delhi -110002.
10.	Date, Time & Venue for opening of Financial Bid	Technically qualified Bidders/Life Insurance Company will be intimated subsequently.
11.	Contact details	Dy.CGM (Admn.), Room No. 205, Delhi Transport Corporation, Head Quarters, IP Estate, New Delhi - 110002 E-mail id: managara@dtc.nic.in, dtcadmn@gmail.com Tel. No. 011-23370236 Ext-244, 8744073059

Special Instruction:

- All the pages of the bid/response should be numbered and signed & stamped by the authorized signatory.
- Total number of pages should be indicated in the covering letter (Format-1).
- The above schedule is subject to change. Notice of any changes will be uploaded on e-procurement, GNCTD & DTC's Official Website.

Manager (Admin)

Two Chinese ex-ministers sentenced to death

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Beijing

Two former Chinese defence ministers, Wei Fenghe and Li Shangfu, were sentenced to death with a two-year reprieve over graft charges by a military court on Thursday, in an unprecedented purge at the top of the People's Liberation Army (PLA).

Their sentences were separately handed down by the military court.

Both Wei and Li were also former members of the powerful Central Military Commission (CMC), headed by President Xi Jinping, and former State councillors, a high-ranking designation of the ruling Communist Party of China (CPC). Wei, 72, was



Ex-Defence ministers Li Shangfu and (right) his predecessor Wei Fenghe.

convicted of accepting bribes, while Li, 68, was convicted of both accepting and offering bribes, the state-run *Xinhua* news agency reported, citing the court rulings. In China, death penalties with reprieve are

typically commuted to life sentences.

Both Wei and Li headed the powerful Rocket (missile) Force, established in 2015 as part of Xi's military overhaul. Gen Wei, who headed the rocket force from its

inception until 2017 and later served as the defence minister from 2018 to 2023, was detained and expelled from the ruling Communist Party of China (CPC) over corruption charges.

The Rocket Force operates China's most powerful long and short-range missiles and is regarded as significant, as it is the key military arm of the PLA.

They were stripped of their political rights for life, and all of their personal properties will be confiscated.

The court rulings said that no further commutation or parole will be allowed after their penalties are commuted to life imprisonment in accordance with the law upon the expiration of the

two-year reprieve period. Under the current political order in China, officials convicted of corruption have at times received death sentences, though these were seldom carried out because the judgments typically included a two-year reprieve.

The reprieve provision allowed the accused to confess their crimes and cooperate with investigators. Ever since Xi took over power in 2012, he has carried out major purges of officials and the military.

Over two million officials were reported to have been punished for corruption.

The periodic purges were reportedly aimed at instilling fear and obedience in the rank and file. In a shocking

move in January, Gen Zhang Youxia, the highest ranking official of the PLA, along with senior General Liu Zhenli were placed under investigation for serious violation of discipline of the CPC and laws. Zhang is the first Vice Chairman of the CMC — the highest-ranking uniformed officer in the Chinese military.

Besides corruption, which is the main allegation against the sacked military officials, indiscipline and disobedience of the CPC leadership were stated to be the reasons for the action against them. Since he came to power in 2012, Xi has been insisting that the military should function under the leadership of the CPC.

Paraguay's President lands in Taiwan amid China tensions



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Taipei

Paraguay's President Santiago Pena arrived in Taiwan on Thursday on his first visit to the self-ruled island that Beijing claims as its own territory. Paraguay is the last country in South America and one of 12 worldwide to recognize Taiwan. China, which has not ruled out force in annexing Taiwan, has been ramping up a campaign over the past few years to lure Taiwan's diplomatic allies.

Paraguay maintains a solid trade relationship with China but has nevertheless reaffirmed its commitment to Taipei as its diplomatic partner. Pena is leading a business delegation from areas such as agriculture and finance to Taiwan from Thursday until

Sunday, according to Taiwan's Foreign Ministry. Taiwanese President Lai Ching-te is set to welcome Pena with military honors on Friday. The visit comes as Beijing has been increasing pressure on the island democracy, including sending warplanes and navy vessels toward the island on a near-daily basis.

Taiwan, meanwhile, has sought to assert its presence internationally. Last week, Lai visited the southern African nation of Eswatini, Taipei's last remaining diplomatic partner in Africa, after being forced to postpone the trip when several countries withdrew permission for him to fly over their territories reportedly over Chinese pressure.

Russian air defences shot down 347 Ukrainian drones

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Kyiv

Russian air defences shot down 347 Ukrainian drones overnight, Russia's Defence Ministry said on Thursday, in what appeared to be a major attack after Moscow spurned Kyiv's ceasefire earlier in the week and tension mounted over safety at Russia's upcoming Victory Day celebrations.

Incoming drones were destroyed over 20 Russian regions, including Moscow, according to the Defence Ministry, in Ukraine's second-biggest aerial attack since Russia's all-out invasion more than four years ago. The largest was last March when it launched 389 drones. The attack came



ahead of Russia's most important secular holiday, Victory Day, which marks the anniversary of the defeat of Nazi Germany in World War II. Russian authorities have declared a unilateral ceasefire in Ukraine for Friday and Saturday.

Ukraine had responded to

that with its own suspension of hostilities from midnight Tuesday. But Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Moscow disregarded the goodwill gesture and launched fresh attacks. "Russia has not stopped any type of its military activ-

ity. Unfortunately, it has not stopped. Ukraine will act symmetrically," Zelenskyy said in his regular evening video address Wednesday.

He said Thursday on X that Russia's attacks have been ceaseless, with drones, missiles, artillery shelling and glide bombs hitting civilian areas of Ukraine, including the power grid and rail network.

In the northeastern city of Kharkiv, Ukraine's second-largest, a drone strike wounded nine people, including three children, local officials said.

Tension has grown as Russia's Victory Day celebrations approach and US-led peace efforts gain no traction. All mobile internet

access and text messaging services will be shut down in the Russian capital on May 9, state media reported Thursday, citing the country's Ministry of Digital Development, Communications and Mass Media. Also, a traditional parade in Moscow won't feature the usual tanks, missiles and other military equipment for the first time in nearly two decades.

Russian authorities say they are concerned about possible Ukrainian attacks, as Kyiv has expanded its long-range drone and missile capabilities. The Russian Defence Ministry cited the "current operational situation" as a reason for excluding military equipment.

Nigerian Army rescues kids abducted from an orphanage last month



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Abuja

Seven children and two women abducted by gunmen at an orphanage last month in the north-central region of Nigeria have been rescued by troops, the country's army said.

Authorities in Kogi state said gunmen attacked an Islamic orphanage that was operating illegally and abducted 23 pupils in an "isolated area" of Lokoja, capital of Kogi State, on April 26. Fifteen of those abducted were immediately rescued.

The troops intercepted and recovered the victims within a forest area in the state, army spokesman Hassan Abdullahi said in a statement.

Flights carrying women linked to IS group land in Australia



ROD MCGUIRK ■ Melbourne

Airliners carrying Australian women and children with alleged ties to the Islamic State group landed in Australia on Thursday.

A plane reportedly carrying three Australian women and eight children landed in Melbourne, while a separate plane carrying a woman and her son arrived in Sydney

soon after. The Australian Government announced on Wednesday that the 13, who have spent years in a Syrian desert camp, planned to return to Australia.

Police said the women face potential criminal charges relating to their alleged time in the Islamic State group's so-called caliphate that spanned Syria and Iraq.

(AP)

China signals Taiwan priority again ahead of President Trump-Xi meeting

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Beijing

China again signaled that Taiwan would be a priority topic ahead of a highly anticipated summit between US President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping next week, saying that the US must adhere to the "one China principle" for a stable relationship with Beijing. China



claims Taiwan as its own territory and has not excluded the use of force to take it. Beijing has been ramping up its military pressure by sending warplanes and naval vessels around the island almost daily. "The Taiwan question is at the core of China's core interests and the bedrock of the political foundation of China-U.S. relations," said Foreign Ministry

spokesman Lin Jian Thursday. "Abiding by the One China principle and the three China-US joint communiques and honouring the commitments made by US administrations on the Taiwan question, is the due international obligation of the United States and the prerequisite for a steady, sound, and sustainable China-US relationship," he added.

Mount Everest season starts late despite ice hazard, high travel costs



Mountaineer walking at Khumbu Icefall of Mount Everest in Nepal

AP

BINAJ GURUBACHARYA
■ Kathmandu

An unstable ice block dangerously hanging over the key trail on Mount Everest, high travel costs and increased permit fees haven't deterred hundreds of climbers from attempting to scale the world's highest mountain.

Around 410 climbers and an equal number of their Nepali climbing guides are at the base camp gearing up for the ascent to the nearly 8,850-meter-high peak this month during the much anticipated window of good weather on the mountain.

Climbers began gathering last month at the base camp, which is at an altitude of 5,300 meters. But for more than two weeks, a massive and unstable block of ice, or serac, stalled them from moving further up the peak.

"Icefall doctors," the elite guides deployed by the Sagarmatha Pollution Control Committee, or SPCC, to lay the yearly climbing route by setting ropes and securing aluminum ladders over crevasses, usually finish the task by mid-April. But not this year.

The team opened the icefall route only on April 29 but also issued a warning: "The serac has multiple cracks and may collapse at

any time. SPCC strongly urges all expedition operators and climbers to exercise extreme caution." The serac was likely to remain, and the new trail dug by the team passes below the serac. The serac is part of the Khumbu Icefall, a constantly shifting glacier with deep crevasses and huge overhanging ice that can be as big as 10-story buildings. It's considered one of the most difficult and trickiest sections of the climb to the peak.

Climbers, their guides and expedition outfitters are both eager and cautious about the situation on the mountain. Renowned mountain guide Lukas Furtenbach, who has 40 international climbers, 11 guides and 90 Sherpas on Mount Everest, said that he was worried. "Anyone who says they're not concerned is either inexperienced or not paying attention," Furtenbach said from the base camp.

(AP)

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, KM Preeti W/o Vipin Kumar R/o Flat No.-104, First Floor, Tower G-3, Bharat City, Phase-II, Loni, Ghaziabad, U.P.-201002 declare that My Education records of B.A. from IGNOU, My name is mention Preeti which is wrongly mentioned, but my true and correct name is KM Preeti according to my Aadhar Card (252468218464), Pan Card, 10th and 12th and M.A. education records. In future known as me KM Preeti for all purposes.

This is to inform the general public that Mr. Jatin as Proprietor of M/S Dahiya Developers and Mr. Pawan Shokeen as proprietor of M/S Best Home Developers had acquired the Property Bearing No. 409-C, area measuring 300 Sq. Yds., out of Kharsa No. 322min, Situated within abadi Lal Dora (1908-09) of Village Neb Sarai, Tehsil - Saket (M.B. Road), South Delhi, New Delhi Vide Notarized GFA, ATS & will dated 18.02.2026 executed by Mr. Anand Singh in favour of Mr. Jatin as Proprietor of M/S Dahiya Developers and Mr. Pawan Shokeen as proprietor of M/S Best Home Developers.

Mr. Jatin as Proprietor of M/S Dahiya Developers and Mr. Pawan Shokeen as proprietor of M/S Best Home Developers intend to transfer the ownership of Flat No. 1 on Upper Ground floor, Front side, without roof rights, area measuring 80 Sq. Yds., (Isaid floor/Portion), Property Bearing No. 409-C, area measuring 300 Sq. Yds., out of Kharsa No. 322min, Situated within abadi Lal Dora (1908-09) of Village Neb Sarai, Tehsil - Saket (M.B. Road), South Delhi, New Delhi, by way of Sale Deed to Mr. Laxmi Kant and Mrs. Monika Subsequently Mr. Laxmi Kant and Mrs. Monika are in the process of mortgaging the said floor with SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 7 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 7-day period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.

If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 7-day period by contacting Law Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-105, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201302. Landline: +91012-40499711, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

Deputy Collector/ 1/C City Magistrate/ Marriage Officer Noida Gautam Budh Nagar

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Banks must prepare for threats by AI tools like Mythos: Nagaraju

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

DFS Secretary M Nagaraju on Thursday urged banks to strengthen their cyber security and operational resilience, cautioning that advanced artificial intelligence models such as Anthropic Mythos could pose significant risks to the banking system if released publicly. “I hope the banking community is prepared well to face in case Mythos is released publicly in the country,” Nagaraju said, while addressing at the Indian Banks’ Association (IBA) conference on Risk Management in Mumbai. Referring to concerns, he said Anthropic Mythos AI model has advanced capabilities



ties to identify and potentially exploit systems, and added that it has raised alarm bells among regulators because of the vulnerabilities in legacy banking technology systems. Nagaraju said banks and financial institutions remain highly vulnerable because of their interconnected systems, dependence on legacy IT infrastructure and real-time operations. “One successful cyber

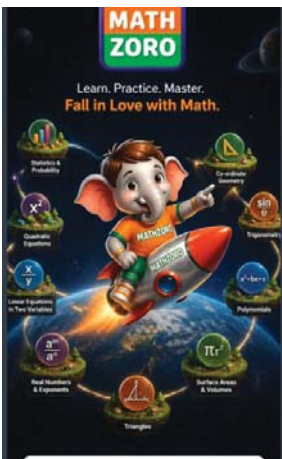
attack can cascade quickly across institutions and markets,” he warned. Nagaraju said banks must continuously test their resilience, strengthen incident response mechanisms, invest in cyber capabilities and ensure that business continuity plans are practical, updated and regularly exercised. Highlighting the broader risk, he said risks are no longer

confined to trade books or balance sheets and now arise from geopolitical developments, cyber threats, operational disruptions, fraud, third-party dependencies, climate considerations, market volatility and changing customer behaviour. “In such an environment, risk management cannot be seen merely as an add-on to compliance or control functions, it must be viewed as a strategic capability,” he said. Nagaraju noted that the Indian banking sector has made significant progress in recent years with stronger balance sheets, improved asset quality, robust capital positions and enhanced governance standards.

AICTE-backed Anuvadini AI ties up with learning platform MathZoro

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a move aimed at making mathematics learning easier and more accessible for school students across linguistic backgrounds, Anuvadini AI has entered into a partnership with game-based learning platform MathZoro to deliver multilingual mathematics education for Classes 6 to 10. The collaboration was announced at the AICTE headquarters in New Delhi by Dr Buddha Chandrasekhar, Chief Executive Officer of Anuvadini AI and Chief Coordination Officer at AICTE, Ministry of Education. The partnership seeks to remove one of the biggest barriers faced by students in understanding mathematics. Dr Buddha Chandrasekhar said the initiative is designed to ensure that a child’s learning does not suffer because classroom content or digital material is not available in the language the student understands best. He said Anuvadini AI was built to make knowledge accessible across regions and social backgrounds, and the MathZoro collaboration is a practical extension of that mission. Anuvadini AI functions under the aegis of the All India Council for Technical Education and the Ministry of Education as a Section 8 company. It is a multilingual technology platform capable



of delivering content in 22 scheduled Indian languages and 89 foreign languages. Officials said the platform has already translated more than 700 NCERT books and 721 NIMI skill development books, besides processing over 150 crore pages through its translation engine and more than 2,000 hours of multilingual video content. MathZoro, founded by Ramadevu Ramkumar, is a mathematics learning application built around a game model for students from Classes 6 to 10. Instead of textbook-style teaching, the platform uses thematic learning zones such as Algebra, Geometry, Trigonometry, and Probability to help students understand concepts through quizzes, rewards, interactive tasks, and visual progress journeys.

Under the new tie-up, the entire MathZoro application will now be delivered through Anuvadini AI’s live translation system. This means every instruction, question, reward notification, quiz line, and game element inside the app can appear instantly in the student’s chosen language without needing separate versions of the platform. Officials said a student in any state will be able to access the same mathematics content in his or her native language in real time. The partnership also includes a second academic layer beyond school mathematics. Students who use MathZoro up to Class 10 will later be connected to Anuvadini Pariksha, an AI-based multilingual examination preparation platform that supports competitive and board examinations, including JEE, NEET, CBSE, ICSE, and state board tests. The aim is to provide continuity in learning so that students do not face a sudden language shift when moving from school mathematics to competitive preparation. Another major part of the collaboration is multilingual assessment generation. Anuvadini AI’s Question Paper Creator will be integrated into MathZoro to automatically generate chapter-wise tests, board-style practice papers, and adaptive assessments in multiple languages.

Project Vartak, BRO celebrates 66th Raising Day with pride, dedication

TONY DAS
■ Tezpur

Border Roads Organisation (BRO) Project VARTAK celebrated its 66th Raising Day with great pride and enthusiasm on May 7, 2026 at Tezpur, Assam, commemorating more than six decades of dedicated service towards nation-building and strategic infrastructure development in the North Eastern Region of India.

Originally raised as Project Tusker on May 7, 1960, Project VARTAK holds the distinction of being the first project of BRO to commence road construction activities in the country. In 1963, following the Indianisation of project names, it was rechristened as Project VARTAK.

Since its inception, the Project has remained at the forefront of providing vital connectivity in some of the most challenging and strategically sensitive regions of the nation. During 1964-65, the Project successfully undertook the formidable task of improving the Bhalukpong-Tenga-Tawang axis, including formation cutting works connecting Bomdila with Sela and surfacing works from Bhalukpong to Rupa. These challenging tasks were executed under extremely adverse terrain and weather conditions by the dedicated person-



nel of 14 Border Roads Task Force.

At present, Project VARTAK operates through its Task Forces located at Tenga, Sapper Camp and Khirmu. The Project is entrusted with the construction, development and maintenance of strategically important roads in Sonitpur District of Assam and West Kameng and Tawang Districts of Arunachal Pradesh, extending up to the international border.

Project VARTAK is presently responsible for approximately 2066.90 km of road network, including significant stretches in high-altitude and snow-bound regions. The Project maintains strategically important passes and locations including Womingla, Bumla, Yangtse, Nagula, Y Junction, Klemta, Lungro GG, Monkey Pass, Lungar, Dhaula and Assam Hill. Regular snow clearance and restoration works are carried out to ensure year-round operational connectivity for both civilian and defence requirements.

From inclusion to impact: How ITC’s skilling programme for differently-abled is unlocking potential

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



Kavali Jyothi, a 33-year-old woman with 65 per cent locomotor disability from Anantapur, Andhra Pradesh, faced severe social and financial challenges with limited exposure to employment opportunities due to her mobility constraints. Today, she works as a Customer Support Associate at Kempegowda International Airport, earning ₹16,000 per month. She now supports her family and lives with greater confidence and independence, becoming a role model in her community. Jyothi’s story is not an isolated.

Across India, many such journeys of resilience and transformation are taking shape. In Pune, Jayram Ramesh Sonune, from Shikrapur village in Pune district with 40 per cent visual impairment has received employment at the Pune Airport after being equipped with computer proficiency, communication, and workplace readiness skills. He earns ₹25,000 per month, supporting his family’s household needs, easing agricultural income pressures, and beginning to build personal savings and assets. Sunil Kumar, a youth from Barabanki, Uttar Pradesh, with 90 per cent locomotor disability, now works as an Accountant earning ₹15,000 per month. In less than four years, over 2,370 differently abled young people have already been trained, with women making up over 30 per cent of participants.

Having started in January 2023 in Bengaluru, today, ITC’s focused programme to skill the specially-abled operates across five cities (Bangalore, Mysuru, Lucknow, Howrah and Bhubaneswar) through eight centres in partnership with specialised implementation organisations - Youth4Jobs, Anudip, Cheshire Disability Trust, Science & Technology Park, Sarthak, and Dr Reddy’s Foundation. Another unique initiative by ITC is the Mangaldeep Sixth Sense programme designed for the visually challenged to train them on fragrance evaluation by honing superior olfactory abilities. Prabhakar Lingareddy, Executive Vice President and Head - Social Investments, ITC Limited, said “At its core, our programme is about nurturing dignity and self-belief among the specially-abled, enabling individuals to see themselves as contributors to their families and society at large.”

Anil Ambani files defamation against NDTV, says Adani keen in his companies



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Thursday issued notice to NDTV and its CEO and editor-in-chief Rahul Kanwal after industrialist Anil Ambani sued the media house for defamation over its reporting of the CBI and ED cases against his companies. Ambani told the High Court that the Adani Group, the majority shareholder of NDTV, wants to take over his companies, and that the news channel has published 72 pointed articles against him in the last few months to facilitate its ultimate owners’ “predatory strategies”. Ambani’s counsel said that the investigating agencies have filed cases against Reliance, but every time a person is arrested, NDTV names Anil Ambani, Justice Subramoniam Prasad directed NDTV to respond to Ambani’s plea for interim injunction against the publi-

cation of the allegedly defamatory news reports and listed the matter for further proceedings in July.

He has sought over ₹2 crores in damages. The damages, Ambani said, will be donated to charity. Anil Ambani also filed defamation case against Arnab Goswami and Republic TV.

Apart from NDTV and Rahul Kanwal, Ambani has named IANS (the wire service also owned by the Adani Group), Manoranjan Bharti (NDTV Managing Editor), Tamanna Inamdar (NDTV Profit Managing Editor) and Ashish Manchanda (IANS Editor) as defendants in his suit. Ambani has argued that NDTV is trying to cause panic in the markets, adversely influence public perception of Reliance Power and Reliance Infrastructure, and manipulate market sentiment to serve the Adani Group’s vested interests.

“The Plaintiff states that the ultimate owners of

Defendant Nos. 1 - 3 [NDTV, NDTV Convergence and IANS] have launched a deliberate, targeted, and relentless smear campaign against the Plaintiff, so as to derive unjust gains by injuring the Plaintiff’s reputation, goodwill, and well-being, as well as the reputation and goodwill of the Reliance ADA Group,” the suit states.

“There have been 72 pointed publications against me. Every time a person is arrested... I am distinct from the entity [Reliance], and the persons being arrested belong to that entity,” argued Ambani’s advocate.

Justice Prasad said that the matter involves Article 19 (freedom of speech) rights and, therefore, he will issue notice to the media house before considering the plea for interim injunction. “Article 19(1)(a)... I have passed orders like that [injunction], but not on the first date. I have had at least 8 hearings,” the judge said.

Vietnam lays thrust on innovation, urban connectivity and megacity governance with India: Nguyen Loc Ha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

MVIRDC World Trade Center Mumbai, in association with the All India Association of Industries, organized a high-level Roundtable Meeting with a delegation from Ho Chi Minh City, Vietnam. The roundtable served as a viable platform to reinforce bilateral cooperation between India and Vietnam across new and modern sectors such as innovation, digital transformation, urban infrastructure, sustainability, tourism, logistics, and smart city development.

Adv. Ashish Jaiswal, Minister of State, Government of Maharashtra and MLA, Ramtek Constituency, stated, “Maharashtra welcomes Vietnam with open arms and invites Vietnamese enterprises to invest, establish businesses, and grow with us. We are committed to elevating this partnership to the next level and are keen to develop dedicated infrastructure, specialized IT parks, and advanced data center ecosystems for Vietnamese companies in Maharashtra. Such collaborations will further strengthen investment, innovation, and technology-led growth, contributing significantly to the vision of a Viksit Maharashtra and the state’s aspiration of becoming a USD 1 trillion economy by 2027.”

“Maharashtra’s strength lies in its unmatched infrastructure comprising railways, airports, roadways, and seamless logistics connectivity, making it one of the most attractive investment destinations in India.



Sangeeta Jain felicitating Mr. Nguyen Loc Ha. Also seen are Adv. Ashish Jaiswal (1st from left); Dr. Vijay Kalandi (2nd from left); Capt. Somesh Batra (2nd from right); and Priya Pansare (1st from right) during the high-level roundtable with the Vietnam delegation at World Trade Center Mumbai.

Emerging sectors such as green hydrogen, electronics, bamboo-based industries, and steel manufacturing are opening new opportunities for collaboration. Gadchiroli is emerging as a future steel hub, and Maharashtra is ready to build a more sustainable growth model together with Vietnam.” said Jaiswal. Nguyen Loc Ha, Standing Vice Chairman of the Ho Chi Minh City People’s Committee stated, “Ho Chi Minh City seeks to develop a long-term ecosystem for Indian investments, especially in research and development centers, digital technology projects, smart urban development models, green energy initiatives, commercial trade, and human resource development.”

“There are several areas where Ho Chi Minh City and Mumbai can strengthen collaboration, including trade and investment, digital transformation, creativity and innovation, high-technology development, logistics infrastructure, urban connectivity, megacity governance, smart transportation, sus-

tainable energy, waste management, healthcare, education, tourism, and disaster prevention,” added Ha.

Dr Vijay Kalandi, Chairman, World Trade Center Mumbai and President, All India Association of Industries, highlighted the growing potential of economic and multifaceted partnership between India and Vietnam and said, “The leaders of India and Vietnam welcomed the signing of the MoU on cooperation in tourism, paving the way for sustainable and inclusive growth in two-way tourism, including cultural and heritage tourism. Bilateral trade between the two nations has crossed USD 16 billion in FY 2025/26, with strong potential to achieve the USD 30 billion target by 2030 through enhanced cooperation in sectors such as data centers, information technology, artificial intelligence, textiles, and agro-processing. Maharashtra and Vietnam hold immense opportunities for collaboration in investment, manufacturing, Pharmaceuticals, IT and technology-driven

industries.” “We would also like to promote ‘Coffee Diplomacy’ between our two countries and invite Vietnam to establish its first Coffee Diplomacy Center at World Trade Center Mumbai as a symbol of cultural and business engagement. There is significant potential for the development of dedicated bilateral cooperation zones focused on human capital development, manufacturing, and information technology,” said Dr Kalandi.

Shashi Bala, Chief, Business Development, Brihan Mumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) said, “Mumbai and Ho Chi Minh City can collaborate substantially in heritage tourism and UNESCO Creative City initiatives. Mumbai, being the financial and entertainment capital of India, serves as a powerful gateway for cultural exchange, tourism collaboration, and creative economy partnerships.”

While proposing the vote of thanks, Capt. Somesh Batra, Vice Chairman, World Trade Center Mumbai, stated, “There exists strong complementarities between the Indian and Vietnamese economies. India’s robust services sector complements Vietnam’s manufacturing strengths, creating significant potential to expand bilateral trade from USD 16 billion to USD 30 billion in the coming years. As key economic regions, Mumbai and Ho Chi Minh City can deepen collaboration in logistics, smart infrastructure, transportation, and emerging technologies for long-term growth and development.”

DAILY SUDOKU

	2			9	4	5		
			2			6		
7						1	9	
	5				1			
9	7		2		1		8	5
			2				7	
5	1							4
	3			7				
	6	7	4					2

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (7.5.26)

1	2	8	5	6	3	4	9	7
5	7	3	9	2	4	8	1	6
6	4	9	7	8	1	3	5	2
8	3	4	6	9	2	5	7	1
9	6	1	4	7	5	2	8	3
7	5	2	1	3	8	9	6	4
3	1	6	8	4	9	7	2	5
4	8	5	2	1	7	6	3	9
2	9	7	3	5	6	1	4	8

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
FRIDAY | MAY 8, 2026

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
			9				
10							
				12			
13		14				15	16
17					18		
				19			
20	21					22	23
24					25		
			26				
27						28	
				29			
30						31	

ACROSS

1 Possibly grips a branch (5)
6 Wide boy out of order (5)
9 One vessel on which another may be stood (7)
10 It's brilliant, being like Alfred! (5)
11 Scottish proprietary line in cooking fat (5)
12 Copper maybe making a name with the police (5)
13 It's right for an amended clause to be non-religious (7)
15 Came down in flames? (3)
17 Poetry from the antipodes (4)
18 Clarify the chance of being fined a quarter of a Euro (6)

DOWN

2 Having said goodbye, depart in distress (6)
3 Classic high flier who got too hot (6)
4 Obtained leave at the end of August (3)
5 The attendant in the hall (5)
6 Behind schedule and in the red, we're told (7)
7 Like a test of morality? (4)
8 Limner turned wizard (6)
12 Officer of the crown (5)
13 It's down in the direction of "27 Across" (5)

19 Fought for love and a kiss in bed (5)
20 During some winters, everybody gets more grown-up (6)
22 Fully occupy Phil, say (4)
24 Property of Mephistopheles (3)
25 Mashed praties can be bad at sea (7)
26 It won't be denied its association with the cavalry (5)
27 You can get 509, that is, in a mess tin (5)
28 It precedes a removal (5)
29 Does it shed fresh light on astronomy? (3,4)
30 Bob from Sandy Lane (5)
31 A name for sham woollen fabric? (5)

14 Sources of electricity in prison? (5)
15 The bounds of fictorial imitation (5)
16 Possibly lets out to a pupil (5)
18 Lived up to a bad name (5)
19 Possibly bent around a little, to fit centrally (7)
21 How the aviator vents his views? (6)
22 Celebrity consuming some wine during a shortage (6)
23 Table vegetable containing gum (6)
25 Soft lump; could be cuddly (5)
26 Can one name her? (4)
28 A shock for the head! (3)

BRIEFLY

Man City clinches Women's Super League title



Manchester City clinched the Women's Super League title on Wednesday to end Chelsea's six-year dominance of the competition.

Third-place Arsenal's 1-1 draw with Brighton meant City, which has one match remaining, could not be caught in first place. City, which didn't qualify for this season's Women's Champions League, has been top of the standings since Nov. 9. Swedish coach Andree Jeglertz led City to the title in his first season at the club after joining from Denmark's national team. It is City's second WSL title, the other coming in 2016. City is six points ahead of second-place Chelsea, which also has one game left. Arsenal is 10 points behind City and has three games left.

(AP)

Hockey India unveils U-18 teams for Australia series



Hockey India on Thursday announced the 24-member Indian U-18 Men's and Women's squads for the upcoming home series against Australia from May 15 to 20.

The four-match series, to be played at SAI Bhopal, is a critical part of the teams' preparations for the Men's and Women's U-18 Asia Cup to be held at Kakamigahara, Japan, from May 29-June 6.

The squad members were selected after a week of rigorous evaluation during the national coaching camp, where the initial group of 42 players was narrowed down based on match fitness and tactical adaptability.

(PTI)

Relaxed Rory McIlroy says he is more motivated



Rory McIlroy appeared rested and relaxed as he prepared for his first tournament since repeating as Masters champion. Just don't let that be confused with complacency.

The world's No. 2-ranked player said he feels "more motivated" than ever heading into a major stretch that includes the PGA Championship next week outside of Philadelphia and the U.S. Open next month at Shinnecock Hills. First up though is this week's Truist Championship at Quail Hollow, where McIlroy earned his first PGA Tour victory 16 years ago and has won four times.

(AP)

Kvaratskhelia shines as PSG reach 2nd straight Champions League final

JEROME PUGMIRE ■ MUNICH

Whether scoring or creating, Khvicha Kvaratskhelia makes the difference for Paris Saint-Germain.

His team-leading 10 goals have played a huge part in helping titleholder PSG reach a second straight Champions League final.

His superb assist put PSG ahead early in a 1-1 draw at Bayern Munich on Wednesday for a 6-5 aggregate win against the six-time champions. That came after the 25-year-old Georgia star's two goals helped PSG win the first leg 5-4.

Kvaratskhelia was irrepresible in the semifinals, as he was against Monaco, Chelsea and Liverpool earlier in the Champions League campaign.



His awareness led to PSG's goal three minutes into the return leg and put Bayern on the back foot immediately, when many observers expected PSG to struggle

early on. Kvaratskhelia even started the move that led to PSG's goal.

Catching Bayern's midfield napping by dropping deep, he then released Fabian Ruiz with a

brilliant flick with the outside of his right foot.

He then spun around to collect Ruiz's excellent first-time pass before sprinting down the left and picking out Dembele with a fine pass across the penalty area. Dembele shot powerfully into the roof of the net for his seventh goal of the competition.

Bayern had some spells of possession but never recovered from the early blow and, at the end, Kvaratskhelia's boundless energy and runs almost led to another PSG goal.

"We have a magnificent team, a young team, we fight together," PSG president Nasser Al-Khelaifi said. "We have stars but everyone fights. Look at the last minute, Kvara is

cooked (but) kept fighting," Dembele was PSG's key player last season, and now it could be Kvaratskhelia's turn to shine when PSG faces Arsenal in the final on May 30.

"We're very happy, we know it will be very difficult against Arsenal," Kvaratskhelia said. "I'm working every day and getting back with assists or goals. I will do everything for the team."

Real Madrid won three straight times from 2016-18.

Seamless selection: PSG coach Luis Enrique has shown remarkable flexibility with his team selections, astutely coping with injuries and juggling positional changes without disrupting the efficiency of his team.

(AP)

Champions League winner Niklas Sule retires at 30 after injuries

JAMES ELLINGWORTH ■ Duesseldorf (Germany)

Champions League winner and five-time Bundesliga champion Niklas Sule has announced his retirement at the age of 30 after an injury scare led him to reconsider his future.

The Borussia Dortmund and Germany defender is leaving soccer at the end of the season, when his contract at the club was already due to expire.

"I'm very, very clear about my decision," Sule said on the Spielmacher podcast in an episode released Thursday. "Despite that, football has given me a huge amount and I had such a great, cool time that there's pain in saying this."

Sule has missed 22 games with various injuries this season and said a moment of clarity came after he hurt



his knee in a game against Hoffenheim last month.

Sule said he "cried for 10 minutes" in the showers after the club doctor examined his knee and shook his head, leaving Sule to fear he'd sustained a third career ACL tear, meaning months of recovery.

(AP)

Nottingham Forest takes a 1-0 lead to Aston Villa in Europa League semifinal

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Birmingham

Nottingham Forest makes a short trip to Birmingham with a 1-0 advantage against Aston Villa in the second leg of their Europa League semifinal on Thursday.

Both clubs hope to contest their first European final in decades.

For Nottingham, it has been 46 years. The relegation-threatened Premier League club won the European Cup, the precursor to the Champions League, under the great Brian Clough in 1979 and 1980.

Forest has been unbeaten in its last 10 games in all competitions but it remains unclear if key attacking midfielder Morgan Gibbs-White will play



after suffering a facial injury on Monday in a 3-1 win against Chelsea in the Premier League.

Villa, the European champion in 1982, has reached its second semifinal in Europe in three seasons. It sits fifth in the English top flight and stands a good chance of qualifying for the Champions League again after

As 2026 nears, India's distance from the World Cup persists



SHAKYA MITRA

India's relationship with the FIFA World Cup has always been one of fascination from afar rather than participation on the pitch. For several years, the tournament has captured the imagination of Indian audiences, even as the national team has remained absent from the grandest stage of global football. As the 2026 World Cup approaches, that paradox feels sharper than ever.

In a surprising twist, India is currently struggling to secure a broadcaster for the 2026 World Cup. This is particularly striking given that every edition of the tournament since 1982 has been televised in the country. Over the years, the World Cup became a staple of Indian sports consumption, drawing millions of viewers even as the host venue has gone from one continent to another. The key factor that is being attributed to the inability of finalising a broadcaster are the inconvenient timings of matches in North America. The broadcasters don't feel justified shelling out a substantial price, latest reports suggest that FIFA is asking for \$60 million which is close to the amount offered for the 2022 World Cup, while no broadcaster is offering more than \$20 million. Yet it is undeniable, that there are bigger issues at play which include the absence of a stronger overall domestic football ecosystem.

India's detachment from the World



India's detachment from the World Cup is not new. The national team has never played in the World Cup, withdrawing from the 1950 edition even before the tournament commenced



Cup is not new. The national team has never played in the World Cup, withdrawing from the 1950 edition even before the tournament commenced.

Yet that period from the 1950s to the early 60s were a golden era for Indian football as they emerged as a dominant force in Asia under the coaching of Syed Abdul Rahim. India won the gold medal in the 1951 Asian Games though the pinnacle came a decade later at the 1962 edition when they won the gold medal beating a formidable South Korean team in the final. This victory was not an isolated achievement but the culmination of years of growth. Earlier, at the 1956 Olympics in Melbourne, India had reached the semi-finals, a feat that remains one of the country's greatest football accomplishments. They narrowly missed out on a medal, losing in the bronze medal match, but their performance found huge respect

worldwide.

This golden generation, featuring players of exceptional skill and determination, briefly positioned India as a serious contender in Asian football. However, the momentum was not sustained. The story of this period was brought back into public consciousness through the 2024 film Maidaan, which highlighted Rahim's legacy and the team's achievements, reminding a new generation of what Indian football once was.

Historically, opportunities for Asian teams to participate in the World Cup were limited. In the earlier editions, only one team from Asia would be playing. Over time as the tournament

expansion includes first-time qualifiers like Jordan and Uzbekistan, alongside regular participants as well as Australia, who now compete in the Asian confederation having earlier played in Oceania. In theory, this broader access should improve India's chances. In practice, however, India still finds itself far from contention, highlighting the gap between potential and performance.

The widespread broadcast of the World Cup and European club football in India has provided a dilemma. On one hand, it has fuelled interest in the sport, exposing fans to the highest levels of skill, athleticism, and tactical mastery. On the other hand, it has starkly revealed the gulf

increased to 24 and subsequently 32 teams, this expanded to two, then four or five slots. The 2026 World Cup marks a significant shift, with nine Asian teams set to participate in the 48 team affair. This

between Indian football and the global game. The better marketed competitions like the English Premier League have been able to draw a considerable audience within the country. The Indian public has adored global superstars like Diego Maradona, Ronaldo, Cristiano Ronaldo and Lionel Messi in the years since football was broadcast in India. The World Cup, despite its global appeal, faces a relative disadvantage in India because the national team is not part of the narrative. Time zone challenges for the 2026 edition, which will be hosted in North America, may further impact viewership.

A flourishing national team and moreover the right intent from the administrators will be crucial towards sustaining the growth of Indian football on the field and fan following off it. Though one should not read too much too into the broadcast issues being faced in the upcoming World Cup as it could well be a time zone related problem, it is undeniable that Indian football needs to improve in all facets for its overall holistic growth.

The World Cup will definitely find its audience in India with or without a broadcaster as real football enthusiasts will still follow it passionately. However for the connection to deepen, India must have a long-term vision to qualify for the World Cup. Only then will the tournament truly feel like a stage where the country belongs.

Shakya Mitra is a sports management consultant with over a decade of experience in sports promotion and development. His work across both the private and government sectors gives him a well-rounded view of India's sports ecosystem.

Assam crowned Champions of the 2nd NE Little Masters Cricket Trophy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Agartala

Assam emerged champions of the 2nd North East Little Masters Cricket Trophy (Under-14) with a commanding 159-runs victory over Tripura in the final played at the MBB Stadium, Agartala, on Thursday. The tournament was hosted by the Tripura Cricket Association with the objective of promoting and strengthening grassroots cricket across the Northeast region.

After winning the toss, Tripura elected to field first. Assam produced a commanding batting performance to post an imposing total of 286/6 in their allotted 40 overs. Tanveer Islam led the charge with a magnificent 112 off 82 deliveries, while Binoy Krishna Debnath remained unbeaten on 64 from 54 balls. Kaustav Gogoi also made a valuable contribution with



26 runs off 34 deliveries.

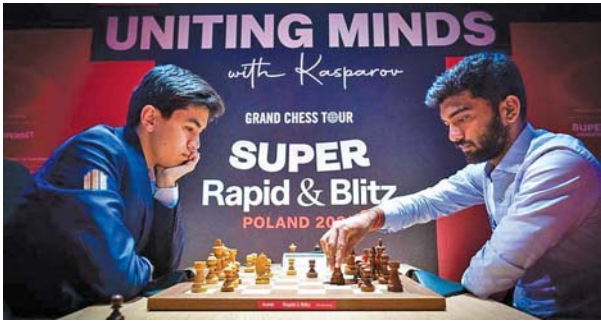
For Tripura, Udayan Paul was the pick of the bowlers with figures of 2/48, while Bihan Das and Bijoy Deb claimed one wicket each. In reply, Tripura were restricted to 127/7 in their allotted 40 overs. Udayan Paul top-scored with 53 off 109 balls, while Arnab Debbama and Sachin Hassen chipped in with 18 runs each.

Assam's bowlers delivered a disciplined and clinical performance, with Kunal Bezbaruah and Ayush Pandey picking up two wickets each. Priyam Kundu impressed with remarkable figures of 2/6, while Tanveer Islam also

contributed with the ball, claiming 1 wicket for 10 runs.

The closing ceremony was graced by Mr M Khairul Jamal Majumdar, Member, IPL Governing Council and Convener of the NE Little Masters Cricket Trophy; Mr Upananda Debbama, Acting President and Vice President, Tripura Cricket Association; Mr Romen Dutta, Vice President, Assam Cricket Association; Mr Subrata Dey, Secretary, Tripura Cricket Association; Mr Mukuta Nanda Bhattacharjya, Apex Council Member, Assam Cricket Association among other dignitaries.

Super Rapid, Blitz: Gukesh stays in hunt after Sindarov win, So draw



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Warsaw (Poland)

D Gukesh made quite an impact, signalling that his preparations for the World Championship are on track by first defeating his title challenger, Javokhir Sindarov, in the fifth round and then holding American Grandmaster Wesley So to a draw in the Super Rapid and Blitz event on the Grand Chess Tour.

After defeating Uzbekistan's Sindarov, Gukesh played out a quick draw with Wesley So to move to six points with three rounds still to go in the Rapid event. The win against Sindarov earned the Indian two points, while the draw fetched him one.

So is the joint leader on nine points alongside fellow American Hans Niemann. The duo is followed by Vladimir Fedoseev, who is a point behind, while Gukesh is tied on six points with Fabiano Caruana, Jan-Krzysztof Duda and Maxime Vachier-Lagrave as he looks to climb further up the standings in the

remaining rounds. Gukesh was in full flow as he matched Sindarov move for move in what was the first clash between the two ahead of their World Championship meeting in December.

Interestingly, both Gukesh and Sindarov entered the fifth round after defeats in their previous games. The Indian had gone down to Radosław Wojtaszek, while Sindarov lost to Wesley So. Playing with the black pieces, Gukesh opted for the Caro-Kann Defence, while Sindarov chose an unconventional setup. The opening soon led to a dynamic position, exactly the kind of game Gukesh likes.

The Indian then won a pawn, though white had sufficient compensation. In his attempt to press for more, Sindarov launched an attack that completely backfired.

The Uzbek Grandmaster had earlier played down the significance of the clash ahead of the World Championship, but his play suggested he was under considerable pressure against Gukesh.

Marsh powers LSG win over RCB by 9 runs

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

Mitchell Marsh slammed a superb 111 off 56 balls as bottom-placed Lucknow Super Giants snapped a six-match losing streak with a nine-run DLS victory over Royal Challengers Bengaluru in a rain-curtailed IPL match here on Thursday.

Sent in to bat, Marsh smashed nine fours and as many sixes, adding 95 off 56 balls with Arshin Kulkarni (17) and 70 off 41 balls with Nicholas Pooran (38) to single-handedly steer LSG to 209 for 3.

Skipper Rishabh Pant also made a quickfire 10-ball 32 not out.

With as many as three rain interruptions causing close to an hour's delay, the contest was eventually reduced to 19 overs per side.

Marsh (111 off 56 balls) put on a breathtaking display of power-hitting, first stitching



a 95-run opening stand with Arshin Kulkarni (17) to lay the platform for LSG's explosive start, before adding

another 70 runs with Nicholas Pooran (38). Skipper Rishabh Pant then blazed away to 32 not out off

10 deliveries to provide the final flourish.

The Australian opener looked ominous from the outset, unleashing a barrage of clean strikes all around the ground. His 56-ball knock was laced with nine fours and as many sixes, most of which came in the powerplay.

With LSG's playoff hopes hanging by a thread, Marsh came out all guns blazing after being asked to bat, taking apart the RCB attack with ruthless aggression.

Josh Hazlewood bore the brunt of the early carnage as Marsh launched two towering sixes straight over his head before following it up with three boundaries in the pacer's next over.

Marsh's attack forced RCB to introduce Rasikh Dar as early as the fifth over, but the move did little to stem the flow of runs.

The burly Australian continued his onslaught, hammering back-to-back sixes

before adding a boundary for good measure. He raced to his fastest IPL fifty, reaching the milestone in just 20 balls, and dominated the scoring as LSG raced to 95/0 in nine overs.

However, LSG's momentum was briefly disrupted by a 30-minute rain interruption, after which Krunal Pandya ended Kulkarni's scratchy stay at the crease.

New batter Pooran wasted no time as he crunched Rasikh for back-to-back boundaries, while Marsh brought up his century with consecutive fours before launching a thunderous six over cover point just as rain halted play for the third time.

Marsh was dropped by Devdutt Padikkal on 110 but could not make full use of the reprieve, eventually falling to Hazlewood at deep point.

With Marsh gone it was time for the Pant show as the captain smacked four fours and two sixes.

Bowling groups have to be detailed in IPL, says Franklin

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

Sunrisers Hyderabad assistant coach James Franklin said bowling groups should have deep understanding of batters' aggressive scoring methods in the IPL, leveraging his argument around Pat Cummins preying on Punjab Kings' opener Priyansh Arya's penchant for the pull shot.

SRH skipper Cummins bluffed Arya with a bouncer outside the off-stump, knowing the latter's preference to play the pull instead of an upper cut.

Arya fell for the trap, pulling Cummins into the hands of Eshan Malinga at deep square leg.

"Obviously Pat Cummins and (head coach) Dan (Vettori) are very detailed and I think you have to be detailed nowadays because of how powerful batting units are, particularly top threes, top fours of all the IPL teams and particularly in the power plays," Franklin said in the post-match press conference.

Cummins' spell of two for 34 had a big role in SRH's 33-run win over PBKS in their IPL



match here on Wednesday night. Franklin said the SRH bowling unit's pre-match feedback helped them devise plans for the marauding Punjab batters, who have been excellent in the chase so far in this IPL.

"I think sometimes you don't necessarily have to bowl the ball that the field is expecting and I think we saw the ball before that he bowled a pretty good bounce on the same sort of line and he obviously called the bluff a little bit, executed the same sort of delivery

and created the opportunity. "So, you know, where the strengths and weaknesses are of the opposition batters, obviously all our bowlers are well across it. So, that was the feedback that our bowling group got and obviously we used it a lot throughout Punjab innings," he added.

The former New Zealand all-rounder praised pacer Malinga for producing some fine spells, particularly at the death overs.

"I think he actually bowled pretty well for us at the back end of the competition and I think you roll forward another year he's had that experience of playing an IPL before. He feels part of it now so he's obviously come into this year's IPL and got performances early and obviously that gives you confidence as a player."

Women upset Korea to assure India's first medal



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Shanghai

India endured a mixed day at the Archery World Cup Stage 2 as the women's recurve team assured the country's first medal with a stunning semifinal win over record 10-time Olympics champions South Korea, but men suffered a disappointing opening-round exit against Bangladesh on Thursday.

The women's team of seasoned Deepika Kumari, Ankita Bhakat and teenager Kumkum Mohod defeated a new-look Korean side 5-1 in the semifinals to set up a gold medal clash against second seed China on Sunday. But there was embarrassment for the men's recurve team as veteran Tarundeep Rai, Dhiraj Bommadevara and Yashdeep Bhoghe failed to win a single set in a below-par 2-6 defeat to Bangladesh. However, the Indian women's team maintained composure throughout a demanding day in which they won three consecutive matches.

The fourth-seeded Indians started strongly in the semifinal, shooting four 10s from six arrows and dropping just two points to take the opening set with a superb 58. The Koreans looked unsettled and managed only 55 after shooting an 8.

Slipped slightly in the second set with an 8 but still managed to tie at 56-56 and move 3-1 ahead. Needing just two more points to seal the match, the Indians again shot 58 in the third set, while the Koreans faltered under pressure and managed 56, handing India a memorable straight-set victory.

But the win came against an inexperienced Korean line-up which was fielded as part of their preparations for the Asian Games in Japan, less than four months away. The Korean team featured two debutants in Lee Yunji and Oh Yejin, while reigning world champion Kang Chaeyoung was the only experienced archer in the side. Olympic champions An San and Lim Sihyeon, along with last year's Shanghai gold medalist Lee Gahyun, were absent.

Earlier, the Indian women trio showed resilience to recover from a slow start and beat Uzbekistan 6-2 (53-56, 57-54, 55-54, 55-51) in the opening round.

DC batters face stern Varun-Narine test

KUSHAN SARKAR
■ New Delhi

Unable to negotiate tricky batting tracks or defend big totals on belters, there seems no comfort even on home turf for Delhi Capitals when they take on Kolkata Knight Riders in a must-win IPL game here on Friday.

Delhi Capitals, currently in seventh position with eight points from 10 games, need to win all four of their remaining games to reach 16 points and sneak into the play-offs. The eighth-placed KKR need to win all five of their remaining matches to leapfrog to 17 points in order to remain relevant.

In this backdrop, what becomes important is the surface on which DC will play the game.

It is understood that to counter the threat of spin twins Sunil Narine and Varun Chakravarthy, DC is likely to opt for a batting belter and will be playing on Pitch Number 6, the track on which they scored 264 but failed to defend against Punjab Kings.

The reason for picking such a track is lack of faith in the batting line-up which was reduced to 9 for 6 on a slightly seaming



surface against the Royal Challengers Bengaluru.

On a slowish surface where the ball gripped, the DC batters failed to come to terms with Rashid Khan of Gujarat Titans, and Akeal Hosein and Noor Ahmed of the Chennai Super Kings.

Sunil (Economy Rate of 6.80) and Varun (Economy Rate 8.88) can make life miserable for the likes of Pathum Nissanka, Sameer Rizvi, and Karun Nair to name a few. Making things worse for Delhi is premier spinner Kuldeep Yadav (10 matches, 7

wickets at ER 10.36), who is going through his worst IPL season right now. In such a situation, the only escape route for a distinctly mediocre team with no apparent 'Plan B' is to play on a flat deck.

It would give the non-performing home batters a chance to pile up a big score. Later, the team would expect that Mitchell Starc and Lungi Ngidi, who suffered a concussion during the game against Punjab, would will seal the deal with the ball. The only advantage DC will have is that KKR's pain point is also its top order performance.

The two main batters at the top, skipper Ajinkya Rahane (205 runs at Strike Rate 131.42) and Angkrish Raghuvanshi (268 runs at 137.43) haven't been able to grab the initiative in most of the games. (PTI)

Adding variety to bowling is the only way ahead, says Krunal Pandya

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

Royal Challengers Bengaluru all-rounder Krunal Pandya said the insane hitting power of modern day batters in the IPL is forcing the bowlers to evolve rapidly and add more variety to their craft to stay competitive.

Pandya has been witnessing this transformation since 2016, and understands that the league has evolved into a high-intensity power driven spectacle.

"If you follow the IPL closely over the last 10 years, the striking ability of batters has changed drastically. Today, power-hitting is constantly evolving. The new-age batters

coming in have an insane ability to clear the ropes with ease," Pandya said on JioStar.

"So as a bowler, I have realised that you have to add variety to your bowling arsenal. You must stay one step ahead of the batter. That is how bowling bouncers and yorkers came into the process," added Pandya, who has so far taken nine wickets this season and has crossed the century wicket mark overall in the IPL.

Pandya, who had earlier played for Mumbai Indians and



Lucknow Super Giants, said he has managed to stay relevant in a competition tailor-made for batters, relying on bouncers despite being a spinner.

"It was not that I suddenly woke up one day and started bowling bouncers as a spinner. It was a very well thought out plan, understanding what a bouncer does psychologically to a batter."

"Being a batter myself helps me think like a batter. I always try to stay one step ahead of the batter in terms of thought process and then focus on how to execute my skill," he added.

The 35-year-old said bowling to quality batters like Heinrich Klaasen and Shreyas Iyer can be daunting but reading the situa-

tion and adapting to it helped him stay with them.

"My approach depends on the situation. Sometimes I need to attack, other times I need to choke the runs. My main thought is always about bowling the best possible delivery for that moment."

"Heinrich Klaasen loves taking on spinners. Against batters like him, the better balls you bowl, the more dot balls you create, and the higher your chances of forcing a mistake. You can't just keep attacking mindlessly. "Sometimes, when a dangerous batter is at the crease, you have to go for the wicket and take a risk. It all depends on the game situation," he added.

Pandya likely to play against RCB, will join squad later

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Skipper Hardik Pandya on Wednesday was not a part of a large first batch of Mumbai Indians players and support staff who travelled to Raipur but is expected to be fit for the next Indian Premier League game against RCB slated on Sunday.

With a five-day gap between their last game on May 4 against Lucknow Super Giants and their next game against Royal Challengers Bengaluru on May 10, the Mumbai Indians players and staff will make their way to Raipur in separate batches. Pandya missed MI's last game on Monday against LSG due to a back spasm.

However, his niggles are said to be a minor one and a team source said he was advised rest for the game against LSG. However he will be leading the team in their must-win encounter against the Rajat Patidar led side.



Pujara calls for 25-30 players dedicated to Tests

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

It is acceptable for a cricketer choosing to play only white-ball formats for India but 25-30 players, who are not a part of the Indian Premier League, should be earmarked for Test cricket on the basis of their domestic performances, said former player Cheteshwar Pujara on Wednesday.

Pujara said while he would urge all youngsters to give serious consideration to becoming all-format players for India, it is not imperative for the white-ball aspirants to learn skills for the red ball.

"I do agree that some of the white-ball players, especially the batters, are coming in a way where they haven't played enough red-ball cricket, but they don't need to," Pujara replied when asked if basics of red-ball were still the prerequisites of success in the IPL.



"If you are just looking for a player who wants to specialise in T20 format, or who wants to just play the white-ball cricket, do they really need to learn Test cricket?" Pujara, a JioHotstar CTV Hindi expert, told reporters during an inter-

action here on Wednesday.

"If they don't want to play all three formats, definitely not. The way cricket is moving forward, we will see players who are picking white-ball cricket and players who will pick red-ball cricket — that is how I see things going forward."

Australia players to stay for IPL despite Pak ODIs clash

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Melbourne

Cricket Australia on Thursday confirmed that its players, including skipper Pat Cummins, will be allowed to fulfil their IPL 2026 commitments, granting them exemption from the three-match ODI series against Pakistan which begins on May 30.

The league phase of the IPL concludes on May 24, while the tournament's final will be played on May 31. The Australian players are scheduled to arrive in Islamabad on May 23, overlapping with the IPL's business end. "Yes, we have received communication that the Australian players in our squad will stay back for the IPL," a source in the Sunrisers Hyderabad told PTI.



Apart from their captain Cummins, the SRH also have opener Travis Head in the squad. The Hyderabad side is currently leading the points table with 14 points, closing in on a playoff berth. Australia are scheduled to play three ODIs and as many T20Is against Bangladesh from June 9.